The Tyrant of Mystacor: Beginning of an Era

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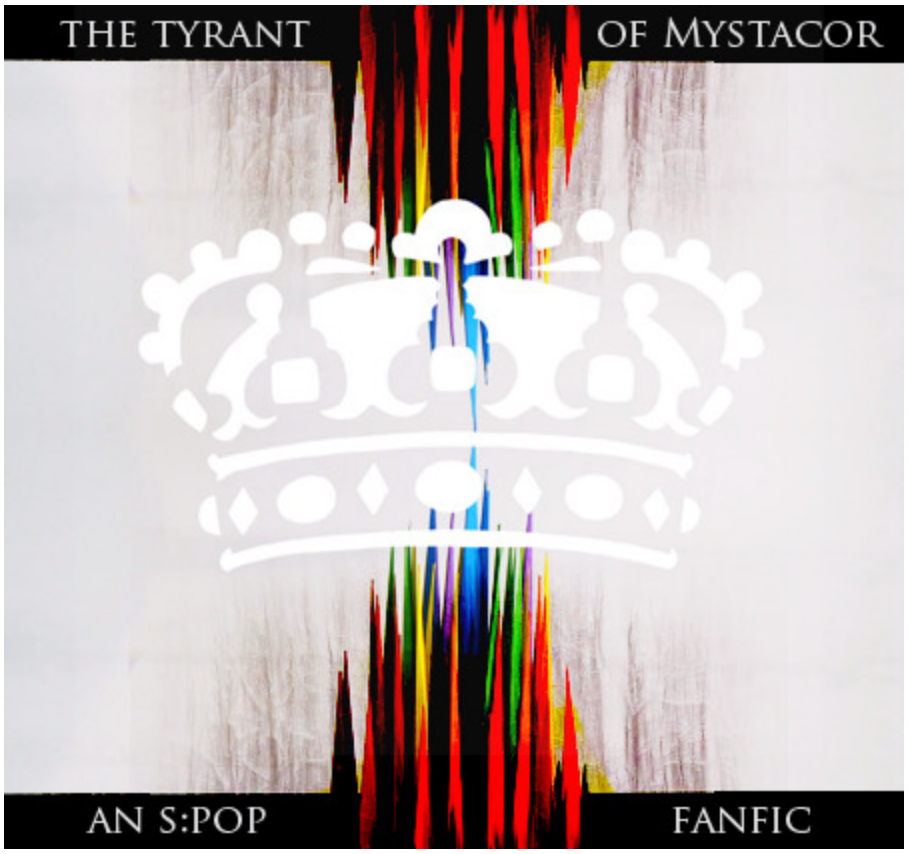
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The Tyrant of Mystacor: Beginning of an Era

by Xenakis (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

What if Light Spinner had never joined the Horde after her corruption? What if, true to her initial desire, she had instead used her new powers to fight them? What if, for that purpose, she had taken over Mystacor and the Sorcerers' Guild?
Shadow Weaver, the Tyrant of Mystacor; an uncanny ally to the Princess Alliance…
After years of ruling with terror, she could have never imagined what looking for fresh blood would result in: her newest asset, her most important one, she would change everything.
How could a single young sorceress shake the very foundations of the Tyrant's beliefs?
Shadow Weaver would never know…



Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

Welcome to another one of my fics!! ^_^

I have been wanting to finally post this for such a looooooooooong time! I'm so excited!

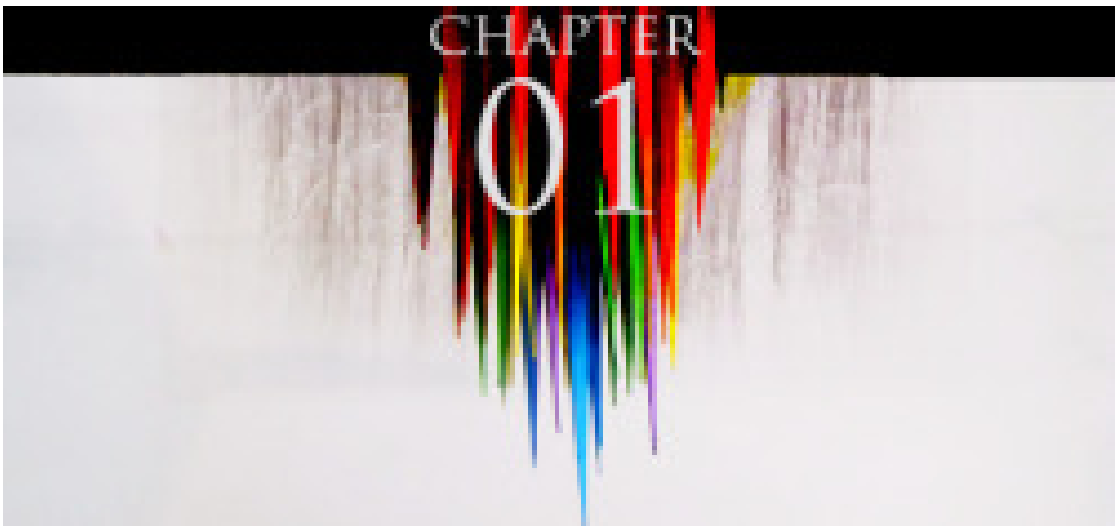
So, this fic has been completed thanks to the Wip Big Bang event I decided to join earlier this year, and is now being posted *almost* according to the schedule
~~I'm actually starting early cause of how many chapters this has~~

And well, this event includes getting art or a fanmix for the fic from the artist who claimed it, but ofc, as I'm starting early, there's nothing yet from that <("^_^)
But, hey! Not like there's any rush, right? I'll just update the notes and such later :D
Edit: the art is here! Cover and chapter headers :D

Just one important clarification: When this starts, **Casta only wears the blue dress and sleeves we see in the show, but not the cape, or the black lipstick, much less the crown** lol (all important details)

Anyways!!
Without further ado, I welcome you to this AU, and hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



It was another silent night for the siblings in the library of Mystacor.

Castaspella couldn't remember the last time she had been outside the large windowless room as Micah had kept her hidden there since she was merely a toddler. And later, when she was old enough to start learning magic, her classes were all there too.

She knew it was necessary; since her brother's tutor took power and became the tyrannic leader of Mystacor, no one was safe from Shadow Weaver's wrath, as she could hardly be pleased. Only some of her pupils had been somewhat safe since they were prone to obedience and, familiar with her behavior, had a better idea of what should be done and what should be avoided.

That way, Micah knew he could keep Castaspella hidden in the library, where Shadow Weaver was extremely unlikely to go, being so invested in taking the war to the Horde itself.

But Castaspella wasn't a kid anymore, not since she came of age…

—Come on, Micah, tell me— she insisted, as her brother tried to brush her off like he had been doing for a while now. —You said you'd tell me exactly what happened once I was mature enough. And, you said I'd be mature enough when I turned eighteen, but then it "wasn't a good time"!

—But it wasn't— he insisted, giving it little importance.

—Oh, come on! When will it be a good time!? I've been waiting for years now. Literally!

Micah took a deep breath and faced her.

He had to accept it, she was no longer a child; he had to tell her everything that went down so many years ago, lest she started to believe the rumors. In his eyes, however, she was still the little kid he first brought to the library, despite having grown more than he'd like to admit: she had learned to take care of herself, made her own clothes, like that blue dress she wears every day, and could cook for herself too; she was certainly independent. And, as a sorceress, she may not have that much talent for casting, but even *he* didn't know as much as she knows now, after more than a decade of reading everything available to her.

—Fine… let's begin then— he complied, taking a seat on a nearby desk, and inviting her to sit in front of him. —What do you know about what happened?

Castaspella took a moment to think before answering —I know that, when I was a kid, and you maybe teenager, erm… she was called different, something people haven't mentioned in years now, and she did some… forbidden spell which gave her powers. And she used those powers to take control of Mystacor.

Micah looked away, partially surprised, but mostly ashamed.

—That's…— he tried to answer, but felt unable to order his ideas. He cleared his throat before trying again. —I can tell you the full story, the details, and you can decide for yourself what to think, okay?

—Yes, please. That's all I want— she assured him.

—Alright— he sighed. —Her name was Light Spinner. Back then, she taught a lot of sorcerers here, but her pupils were just a few select ones, the best in Mystacor. And I was extremely eager to be one of them. I promised I'd do anything, and she only asked me to obey her every word. So I did. When I had to keep a secret, I would; when I had to steal crystals for her experiments with spells, I would; and when I had to help her perfect a forbidden spell… *I did*.

—That spell…

—It's called Spell of Obtainment. It was forbidden because it reaches for some powerful parasitic magic in the core of Etheria… it's a terrible power that feeds on magical energy and corrupts the user— Micah explained. —She thought she could enhance the spell to actually control that power, and I… I really believed in her vision, her plan. She showed me what the Horde was doing and she was so sure that power would let us fight them…

—Isn't that what she is doing now?

—I suppose but… things are very different from what she had told me she wanted to do— Micah continued. —Back then, the Sorcerers' Guild was ruled by the Head Sorcerer, Norwyn at the time, and Light Spinner tried to take her idea to the council, but they rejected her. And…—, he took another deep breath, closed his eyes, and sighed slowly, —And I was still so convinced she was right that I fully supported her and decided to help her carry out the spell without permission.

Castaspella's eyes widened.

—You… I had no idea… you were there? I-I was told everyone in the Lunarium had… died.

—No, no. Of course not— he quickly corrected her. —Two acolytes arrived with Norwyn and were simply knocked out. And I… She spared me— he told her, seemingly ashamed. —Look, when the spell began, everything was going fine but then… then it just became scary, it grew stronger and it was obvious how dangerous it still was— he began, his eyes fixed somewhere in the distance as he remembered. —I realized nothing could control it and tried to escape. I wanted to get help because I could barely break free from that dark magic, and she was completely surrounded. But- Ah…— he interrupted himself with a sigh; once again he seemed ashamed, perhaps of having fled. —Norwyn and those acolytes I mentioned showed up and didn't hesitate to try and stop her. But it was late, she surrendered to the dark magic as soon as I tried to leave; she fully embraced that power, her body was instantly corrupted, and that magic… Well, she certainly got what she was looking for, she was more powerful than Norwyn and consumed him, or-or sent him to some other dimension, I-I don't know— he continued, looking away and holding his head between his hands. —She had first knocked out the acolytes with a move of her hand, then did *that* to Norwyn, and finally… she just… cupped my face as I looked at her with terror.

He couldn't see it, but Castaspella's expression went from surprised to pained.

—So, she didn't hurt you?

—At all. She only caressed my cheek once, then left the Lunarium, and… completely submitted Mystacor to her rule in, what? Minutes?

—Just like that!?

—Yes. I left the Lunarium once I was out of my shock and she was literally announcing her control over the place and the Guild— he replied, looking back at her with a severe expression. —Before nightfall, some of the other kingdoms' rulers showed up, they wanted answers, but all they got was Shadow Weaver introducing herself with that name, and claiming to be the new self-proclaimed ruler— he narrated. —The princesses said she was a tyrant and, ironically enough, she liked it.

—I understand she has an agreement with the Princess Alliance— Castaspella pointed out.

—Oh, yes, she does— Micah nodded, with a shy smile and feeling a bit awkward. —You see… eh… even if we don't like her methods, she has kept the Horde in check, and erm… you know Angella is extremely resourceful, a great strategist; she couldn't ignore how much her influence has helped Etheria after all these years. At a price, of course, like everything…

—You can't mention her without attaching praise, can you?— Castaspella mocked him. They both laughed a moment before she asked again —And she really accepted a truce with a woman who gave herself the title of "Tyrant of Mystacor"?

Micah nodded and let out a resigned sigh.

—Look… I've told you many times that the war out there isn't an easy matter, and I've seen for myself how much help the Rebellion needed— he replied. —It's hard to imagine how they would be if the Horde hadn't been stopped by Shadow Weaver's relentless attacks. I won't ever accept her methods but… this is war and all the Princess Alliance cares for is keeping their people safe.

Castaspella looked down, reflecting.

—I see…

After a moment of silence, he finally recalled —Ah, Sis, before I forget. I'm… permanently moving to Bright Moon. I don't want Angella to sneak in anymore; I know she's your only visitor ever, but we can't risk it any longer. So I'm… taking my things tonight.

—Finally!— she celebrated, much to his surprise.

—I wasn't expecting you to be so happy about it— he admitted.

—Micah, I love you brother, but your daughter just turned five this year. You should be there… *always*— she replied, taking his hands between hers. —I know you were worried about me, but you should have gone long ago— she assured him with a gentle smile.

—But… you haven't even left this place since I brought you.

She let go of his hands and nervously looked away, dismissing his concern with a gesture.

—Well, that won't be a problem anymore, I have to leave from now on, you know?— she let out, blushing a bit. —After all… I was invited to join the council!— she finally revealed.

—You… were!? But-but… *how*!? You're barely twenty! And that's the top of the hierarchy below the Tyrant!

—Oh, well, I was told Shadow Weaver asked for everyone's performance in our classes and… I may not have your talent but I'm the top student when it comes to theoretical knowledge. And… this council member came to find me earlier today, he explained Shadow Weaver was looking for the best student to join the council. You can imagine my reaction: I'm not close to being the best… but he said she didn't care about spell-casting, only about knowledge, and…— she replied, speaking quickly and nervously until Micah interrupted her.

With a hand on her shoulder, he smiled faintly as he said —I get it, Sis. It's… I'm happy for you. You've earned this.

She smiled back and hugged him.

—Thank you— she sighed. —I'll miss you now that you're moving away but… I promise to keep myself occupied; I'll survive without you and your dear Queen's visits.

Micah chuckled as she released him.

—Well, let's hope you can now achieve what you wanted and help the people of Mystacor despite our *dark* situation— he jokingly replied.

Castaspella lowered her face to her hand, covering the blush of second-hand embarrassment, and sighed —Don't ever say that again. You're terrible at puns.

He laughed once more at her reaction and made her giggle a bit.

After one final goodbye, she saw him leave and finally faced the exterior of the library.

A cold night welcomed her.

She had always imagined the world outside would be dark as it felt like everything was somehow under a veil of somberness; the stories she had heard, the way people seemed to be constantly holding their breath, everything made her believe the shadows of the Tyrant were all over Mystacor.

But they weren't.

It was a cold and calm night, with dark skies illuminated by Etheria's moons, the fresh aroma of the plants growing all over the place reached her nose and her oldest memories returned. She was a toddler the last time she had walked freely through the corridors, outside in the gardens, or down on the beach, and she hadn't realized how much she missed it.

Despite the chill she felt, having nothing but her dress on, she took her time to walk around, even went to the beach to sit and just watch the cloud-waves come and go. It was still so beautiful, and almost everything remained as she remembered; it made her feel happy, relieved, and her tears quickly fell as she fully embraced that nostalgic feeling.

She would *never* hide again.

During the first few weeks, Castaspella was introduced to the rest of the council and informed of the usual work-flow they handled. At the same time, she couldn't help noticing almost every council member was about double her age; they were all older than her brother at least, which made her feel somewhat uncomfortable, like a child meddling with grown-ups' business. She had to remind herself she was no longer a kid, and she had been *chosen* to do this, meaning they considered her fit enough for the task.

However, it quickly became evident she would need some time to learn how to navigate Mystacor in general, as she couldn't even remember the places she used to go before Micah hid her in the library.

When her colleagues realized her situation, none of them hesitated to help her. She didn't have a proper room, so they assigned her a new one. She didn't remember where the dining room was, so they showed her the easier way, knowing that, with time, she'd find faster routes. And, most importantly, she had never been face to face with Shadow Weaver, so each of them carefully explained how they approached her during meetings, to make sure they wouldn't provoke her wrath.

In fact, Castaspella hadn't ever *seen* the woman, not even from afar. All she knew was what others told her, even when it came to her appearance. So when they told her there would be a council meeting with Shadow Weaver soon, nervousness overtook her. And she had no better idea than asking for the latest mission reports and records of past council meetings, which she carefully reviewed the days prior.

When in doubt, she went back to reading… the only thing she can always rely on.

But it could hardly prepare her to actually attend the meeting.

What was she supposed to do there?

Do they have special rules or protocols?

Maybe the other council members had forgotten to tell her, or maybe they were doing that on purpose, to make fun of the newbie who would easily fall in their prank.

No, no. That made no sense.

They had warned her repeatedly about how dangerous Shadow Weaver's wrath could be, it would be the last thing they'd do.

In any case, Castaspella wouldn't allow any missteps.

And yet, she barely managed to calm herself down before entering the council room with everyone else. She followed them in, took the only seat that was left available in front of the central table, around the middle, and kept her sight down, away from the Tyrant seated at the back, meters away from their table.

—Is everyone here already? You know I dislike repeating myself— Shadow Weaver suddenly spoke.

She looked up briefly to see the woman literally enveloped by darkness, only the white sockets of her mask visible.

Right.

Her mask.

She *knew* the Tyrant used a mask, but didn't know how it was, and was absolutely not expecting the sockets to be so visible in the darkness.

—Yes, everyone is here— the councillor on Castaspella's left replied.

He was the one who came looking for her, Daryon: an imposing man with a stern look, but noticeably gentle with younger sorcerers.

—Then pay attention, everyone— Shadow Weaver demanded, walking closer to the table. She stopped right before the faint light above the council could illuminate her, and some strange shadow entity appeared on her side, bringing a deep plate filled with water. —These are the results of the last missions you have carried out— she began, placing the plate on the edge of the table. Her hands were mostly covered by red garments up to the last phalanges of her fingers, leaving them and her long claws visible; she moved them under the light as she cast a spell over the water to show the council what her spies had seen the past weeks. Groups of sorcerers appeared in the images, plenty of them were wounded and forced to retreat by Horde forces. Some more were trying to ambush the soldiers but instead fell into a trap, and others were scouting and got knocked down, forcing nearby teams to rescue them. —How exactly do you expect to progress at all if this poor excuse of an army can defeat you so easily? They have small blasters and weak spears, while you have magic, *spells*! And yet… You all keep *failing*.

There was a short silence.

They knew she hated it when they didn't reply, so the sorceress in charge of some of those missions, Ekaterina, promptly spoke up.

—We followed your instructions; we took our teams to the locations indicated, used as many spells for camouflage as possible. But we… we can't blend in with the shadows, even our spells aren't enough to hide us from the Horde— she explained from her seat, near the left end of the table, fearful but hoping her honest reply would suffice.

—Are you implying my instructions were *wrong*?— Shadow Weaver asked menacingly.

—No, no. She didn't mean that— Daryon interrupted. He seemed to be like a leader in their eyes, and Castaspella quickly realized they were all protecting each other here; they could only rely on one another to appease the Tyrant and make sure to survive another day. —Perhaps she phrased it wrong; she only meant we did all we were told, as we always do, but our spells no longer give us the upper hand. We have lost too many in these missions, we've been careless, and it's a fact we're being left to die.

—I am doing everything in my power, which is not little, to protect you all; to ensure the Horde threat won't advance anymore. Haven't I done more than all those princesses?— she pointed out, condescending, looking back at them with her head tilted.

—O-of course, Shadow Weaver— Daryon replied, somewhat nervous with her tone. He took a second before speaking again, needing to gather his ideas to better express his concern. —However, the soldiers… they have learned to see us despite the cloaking spells, they know how we move, and how you plan the missions— he explained, managing to look unfazed, despite his shaking hands behind his back. —It is clear we need new strategies, not because the current ones are flawed, but because they have become outdated.

Shadow Weaver turned around, considering his words before speaking up again.

—Then I suppose you've come up with your *own* strategies to replace the old ones, no?— she defied them, knowing they were *not* ready at all to please her this time.

—Our… own strategies?— another councillor asked, visibly nervous.

—Of course. Unless you only prepared excuses for your poor performance and no suggestions to actually improve it— she pressed them.

A new silence settled among them and Shadow Weaver anticipated the delight of punishing them for their incompetence.

Ah, yes, she'd enjoy it…

However, an unexpected voice soon spoke up, sounding more conclusive than nervous, as if she was just reflecting, thinking aloud.

—Actually, you're not doing everything in your power; and she *did* mention something you could do— Castaspella pointed out, referring to Ekaterina's reply. —She said we can't blend in with the shadows with our camouflage spells, and that is what we need for new strategies — she continued, catching everyone's attention. Surprisingly, the Tyrant let her speak and listened carefully as the sorceress elaborated —It's clear you aren't just sending sorcerers to die, that's why you make these careful plans; be it because you require the manpower or because you still want to keep the people of Mystacor safe, the facts remain: old strategies are no longer useful, you need new ones, and you have the *one* power no one else has, power the Horde can't beat, that can keep the sorcerers safe to continue fighting.

—Then you expect me to join the team missions?

—Is that a trick question?— Castaspella asked, genuinely confused. —The mission reports are commented on by you, I supposed at least the council knew you personally supervise them. You keep yourself safe within the shadows, I reckon, so it wouldn't be much different to hide them too; it's useful for ambushes and especially helpful if they are only setting traps, as the *whole point* is ruined if they are discovered.

Shadow Weaver had to admit she was surprised; she didn't expect her to know so much already.

Wasn't she *new*?

—Who are you, girl?— she asked, slightly annoyed.

—Again, is that a trick question? Don't you recognize my face? One would say you'd see his face in mine after almost getting him *killed*— Castaspella replied, bolder than she should, but barely able to control her anger.

—Ah, of course— she uttered. She had recognized her the second she saw her, obviously, but now she knew what view of her she had. —And yet you dare suggest cloaking ambush teams with my shadows, *girl*?— she questioned her, hiding her surprise.

—I am treating you with respect so, please, don't call me that— she let out, with a severe glare that made her look much older. After taking a deep breath to compose herself, she relaxed her expression once again. —Your umbrakinesis can do that— she began, with absolute confidence. —I've read enough about it and, dark magic or not, I know for a fact that you have absolute control over it, so you can envelop anyone in shadows without harming them. That is something you can *choose* to do— she insisted.

That… was correct.

Once again, the Tyrant had to admit *she was surprised*. After shoving it in her face how she endangered Micah, how could she be so sure of her control over her dark magic?

In any other case, she would already be submitting such an irreverent girl under the full might of her powers to make a point.

But how could she, when all the sorceress did was *prove her wrong*?

No, she needed to find the flaw in her logic first.

—And what makes you think anyone in Mystacor would *ever* agree to leave their safety in my hands? You are the first person to suggest my powers can do more than just harm.

Everyone realized Shadow Weaver was adamant about dismissing her idea, trying to get her to cower and withdraw the suggestion, but the young sorceress was extremely stubborn.

—It can be safe if you decide so! I know it.

—Do you? You sound too confident, girl. Maybe you'd be willing to prove it?— she challenged her, smirking under her mask.

And much to everyone’s surprise, she didn’t hesitate to accept.

Castaspella stood up, walked to the right side of the room, and called out —Whenever you want, *hag*.

Shadow Weaver ignored the insult, and the council’s gasps, and raised a hand to send her shadows in her direction; even *she* wasn’t sure something like that would work, but maybe the girl was right.

After all, she always waited her sweet time before letting her shadows invade her victims.

In this case, she simply had to keep that power controlled instead.

The shadows could perceive the sorceress's magic emanating from her body, which allowed Shadow Weaver to know exactly where she was, and when Castaspella began moving, she simply let her shadows follow her freely.

Moments later, she had reached the other side of the room and Shadow Weaver called the shadows back.

She was right.

—She’s… fine.

—It worked?

—Are you alright?— the councillor closest to Castaspella, Anya, asked; her concern evident, as was her surprise.

—It feels a little weird but I assure you there’s no danger— she told everyone, which made them mutter among themselves.

—Well then— Shadow Weaver interrupted, calling their attention back to her. —You can thank your new member for saving your sorry lives; we shall test the new strategy tonight. You’re all dismissed— she sentenced.

Chapter End Notes

Well, how's that for an intro to the AU?
Interesting?

I certainly hope you enjoyed it and want to see more!

Updates are, as always, weekly, but on Saturdays for this fic, so see you next week!!

P.s.: I take suggestions for the tags since I don't know which ones to use <("^_^)
If you see anything that really needs to be tagged, please let me know, more so if it's

anything triggering. Thank you!

Chapter 2

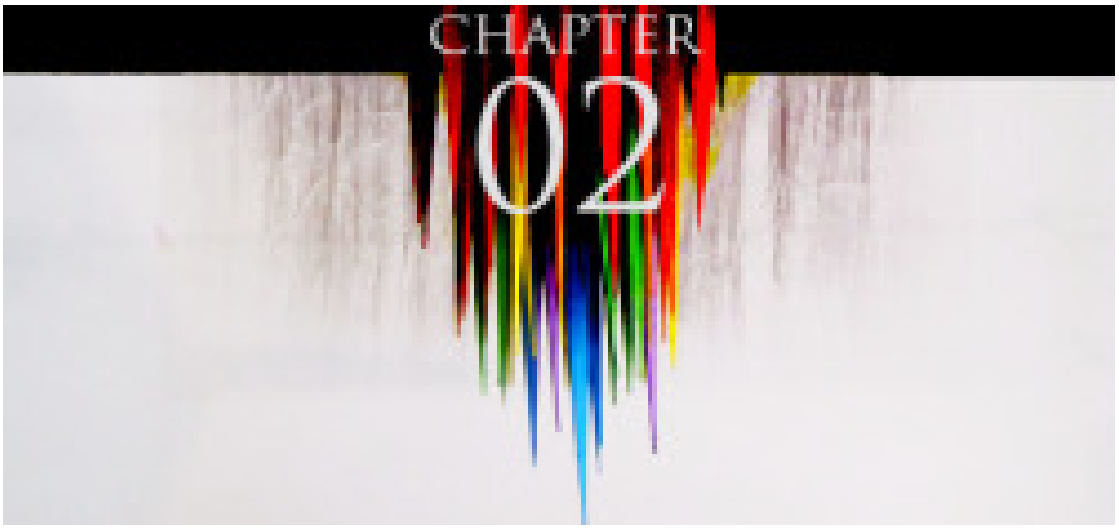
Chapter Summary

> “Being so selfless will get you *killed*, and being this reckless will kill you *faster*” ~ SW

Chapter Notes

> Hello and welcome back!
>
> So, I really hope you’ll like how the story continues!
> It’s nothing for now, there will be more action and intrigue (I hope lol) in coming chapters, so this short chapter is more like a little dip into the sorcerers fighting the Horde, one of the biggest divergences as a consequence of SW’s rule!
>
> I certainly hope you enjoy, regardless of how short it is, and see you at the end!!
> Please enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



—Well then— Shadow Weaver said, calling everyone’s attention back to her. —You can thank your new member for saving your sorry lives; we shall test the new strategy tonight. You’re all dismissed— she sentenced.

The council stood up, their heads hanging low in obvious shame, and after briefly bowing, they began to empty the room. Castaspella was about to follow, but Shadow Weaver approached her, and the young sorceress turned around to find the Tyrant towering over her.

—Don’t you dare call me “hag” ever again— she stated.

—I tried to be respectful enough, politely asked you to stop calling me “girl”, but you ignored me— Castaspella replied.

—You are too bold, *girl*.

—I am *not* a girl, like you’re not a hag. But if you won’t acknowledge my maturity, then maybe I shouldn’t be in this council— she replied, angry enough to be willing to quit.

—Really? You must have a death wish for speaking to me like that— Shadow Weaver remarked, menacingly.

—You can fool everyone by pretending you’re a monster, but my brother told me everything that happened back then… when you did the… *spell*— she replied, hesitating a bit. —You never meant to harm him, so it’s clear you don’t completely disregard others’ lives. It’s just easier to be mean, I suppose.

—I should throw you out of Mystacor for your irreverence— the Tyrant threatened. —But that would be a waste. If I remember correctly, you’re only competent with theoretical magic and defense spells, no?— she asked, and Castaspella nodded. —Well, that bunch of fools can certainly use your brains, today proved as much. And, as it is your idea what we’re testing, I believe it’s only logical to have you as the defense support, no?

—What!? I-I have no field experience…

—Which is why I can’t send you to be part of the ambush itself.

—So I am supposed to keep everyone from *dying*!?— she exclaimed.

—Don’t you trust your own suggestion?— Shadow Weaver defied her.

—I don’t trust my spells to keep their lives *safe*, which is different!— she replied, indignant.

—Then you better start focusing. Do you want to prove you’re an adult too? Start acting like one— she defied her. —And don’t be late— she added before returning to the darker part of the room.

Hours later, six sorcerers were waiting near the entrance to Mystacor, getting ready for the mission. The council member leading them, a built sorcerer called Kenno, noticed Castaspella approaching and introduced her to the team.

—You are really coming with us on this mission?— he asked her in disbelief.

—Apparently… As it was my idea, I’m… in charge of protecting you.

Kenno laughed light-heartedly and replied —Don’t worry, those Horde soldiers have no chance against my strength and my magic. They think we sorcerers are all brain and no

muscle.

—You may have both, but you're *not* immortal. You shouldn't be this calm to have *me* protecting you— she warned him, anxious.

—I appreciate the concern, Castaspella, but really, I trust you— he replied. —I personally reviewed your performance and suggested you for the vacant spot in the council; this is something you *can* do.

Before she could reply, Kenno and the other sorcerers straightened and she realized Shadow Weaver was there.

They had no time to lose.

The group stood in a circle around the Tyrant and let her envelop them with her power. It wasn't the evening yet, but when they teleported into the Whispering Woods, the darkness of the place was almost total, giving them the perfect cover.

Kenno instructed the sorcerers to separate for the ambush and, without alerting them, they surrounded a reduced score of Horde soldiers sitting on a small illuminated area, while, at a safe distance, Shadow Weaver stood hidden with Castaspella.

The sorcerers jumped into the light, their spells ready to attack, and the shadows receded instantly; Castaspella raised her hands, preparing a spell, while the Tyrant carefully watched, keeping her close enough so she wouldn't accidentally reveal herself.

She was expecting the girl to panic, to freeze and mess up her spell. And yet, when the sorcerers easily defeated the soldiers, Castaspella didn't hesitate to cast a barrier around and above them, realizing it was a trap.

Dozens of soldiers came rushing at them from every side, and some jumped down from the trees.

—It's a trap— the young sorceress uttered.

—I can see that.

—Then order the retreat! Hide them again and help them escape or they are all doomed!— she begged, never losing focus.

Slightly annoyed, but recognizing she was right, Shadow Weaver raised her voice to yell — Retreat! Return to the shadows! Get out of that clearing!

It became evident to Castaspella that, as long as they were under the light, they would have no escape; the Horde soldiers were pushing to break her barrier, and she didn't know how much they could last, but she had to open them a path back to the shadowed part of the forest.

—I'll… try… something— she said, already out of breath.

Shadow Weaver looked at her, surprised that she hadn't given up, and observed as she bent the barrier, forcing the soldiers aside, trying to clear the way for the sorcerers. Kenno quickly understood what she was doing and began pushing against the soldiers through the barrier, swiftly escaping with his team as soon as the shadows enveloped them.

Moments later, they were all back in Mystacor, some sighing in relief, some cursing their bad luck, and before Kenno could thank her for saving them, Castaspella passed out from exhaustion.

The young sorceress opened her eyes and found herself amidst darkness.

She wasn't sure whether she was awake or not; it certainly felt like she was asleep because she couldn't move her body and saw nothing around her. However, she could perceive different sounds: water boiling, crystals tinkling, someone pouring a liquid, walking and moving things.

Her only option was trying to speak; be it a dream or reality, she should get an answer, right?

However, Castaspella could barely form any words at first…

She eventually managed to ask where she was, only to hear the most unexpected voice reply —So you are finally awake. Well, you're in my room; you overused your power. Could have died.

—I… can't move— she uttered, struggling to speak and slowly starting to distinguish forms around her.

—Of course you can't. It's normal. After all, you almost fried your nervous system— Shadow Weaver replied, approaching her side with a cup. —You have to drink this, it will help— she ordered, offering the cup.

Castaspella attempted to move, tried to lift her arms, move her fingers; she *really* tried but simply couldn't.

—I… cannot… move— the sorceress repeated, her voice strained.

The Tyrant let out an exasperated sigh; she wondered why exactly she was doing this, how this young woman had become such a key piece in her plans in a matter of hours, and why she had allowed this to happen.

Everyone in Mystacor had felt completely dispensable to her from the beginning; she wouldn't carelessly waste resources, but hardly spared a thought for those who had to be sacrificed.

Yet now, she had brought this sorceress to her own room, used her personal supply to make this potion, and was sitting on her side to lift her head up and feed her the concoction before the damage became irreversible.

—What you did was *reckless*. You should have dropped the barrier when you began feeling tired; what is the point in protecting them if you might pass out before they are out of danger?— Shadow Weaver reprimanded her, knowing she would have to listen at least until the potion took effect. —Being so selfless will get you *killed*, and being this reckless will kill you *faster*— she insisted. —Besides, they can protect themselves; if you had dropped the barrier, they would have lasted long enough to reach the darkness so I could take them away.

Castaspella finished drinking and Shadow Weaver laid her down once again, her eyes closed as she breathed deeply. The liquid helped with the dryness of her throat so the sorceress could speak more now.

—They had to focus on escaping; the… the ambush was too large for them. And… and maybe Kenno had a chance… but he had to keep all of them safe… And he trusted me. I wouldn't let any of them down— she stated.

Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes as she uttered —That self-righteousness is a great weakness if you don't acknowledge your limits.

—Then can… can I learn better casting? Or develop… more resistance?— she asked, making an effort to speak and starting to test whether she could move her fingers.

The Tyrant was, once again, surprised.

Castaspella proved her wrong just like earlier.

She was so sure the young sorceress would try to quit…

Wouldn't she give up after this?

How could she be so willing to continue, to get *better* just so she could do this *again*, even after almost dying?

Wasn't she *afraid*?

Perhaps she was too stubborn for this method, so how could someone like Castaspella be properly controlled?

Or maybe she shouldn't be.

After all, the *obedient council* had always been too scared to actually contribute a single thing. Meanwhile, this sorceress and her irreverence showed them they had completely overlooked for years one of the best resources they have, if not the best one.

—I can ask my best pupil to tutor you; developing resistance and perfecting your casting will take time, but proper guidance will noticeably shorten that time— Shadow Weaver finally replied.

Castaspella opened her eyes again and realized she could slightly distinguish her form in the darkness; she was looking away, and with her mask on, she had no idea what the Tyrant could be thinking.

—Why have someone else train me?— she asked, interrupting herself to clear her throat a bit. —It's obvious you would never think someone else is better than you, especially not a pupil of yours. And being a tutor yourself…

—Every member of the council is, or has been, a pupil of mine. *You aren't*. They all see me almost exclusively as their tutor, and all of them are probably more scared of me than of death itself. *You aren't*. And none of them ever dares propose a good idea, none of them takes a risk, too fearful of upsetting me. You didn't care and suggested something so obvious and simple it's almost *shameful* we hadn't done it before— Shadow Weaver admitted. —So I'd rather you remain more neutral to me; if being my pupil turns you into another fool or another Micah, then *I* will be the fool for allowing it.

Castaspella wanted to laugh, she could hardly believe what the woman was saying, but it *actually* made sense.

—I see…

The Tyrant looked back at her, the mask showing just enough to let Castaspella know she had to be smirking, and sentenced —We wouldn't want you to lose that boldness after this… insightful suggestion, no?

Chapter End Notes

😌 Alright, enough for today okay, tho I promise longer chapters for the future XD

In fact, next chapter I can't remember its length, but it will be ✨ interesting ✨

ANYWAYS, before biding you all farewell, allow me to say: today is the 7th, meaning in two days, **it's my birthday**!!! I'll officially be 25!
Little by little I'm closer to Casta's age in the show lol
Here, I'm older than her (for now) hahaha

ANYWAYS AGAIN
Thanks everyone for reading, I hope you're enjoying this, and I'll see you next week, I sure hope (#^_^#) bye!

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> The sorcerers had long realized how much they owed Castaspella; they had come to appreciate her for her gentleness and absolute commitment to keeping them safe, and now it was their time to protect her…

Chapter Notes

> So… This is quite an important chapter, in my opinion, for a number of reasons I shall leave to your discretion. I guess I just wanted to let you know that you can expect the events of this chapter to completely shift the dynamics from now on.
> I think.
> I'm kind of numb to that kind of details by now from how much I've worked on the story, but like, the intention behind this chapter is what I mean, and I hope it does achieve that goal.
>
> And omgs, I almost forgot to post this today! Sorry, I came to visit my BFF for a week, so I was a bit distracted <("^_^)
>
> Now yes, I suppose that's all for this initial note, so I invite you now to read this new chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



For six months, without rest, Castaspella handled her daily duties and the new training. Every day she juggled her routine of personal care, like washing her clothes, fixing it, sewing or knitting new garments, keeping herself fed and her room in order; with her duties in Mystacor, from council matters to tutoring stuff, as she had to teach at least a few courses due to the shortage of competent teachers.

And yet, she made sure always to have enough time for her training and dedicated at least an hour to practicing every night before going to sleep.

Under Ayax's tutelage, Castaspella made quick progress, and with her determination to get better, they noticed she was ready for missions in just half a year and recommended she return to the field.

However, Shadow Weaver had some reservations.

Ayax was the oldest in the council, had been her pupil so long ago she could barely remember how they used to be, and defense had always been their thing. It was clear that now they saw Castaspella as the perfect replacement so they could finally remain in Mystacor.

The Tyrant promised them she would eventually withdraw them from the field, given their old age, but she couldn't do so until Castaspella proved her worth.

In her first weeks back on the field, Castaspella demonstrated her improvement, and everyone in Mystacor soon knew that "the youngest in the council was relieving the oldest from their duty".

Ayax felt indebted.

But the sorceress still asked from them one last thing: to keep training her until she had mastered every defense technique, until her endurance to cast and maintain spells was enough that even holding a barrier for a full day wouldn't put her on death's door.

—But, dear child, haven't you perfected it enough?— they asked, talking like a grandparent.

—Well, in a way, I suppose; I can give my spells whatever form I need, and cast just any protection in a blink. I can literally give them the form of lightning so it's easier to move and requires less energy from me… but, none of that matters if I'm not fast enough or get exhausted too quickly— she explained, trying to make them see why she was so adamant on improving further.

—I see… Then I suppose… It's time for a real test— they said. Castaspella's confusion was evident so, while walking through the training ground, they explained —I've heard you avoided using the form you chose for your spells, am I correct? Don't answer, I read the reports. So, my child, you need to prove you're ready to progress: the path forward requires you to be comfortable with your magic, your technique, your casting—. They finally halted near the training dummies and placed themselves right in front of one, looking back at Castaspella. —You are right, there is always something more to learn, but I don't have

anything else to teach you, I can only support you from the sidelines. So this is my last test for you: using the form you picked, the lightning, to cast protection spells, make sure nothing hurts me— they sentenced, right before activating the training ground with a spell.

Their trust in her was so absolute that they kept their eyes closed, hands behind their back, and stood their ground as if they weren't in the line of fire, *literally speaking*.

Despite how shocking it was, Castaspella didn't miss a beat; every spell she threw connected right in time, either creating barriers away from Ayax to stop boulders shot at them, or barely perceptible protections around their body to protect them from flames that suddenly burst under their feet.

Blades, photon blasts, icicles, everything shot at them, she managed to catch it. And when she thought it was over, a pair of dark arms suddenly tried to grab them, but Castaspella didn't think before enveloping Ayax with a barrier that emanated light like an illumination spell.

—Very impressive— a voice spoke behind her.

Startled, she turned to find Shadow Weaver.

And so she understood: The test *was* over; the dark magic that attacked them at the end was actually *hers*.

—You could have hurt them!— Castaspella exclaimed.

Ignoring her indignation, Ayax approached with a bright smile, bowing at Shadow Weaver when they were close enough.

—I say she's ready, even using her personal forms— Ayax sentenced. —Can I consider myself retired?— they asked, very politely.

There was a second of silence until she scoffed sardonically.

—Congratulations, old fogey. You did it; but you better keep teaching, understood?— she replied with severity.

That was all.

As Shadow Weaver left, Ayax laughed and gave Castaspella a warm hug, yet she was still indignant.

—She could have *killed you*! I barely learned the light barrier a week ago!— she exclaimed.

—Oh, don't worry, dear child— they laughed. —Death by her hand would be a blessing at this point in my life— they smiled. —See you in our next training session.

A blessing?

She couldn't be more confused now…

Yet she didn't have a chance to ask what they meant.

Without another word, they patted her shoulder and left.

The next day, Castaspella was in her room after half a day of putting everything in order so she could take the afternoon and evening for herself. She had her clothes ready, gave up on changing her hairstyle, as nothing seemed to fit, and was now contemplating her reflection in the mirror, deciding whether to use makeup or not.

Lipstick? Shade? She was slightly annoyed as Angella always looked flawless no matter what she used, while she couldn’t even use some cosmetics without feeling like an utter mess.

After longer than necessary, she finally made up her mind: better without any makeup, why not look like every other day? It wasn’t that important.

However, part of the council was called for an urgent meeting shortly after, and she had to go, if anything, to ask for the rest of the day off.

—An impromptu mission? Is this a joke?— she asked, indignant, as the short meeting ended.

—Do I look like someone who makes *jokes*?

Castaspella would have *loved* to reply that she looked like someone who enjoys annoying people, but she bit her tongue; she needed to get Shadow Weaver’s permission to leave, after all.

Instead, she took a deep breath and calmed down before speaking.

—In that case, I need to do something before we go, and… I was going to ask for the rest of the day; it would be after the mission, of course— she politely requested.

—The day off? Don’t tell me… Today is your birthday— she guessed, her tone ambiguous enough that Castaspella didn’t know if it was menacing or some sort of malicious curiosity.

—I won’t ask how you know— she uttered, her expression unamused.

A bit taken aback by the lack of reaction, Shadow Weaver severely resolved —If you do well on the mission, perhaps I’ll consider authorizing your leave once we’re back—. Castaspella didn’t reply, just nodded and turned to walk away, barely hearing the Tyrant mutter —A year older, a year bolder.

Some time later, Castaspella rushed to arrive at the entrance of Mystacor, returning from Bright Moon after explaining to her brother she’d be there later than the agreed time. Out of breath, she apologized for the delay and joined the mission team, led by Ekaterina this time.

—Do yourself a favour and master the teleportation spell soon— Shadow Weaver let out, disregarding her apology, while gesturing at the sorcerers so they would get ready to leave. —The plan is simple: a fake ambush to expose theirs and a coordinated attack to take them down. *Don't fail*; if you make a mistake, you're on your own.

—Of course not— Castaspella countered. —Even if you leave, I'm not getting out of the woods until everyone in this team is back— she defied her.

—It-it's alright— Ekaterina interrupted, before Shadow Weaver could lash out at the sorceress. —We *won't* fail, I give you my word.

Although it was somehow frustrating, Castaspella didn't insist; she didn't need the Tyrant's approval, she *would* make sure they all returned.

The mission went… unexpectedly *well*: Ekaterina divided her seven sorcerers into three teams, two of them were ordered to stay hidden, both on the ground and above some trees, while she joined the third team to expose the ambush. When chaos began, the sorcerers fully focused on attacking, while Castaspella sent innumerable spells as quick flashes of lightning, one after another, protecting them from all shots and, in some cases, invigorating them at the same time. Behind her, Shadow Weaver observed once again, remembering how her first mission had been; she could barely believe how much progress that "girl" had made.

It almost angered her that, in fact, she managed to pass all her challenges, proving her worth more than she was willing to admit.

—They are almost done— Castaspella noticed, keeping her voice down but too excited to realize she was almost out of cover.

The Tyrant reacted quickly, grabbed her waist, pulled her back without disturbing her casting, and hissed —Focus on keeping yourself safe first. What use is a defender who is *dead*?

She couldn't believe she was actually depending on this young sorceress for the success of her missions.

Why couldn't she simply obliterate all the Horde with her powers!?

Right, she knew why… She would die before half of them were down.

But the sorcerers of Mystacor had been a *disappointment*.

So this girl- woman, no, this literal wild-card was a rare blessing she had to preserve as long as she could.

Now she *depended* on her, and that absolutely *infuriated* her.

As Ekaterina and her team faced the last of the soldiers, those who didn't run away, Castaspella put a few more spells on them to deflect the blaster shots and energize them. That way, their next spells were notoriously stronger and knocked out all remaining soldiers.

They let out a loud cheer; the sorcerers could hardly believe they succeeded despite being so outnumbered, and their cries of joy only stopped when they saw the Tyrant and the young sorceress approaching.

—How did you do that!?

—Did you see that last shot!?

—I was so sure the blasters would fry me…

—Not with our star defender! They were so confused seeing they couldn't hurt us!

The sorcerers spoke excitedly, one over the other, while Ekaterina looked back at Shadow Weaver expecting, at least, an acknowledgment.

Yet the Tyrant remained silent…

However, the councilwoman couldn't even stress about it for a second before a movement a few meters from them caught her eye.

She barely had time to warn —Behind you!

Everyone turned simultaneously to see one last Horde soldier who came out of nowhere with a spear, aiming for Shadow Weaver. Out of instinct, Castaspella jumped right in front of her, already casting a barrier between them and the soldier.

But they didn't stop and thrust the spear without hesitation…

The sorceress gasped, feeling an acute pain in her abdomen, and stared wide-eyed at the soldier behind her barrier, who was trembling, looking down at their spear.

Following their sight, she realized they had managed to throw the blow right before the barrier appeared, and the spear was now surrounded by the spell, making it impossible for them to remove it.

Before they were out of their shock, the Tyrant's black magic was wrapping around the soldier, making them scream as they felt their skin burn under the armor.

Right after, Shadow Weaver merely cut the head off the rest of the spear with her claws, leaving only the bloody edge still buried on Castaspella's left side, and immediately picked her up as she grunted —That Horde scum…

—Everyone! Cover our retreat! Handle any other surprises that were to appear!— Ekaterina ordered. —We cannot let anything else happen to her. We need to return to Mystacor safely and *fast*!

Nobody questioned her orders and obeyed without delay.

They wouldn't dare…

It was quite *wild* seeing the Tyrant carrying the young sorceress in her arms like that, but they couldn't care less.

The sorcerers had long realized how much they owed Castaspella; they had come to appreciate her for her gentleness and absolute commitment to keeping them safe, and now it was their time to protect her…

With little effort, they were soon back in Mystacor, and once again the sorceress was taken to Shadow Weaver's room; while Ekaterina went for Anya, the Tyrant rushed to prepare a local sedative and a powder to close the wound.

Once Anya arrived, she didn't waste time asking questions, instead focusing on assisting the sorceress. She first cleaned the wound and applied the sedative Shadow Weaver gave her, then used a healing spell that stopped the bleeding, and finally applied the powder.

Castaspella was conscious but too tired, yet still heard as the sorceresses argued.

—She should rest now— Anya advised.

—No. Use the healing spell once more; along with the powder, it will let her move again— the Tyrant ordered.

—But… Master, you don't expect her to…

—I won't ask anything else from her— she interrupted, seemingly rolling her eyes behind the mask. —However, she's stubborn enough to go see her brother tonight even if she were still bleeding. We can't stop her, so we better patch her up properly or she will worsen it.

—But she needs rest— Anya insisted.

—No more buts— Shadow Weaver retorted, severe yet without raising her voice. —She'll be more than fine where she's going. She'll be taken care of, you can rest assured— she added, obviously bothered.

When Castaspella reached the palace in Bright Moon, she was noticeably pale and hadn't even changed clothes, so the ripped bloodied fabric of her dress was the first thing the guards noticed as she arrived.

The King was immediately notified and, soon, Micah appeared at the entrance to help her into the main hall. His first instinct was to offer her new clothes and to get the healers, but she quickly dismissed him.

—I'm fine… I've been treated already— she explained, her voice faint. —I just… I need rest, and food— she assured him, trying to smile.

—What happened? Who did this!?— he asked, increasingly worried.

—Please, Love. Let her recover first— Angella interrupted, gently taking Castaspella to a seat at the table. —You can tell us what happened once you regain your strength.

Both were extremely worried about the sorceress; whatever had happened, she had to be downplaying it so they wouldn't fret, but it was obvious she had lost too much blood, and in such a weakened state, they couldn't believe she was there with them.

However, it was evident that what she needed the most right now was time and space. She'd explain everything once she was ready and recovered.

Hence, they gave the order to serve the dinner, as they had planned, and decided to tell her about any irrelevant eventualities they could remember, trying to ease the tense atmosphere.

Almost half an hour passed before the sorceress showed a healthier color, and her breathing seemed easier, so she finally explained what happened during the mission.

They were in absolute disbelief but Castaspella assured them she would be fine soon.

—We're making progress, *real* progress, and I make sure no one gets hurt during our missions.

—And yet *you* did— Micah pointed out.

—I just need to be faster— she sighed. —I'm still training so this won't happen again.

—But you can't neglect your own protection for others' sake. What will they do if they lose you mid-fight?— Angella expressed.

The sorceress lowered her sight and let out a dry laugh.

—She said the same— she recalled. —Only a bit… harsher. Her exact words were: "What use is a defender who is dead?", which… is pretty much literal.

With a serious expression, the Queen replied —No matter how intense it sounds, she's still right. You can only keep others protected if *you* remain safe first.

—I know. I… Usually, I just stay next to Shadow Weaver, both of us concealed by her magic, and I protect the team from there. This… was different, unexpected. And I was just… too slow.

—Casta— Micah called. With a pained expression, he stated —Sometimes you can't be fast enough. This was an accident, we get it, but… Just promise next time you'll prioritize your *own* safety—. She looked away with a gloomy expression and he felt the need to add —And with all due respect, Sis… That Tyrant's life is not worth it.

She froze for a second.

It wasn't completely unexpected from Micah to think that, but it felt so *wrong* to hear him say it.

However, Castaspella couldn't answer since a five-year-old pink-haired girl came running into the room.

—Auntie!

Little Glimmer ran up to her and extended her arms, wanting to be lifted into her lap. Unable to refuse, the sorceress hissed a bit in pain as she picked the girl up and carefully sat her on her lap, making sure Glimmer wouldn't notice the wound. She wished Castaspella a happy birthday and merrily remained between her aunt's arms, oblivious to the grim atmosphere.

—Casta, tell me something— Angella requested with a light tone, her sight fixed on her daughter. —If Glimmer was already of age… Would you recommend she went to learn magic at Mystacor? Please, be honest.

Glimmer learning magic there…

She contemplated the question for a moment before replying —Currently, no. Honestly, I wouldn't… However, by the time she's actually of age, I expect things to be *different*.

—Casta…

—So much can change in the years to come. You wouldn't believe how much things have already changed. And, of course, I intend to use my position as councillor to further improve Mystacor's environment— she insisted, sounding proud at the end. With a soft smile, she concluded —Ask me again in a few years; my answer could change.

A while passed, it was now time for dessert and they decided the dinner should end on a happier tone; after all, they were supposed to be celebrating a birthday, so they changed topics and told Castaspella about a few funny incidents with Glimmer's developing powers.

By the time the desserts were finished, the little Princess had fallen asleep on the sorceress' lap, and Angella took her daughter to bed before seeing her off with Micah.

—Angie— he called.

—Yes, Dear?

—Do you think… she will be fine?

Both of them observed the sorceress walk away vigorously, a stark contrast to the weakened state in which she had arrived, and kept watching the horizon after she was gone. Angella kept silent, considering her words, and let out a long sigh when she settled on an answer.

—I know she will.

—How are you so sure?

The Queen turned around, held his hands and, with a gentle look, assured him —She's far stronger than you think. You're her brother, of course you'll fear for her. But trust me, Love, she's not being stubborn for going back, it's possibly the only thing she trusts herself with.

—Getting hurt to protect others?

—Making Mystacor *better*.

—So you really think she can improve things?— he asked with a hint of hope.

—She will find a way to make it possible.

It was almost midnight when Castaspella returned to Mystacor. She looked much better than when she left, obviously recovered, and walked into the building standing straight, breathing easily.

However, being so tired, she couldn't wait to arrive at her room and go to sleep at last, so she walked into the corridors, faintly illuminated by the moonlight, without noticing the person standing right next to the entrance.

—Back already?

Startled, the sorceress turned around and quickly recognized the tall figure in the darkness.

—Were you waiting for me!?

—Perhaps…— Shadow Weaver ominously replied. It was just a coincidence that she happened to be nearby when Castaspella arrived, but it could play to her favour if the sorceress believed she was monitoring her. —I'm surprised your brother let you return after almost dying to cover me— she taunted, walking closer.

—Deciding that is *not* his prerogative, you know?

Castaspella crossed her arms and looked away as she answered; it always annoyed her when the Tyrant implied others' dictated her actions.

—So you were eager to return?— she insisted, closing in on the sorceress. Noticing her stepping back, she pressed on until the young sorceress bumped against the wall. —Sometimes I wonder if you're too courageous or too stupid— she mocked her.

It was obvious what she was trying to do…

Yet, despite how menacing Shadow Weaver looked as she towered over her, Castaspella daringly replied —I joined your damned council solely to protect everyone on this floating island. I *don't* care what it takes or whether you approve of it: I'm staying here to defend everyone. Be it from the Horde… or from *you*.

The Tyrant fixed her sight on Castaspella, slowly moving closer to her face; her resolve was something she hadn't seen in years. It intrigued her as much as it infuriated her.

On the other hand, the sorceress had mustered all her courage and now feared the consequences, but she wouldn't back down.

As Shadow Weaver moved closer, Castaspella noticed she felt her breathing on her face, meaning she wasn't using her mask, yet she hadn't realized before due to the darkness.

—A year older, a year bolder— the Tyrant uttered.

—Does that annoy you?— she taunted, unwilling to break under the pressure.

—On the contrary, Castaspella. You might have just earned my approval thanks to that fearless personality of yours— she replied, her tone deriding, wanting the sorceress to know how much she was enjoying mocking her. Suddenly, she got an idea, and added —I haven't given you a birthday present, have I?

—Unless you consider the surprise mission a "present"…— she scoffed, rolling her eyes. —Not like I was expecting anything from you, anyways.

—All the better, then— she let out. The next moment, her hand was on Castaspella's neck, and before she could react, the Tyrant harshly kissed her, pinning the sorceress against the wall. Surprisingly, she soon gave in and kissed her back. Shadow Weaver released her shortly after and sentenced —You now have my favour. This is my *present* for you. Use it wisely.

And just like that, the Tyrant walked away.

Castaspella leant against the wall until her legs gave in; she slid down to the ground and sat there for a moment, trying to understand what had just happened.

But she was in shock.

She could still feel the cold, split lips against hers; the intensity of the kiss kept the memory fresh and wouldn't let her focus.

She lost track of how long she stood there, but eventually the chill of the night breeze woke her up from the trance she was in, and she finally dragged herself to bed.

Yet… she couldn't sleep.

Every time she closed her eyes, she felt herself cornered against the wall as Shadow Weaver kissed her.

Castaspella couldn't see her face at all, but now couldn't forget how her mouth felt; rough skin, split lip, sharp teeth, and a somewhat smoky taste.

Then she remembered what she told her: the Tyrant bestowed her *favour* on her, but what exactly did that mean?

Morning found her reflecting about it, and before she knew it, she had to get up and ready herself for a new day.

Chapter End Notes

Well!
Just to be clear, there are yet no traces of romance in sight.
As I've mentioned in the tags, that's gonna happen with time, ofc, and until then, you can only expect mainly *lust* and lots of troubled thoughts the more the aforementioned romance closes in.
Besides, take into account that someone like SW will only use what she *thinks* "love" is (and everything related to it, like kisses in this case) as a manipulation.

Oh another note, I just realized I'm posting this chapter about Casta's birthday just after *my* birthday! I hadn't noticed before lol
It was pretty funny to realize, since my b-day "celebration" was also just a dinner with my family <("^_^)
Fortunately, that's where the similarities end; I wasn't hurt in any way, wasn't assigned any difficult tasks (kind of), and got to enjoy my day heh
I just went to the Japanese Garden, which is a beautiful place we have here in Argentina, had a great meal and, well, enjoyed it while I could since I had to return home a bit too soon to receive the electrician… So I kinda got a task, but again, nothing difficult lol

Finally, I posted without a final check, so if u found any mistakes, please, do point them out :D

Anyways, I hope you enjoyed this chapter, and see you next week!!

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Shadow Weaver had come to the conclusion that every time the sorceress was bold enough to challenge her to torture or punish her, it was but a test of that favour she had granted her.

It was a way to test her limits, wasn’t it?

Quite intelligent of her…

It had to be, because the other option was that the sorceress was actually a resounding idiot with no self-preservation instinct whatsoever.

Chapter Notes

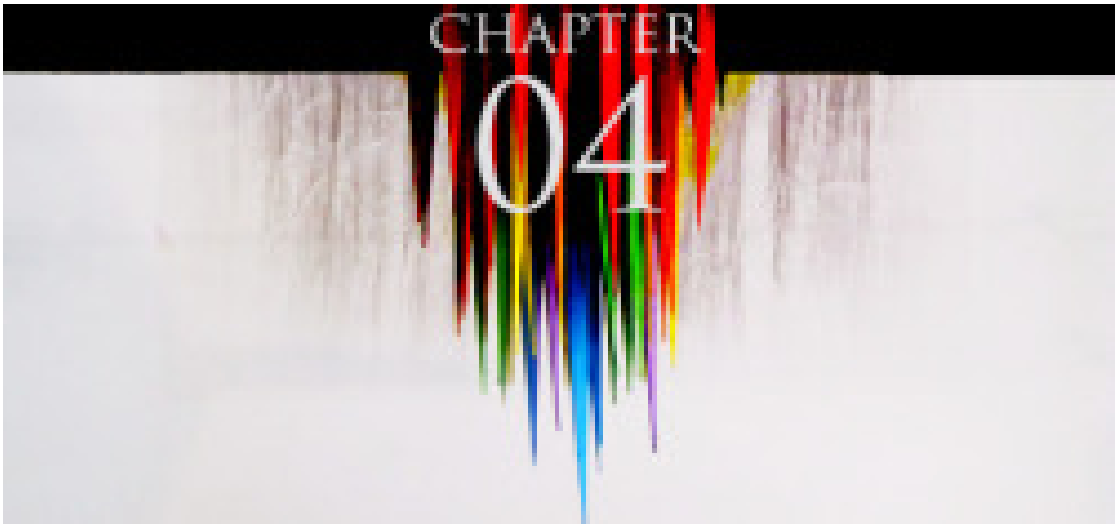
Alright!
So… since last week I totally forgot to post, I'd like to avoid that this time, so I'm posting it now, barely minutes after midnight XD

I really hope this chapter won't feel like mere filler, it's kinda… I don't know, not exactly important, but despite how short it is, I feel like it shows a lot of how SW's view of Casta currently is, and why it isn't yet settled. As in, her way of regarding Casta will keep changing, evolving, and I feel like this chapter shows it pretty well…

Then come the events of the next chapter, which further push that change but… You'll see next week XD

Anyways! I will let you read now! Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



The plan was in motion.

It would be a question of time, she believed, until Castaspella was fully under her control; with the illusion of freedom and safety keeping her boldness untouched. It was *perfect*.

It *should have been* perfect.

But it wasn't.

The Tyrant solely observed the sorceress for days trying to learn her behavioral pattern, yet there was none…

So she changed strategies.

Every time she found Castaspella alone, she'd usually come out of the shadows, saying — What do you think you're doing?

The sorceress got startled for a second as always, but rolled her eyes as soon as she realized it was her, and sighed —As I've told you enough times this week, I am just fulfilling my duties. Please leave me alone.

This was the second time she had found her in the library, picking up books and returning them to their shelves, but there was nothing in common with the first time; the people around, the time of the day, her mood, everything was different.

—Since when do my councillors count "tidying up the library" as a duty?

—*This* councillor offered to do so, especially since I take plenty of books out for the classes I'm teaching… to pupils *older than me*— she replied, without looking back at her, and mildly annoyed at the end.

That was so stupid. The tyrant had also taught pupils older than her!

It was evident she was just too insecure…

Shadow Weaver couldn’t let the opportunity pass.

—I see… You compensate for the feeling of not being enough by overworking, making yourself indispensable.

That was *so* annoying…

And Castaspella couldn’t take the taunting this time, she wasn’t in the mood.

Using magic to put away all the books she was holding, she angrily turned to look at her, crossing her arms in front of her chest.

—I don’t care what makes you so miserable to believe everyone is on some petty mission to appear perfect, but it does *not* apply to me— she sentenced, and the Tyrant was so surprised at her lack of fear that she couldn’t even interrupt her. —I’m compensating for *nothing*. I am *concerned*; I’ve been put in front of a set of classes where everyone is my age or older and I have to *logically* justify my position there. I-I haven't even graduated yet! Do you have any idea how difficult it is to fulfill this position you've *imposed* on me in these conditions?— she added, indignant. —At the same time, I know this library better than anyone, *literally*, so when I come to look for my sources for the classes, I help tidy up a bit, as I’ve learnt by heart where each book goes.

Silence.

Well, that was… certainly something.

Shadow Weaver was left speechless.

How was she supposed to answer to that?

Her first instinct was to *attack*; she could already feel her magic leaking and wanting to surround Castaspella, but the young woman was perhaps too angry to notice the darkness curling around her.

Or was she just too confident?

—Who do you think you are to tell me how to treat you?— she finally hissed, squinting at the sorceress as her power crawled up the shelves, about to fall on Castaspella.

—Opposite to you, I don’t think I’m *anyone*— she calmly answered. She was so calm it actually shook the Tyrant out of her anger enough to notice the subtle protection spell she had already surrounded herself with. —I just believe everyone here deserves proper respect, *even you*, despite being so… dismissive of others.

Right…

Smart.

—Or your magic has gotten to your head— Shadow Weaver taunted. —Very clever of you, but I could still break that petty defense of yours.

—Then *do it*. Go ahead. Punish me all you desire, then leave me alone— Castaspella let out, straightening her back, arms crossed in front of her abdomen, holding her waist.

—I see— she scoffed. —You're testing your favour again. Cunning. I'll take my leave.

Shadow Weaver had come to the conclusion that every time the sorceress was bold enough to challenge her to torture or punish her, it was but a test of that favour she had granted her.

It was a way to test her limits, wasn't it?

Quite intelligent of her…

It had to be, because the other option was that the sorceress was actually a resounding idiot with no self-preservation instinct whatsoever.

In any case, she finally decided to leave because there was nothing else for her to do there and, much as she liked pestering Castaspella, there would be other occasions soon…

Perhaps next time she'd catch her doing something a bit more interesting, or a bit less innocent.

But then it came to her attention that the books the sorceress was putting away were all about healing magic and potions.

Her classes were far from related to such topics, so why would she be investigating that?

It was suspicious, but it was also too harmless to be worthy of attention.

So, this time, she let it pass…

Castaspella, still at the library, finally breathed easy as the Tyrant left, yet kept her hands crossed in front of her abdomen, tightly holding her waist, and took deep breaths with her eyes closed.

Fortunately, the pain from that wound on her side slowly subsided, and she could soon return to her room… But the scare of Shadow Weaver's sudden apparition kept her heart racing.

Had she noticed?

Had she seen what she was researching?

Perhaps not, or she would have said something… Or maybe she didn't even care…

Whatever the case, she never said a thing the next few times she showed up.

Despite sounding suspicious every time, as if trying to catch her doing "something", she'd always disappear again without saying much.

The woman only went to annoy her…

It wouldn't really bother Castaspella if it weren't because she was trying *not* to let anyone know how terribly bad her wound looked.

After two weeks, it hadn't improved much, but rather worsened, and she had been trying to find something, *anything*, that would help with it.

Anything that would let her treat the wound without having to ask for anyone else's help…

That afternoon, after trying and failing once again, the young sorceress decided she needed a hot bath at the Steam Grotto, and took advantage of the empty place.

Oh, but she knew she's never completely alone lately, so she preferred to keep a towel over the wound even after sinking into the hot healing waters.

And she was *so* right…

—What do you think you're doing?

—Re-lax-xing… Should I spell it out for you?— Castaspella replied, gritting her teeth.

—Always so respectful…

—Because you're so respectful *yourself*…— she retorted, rolling her eyes.

—Funny— Shadow Weaver uttered. —My question remains… It's not common to see you here, of all places.

—It's a nice place. It was empty. And I want to *relax*— the sorceress argued. —Can you just leave me and let me rest alone? I really mean it— she insisted.

—Luckily for you, I have more important matters to attend to— the Tyrant accepted. —So I shall take my leave… Enjoy your bath— she carelessly said, walking away.

Finally…

Castaspella let out a sigh and sank deeper into the water, yet kept the towel still. She wanted to remove it, to see if the water's properties could help with the infected wound, but first, she wanted Shadow Weaver to be *gone*.

After a moment, she opened her eyes and looked around.

—Alright— she sighed, once she felt safe. She slowly sat up a bit straighter, withdrew the towel, and set it aside, hissing in pain again. —This bitch…

It looked *so bad*.

Disgusting and concerning, indeed.

If anyone saw it…

—You can’t be serious!— she suddenly heard, which immediately made her look up.

Shadow Weaver stalked into the Grotto in her direction.

Furious.

—What!? Yo-you were still there!?

She had been watching.

She never left.

—Why haven’t you said a thing!?— the woman questioned her when she arrived at the edge of the pool, angry beyond imagination.

—Why were you *spying* on me!? I told you to let me rest!— Castaspella asked back, panicked.

She tried to hide the wound, but it was too late. The dark sorceress had obviously seen the blackish scab that had formed around it.

—With that thing on your side, resting will *kill you*!— the Tyrant argued. —Get out of there this instant and put on your clothes. You need attention, *now*!

The young sorceress hadn’t seen Shadow Weaver so angry since the last time the council fucked up…

Yet now it was over *this*?

—And if I don’t?— Castaspella defied her.

—I can always drag you naked all the way up to the last floor— the woman retorted.

Was it a threat or a bluff?

Well, she would find out soon, because she did not plan on following her orders.

—Why do you even care!? I won’t believe you feel *guilty*— she argued.

But the woman didn’t answer.

She was done playing games.

Without a word, she pulled her by the arms and forced her out of the pool.

How was she so terribly strong!?

—Time’s up. I’m dragging you.

—Hey! Stop!

The Tyrant couldn't take a "no" for an answer, could she?

However, she didn't *actually* drag Castaspella upstairs. She only used a teleportation spell to make them both appear at the entrance of the garden on the top floor. From there, the sorceress saw Anya and a pair of sorcerers look up from their work and back at them.

Their shocked expressions were to be expected…

—You! Come now!— Shadow Weaver ordered, addressing Anya.

—Me?— the councilwoman nervously asked.

—Yes, you! We don't have all day— the Tyrant barked, before taking Castaspella all the way to her room at the end of the corridor. Without any semblance of gentleness, she pushed the young sorceress onto the bed and went to her desk. —If you heeded my advice from the last time, then you can still get your clothes— she challenged her, referring to her "suggestion" of learning the teleportation spell.

—Not completely yet…— she admitted. Grunting in pain, she tried to argue —And I was…

—Trying to heal it on your own like an idiot— Shadow Weaver interrupted. Right that moment, Anya walked into the room and she reproached her —I thought I was clear enough. Take a look at that wound, *now*!

—How did this…— the councilwoman began, afraid to touch the blackened scab. —Oh, this must have been some toxin from the Fright Zone— she realized. She then asked Castaspella —Did you do this? The scar won't properly heal now.

—I don't care if it looks nasty; it's the same— she replied. —I just tried to make it stop hurting and spreading— she explained.

—But almost got yourself killed! I warned you about that recklessness— the Tyrant reminded her, as she rummaged through some vials.

—And since when do you *care*!?— Castaspella indignantly exclaimed.

—That's enough chatting— she sentenced, handing Anya a few vials and refusing to reply. —Lay down and shut up.

Resigned, Castaspella lay across the bed and suddenly noticed the windows covered with bourbon curtains, which was why the room was so dark despite it being daytime.

—Why do you have the windows covered?— she asked, thinking aloud. Yet right then, Anya began treating the wound, making the young sorceress flinch and move away as she yelled —That hurts!

But Anya ignored her cries and tried to continue, making her shout even more.

—Ignore the pain— Shadow Weaver ordered, pinning her down so she wouldn't move away anymore. —Look at me; this *has* to be done. Had you come to us before, this would be less

painful— she reproached her.

—It *hurts*!

—Stop thinking about it— the Tyrant insisted.

—*How*!?

It was so frustrating for Shadow Weaver…

She would regret this…

—Speak about… anything— she suggested. —What was that before? What's your problem with my windows?

—Why… would you… cover them?— she asked, interrupting herself with a grunt every time Anya touched the wound.

—Sunlight wears colors and materials off— the woman argued.

—Sure…

—It *does*.

—I know!— Castaspella yelled, struggling to move away as Anya applied a hot liquid on her left side.

—Then *what* is your problem?

—I grew up in a windowless place! Now I live in a windowless room!— she argued. —This just looks like a literal *waste*!

Well, even if the conversation seemed quite stupid to Shadow Weaver, at least she managed to distract the sorceress enough to keep her from yelling like a damned soul.

She couldn't stand the yelling.

—Unless you want to punch a hole through the wall of your room…— she mockingly suggested.

—Shut up!

Always the defiance…

Anya visibly shivered upon hearing that and looked up at the Tyrant, scared.

—I'll let it pass because you're in pain— the woman simply warned her.

It took them a few more hours to fully clean, disinfect, and treat the wound, but eventually, it looked much better.

Stars… Shadow Weaver wanted to slap some sense into that sorceress.

But she honestly liked her boldness.

She needed her to be defiant enough to keep offering her useful ideas, so she better not punish her that way…

Or any other way, for that matter…

Only after a whole week, the sorceress could be considered to have fully recovered and, fortunately for them all, her brother never heard a word about it.

Shadow Weaver knew he would definitely take her away if he knew his sister had been so close to dying after saving her, and she couldn't afford to lose her key asset.

Not now, not ever…

Chapter End Notes

Hehe ^_^
What do we think??

Casta is pretty stubborn, isn't she? lol

And if you find yourself low-key agreeing with SW, don't be alarmed, it's just common sense in this chapter XD

As in, Casta *was* wrong to hide the negative evolution of her wound and trying to treat it on her own… And just as SW thinks, Casta is either too smart or a resounding idiot with no self-preservation instincts whatsoever…
Maybe both <("^_^)

Alright, that's enough!!
Thank you very much for reading!! See you next week!!

Chapter 5

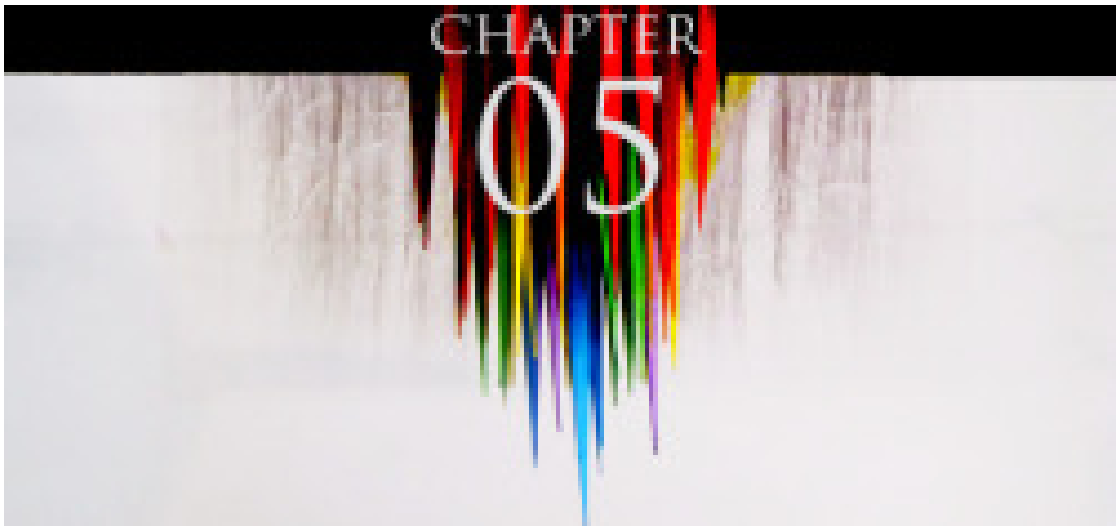
Chapter Summary

> No matter what happened, not even Micah would be able to take Castaspella away from her.

Chapter Notes

> Hello everyone! Welcome back to another chapter!!
> This one is quite an interesting chapter, imo, because certain dynamics start to cement; the events you're about to read are a direct consequence of *that* pivot moment the night of Casta's b-day, while also constituting yet another watershed, so to speak, in this universe.
> You'll soon see…
>
> But well, less rambling and more letting-you-read-what's-important XD
>
> Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Castaspella was back in her best shape right in time for a new mission, and it went *close* to perfectly. They still had a few issues, and almost needed to retreat again, but they kept progressing, impeded the Horde from gaining territory, and the Princess Alliance had no option but to leave Shadow Weaver in peace.

The Tyrant was satisfied.

How not? Everything went according to her plans.

And that little sorceress… perhaps she wasn't under her control just yet, but she was certainly not giving her much trouble either.

With her new favour she could have done *so much* to take advantage of it, yet she would only use it to, what? Make the citizens of Mystacor's lives easier?

What a waste…

But if that was her aim, perhaps it was an intelligent move. She was using her resources wisely without risking losing the favour that got her what she wanted.

Yet the bolder the young sorceress got, the more it enticed the Tyrant…

She had to do something about that.

—Come with me— she said one day.

Castaspella didn't ask questions and followed, possibly because she had nothing better to do, and they soon arrived at the garden in the top floor.

—What are we doing here?— the sorceress finally asked, curious.

—I have a proposition— she began. —The last thing you have yet to learn when it comes to protection: potions.

—And you plan on teaching me personally this time?— Castaspella questioned her, raising a brow, suspicious.

—No. You will learn on your own, and I…— the Tyrant began, towering over her. —I will test your knowledge.

—And why exactly are you moving so close to me now?— the sorceress questioned her again, unfazed.

—Clever…

Well, she wasn't so easy to fluster this time.

Perhaps it was because, back on her birthday, she had caught her by surprise…

—Look— Castaspella began, moving away while shaking her head slightly. —If you're somehow trying to manipulate me, then you better stop right now. That's not necessary with me.

—Is that so?— Shadow Weaver asked, hiding her confusion. —What, then? Are you afraid I'll try to kiss you again? Don't worry, I won't... unless you want it.

—What do you want from me this time?— the young sorceress sighed, guessing from that teasing what her intentions were.

Well, if she was going to be so direct, then she might as well be honest…

—What if I said, “you”?— the Tyrant replied, taking a step closer and lifting Castaspella’s chin with a single finger. —Out of lust, of course. Nothing else…

—Yet instead of simply taking me, you’re trying to seduce me; want me to willingly accept. Don’t you?

—This is but a courtesy, seeing how you have been of great help lately— she explained, smirking. —I suppose this is the least I owe you…

—Meaning… otherwise you *would* just take whomever you wanted?

—*Maybe*.

Her ambiguous tone made Castaspella close her eyes as she weighed her words.

It had been a while since her last relationship, and she did feel… *needy*.

But would it be a good idea?

Wasn't this… playing with fire?

Worse, even!?

However, the Tyrant made the first move, didn't she?

All in all, Castaspella wasn't asking for this; it was offered to her and she'd simply be accepting…

So, perhaps, there was nothing to fear?

Rolling her eyes, the sorceress finally admitted —You know what? I actually don’t mind giving you what you want, but I *won’t* do it for the "favour". Am I clear? I didn’t even want your favour to begin with. I'll do it because I want to.

—Yes, yes. It’s clear…

—My only condition… is that you don’t force me if I say “no”.

—I shan’t.

—And yet it sounds like you're nothing but lustful right now.

—I may be— the Tyrant admitted. —But you can rest assured that I'm in full control. If you say "no", I won't push you…

—Then we're good— Castaspella sentenced, letting out a shaky exhalation as she hadn't realized she was holding her breath.

Shadow Weaver inhaled deeply, nodded, and stepped back.

It was so unexpected…

The sorceress surprised her yet again.

Perhaps it was *not* the time then.

—Should we go back to the potions?

—I have a question first.

—Go ahead— she sighed.

—Why me? What do you…

—If you're asking whether you're special or if just anyone sparks my lust... then let me tell you: no one has defied me like you in decades, which I find very enticing, so you can consider yourself special for that; you're certainly different from everyone else here. But if you want to know what it means to me... I'll have to disappoint you, but I have no particular regard for this feeling. I've gone decades without feeling lust and I can go many more without satisfying it either, were you to completely reject me.

—I see. That makes sense. Tha-thanks for clarifying.

—Now, we better start with the potions, if you don't mind— the Tyrant decided, completely changing her demeanor as if nothing had happened. —I will test your current knowledge so we can track your progress.

—A-alright— Castaspella agreed, relaxing her body and letting out a sigh.

She hadn't noticed she was holding her breath *again*.

—Have you read anything on botany before?

—I have. But there was little material available at the library, so I don't know as much as I do about other subjects— she admitted.

—That may be because most books related to plants are not at the library but rather here— Shadow Weaver explained, gesturing at a bookshelf behind the sorceress.

—Right. It makes sense… Then what do you want to know?

—Can you distinguish poisonous plants from healing plants?

—Hah!— Castaspella immediately laughed. —That's a trick question!

—Is it?

—That's like asking what plants are evil or good. Which makes no sense because there's no such thing— she began. —The same way magic can be used for good or bad deeds, plants have properties that can be used for healing as much as for poisoning, depending on how you apply them, or how much— she explained. —I mean, with certain plants, its different components will present different chemicals. The same plant may contain highly toxic leaves and perfectly safe fruits, yet even the toxins of the leaves could be used to heal certain ailments if properly applied— she exemplified. —But not just that. You have plants known for their "healing" components, but they might as well be used as poison in large quantities…

—That's enough— Shadow Weaver stopped her. —You know quite a lot for someone who claims to have read so little.

—We-well, I just… I know *that*, but I can't concoct any potions, nor do I know exactly what plants have what properties, or what their parts are. I-I just know the theory I explained…

—I didn't expect you to know all these plants by heart either— the Tyrant clarified, rolling her eyes. —That requires years of practice with them. And having lived all your life inside that library…

—*Most* of my life— Castaspella interrupted.

—…You probably can't tell which of these plants are commonly known for their healing or poisonous properties— she continued, ignoring her. —It wasn't a trick question *per se*, but rather an attempt at ridiculing you— Shadow Weaver admitted. —Yet you're full of surprises, aren't you?

—I suppose my reply wasn't what you expected…

—Even so, I shouldn't be surprised… Now it makes complete sense that you could see the "good" in my dark magic like no one else did…— she reflected. Then, apparently lost in thought, she added —In fact, while Anya does find traditionally poisonous plants quite alluring, she is unable to see their healing properties like you do.

—Well, I believe you should apply this too… To people, you know? Especially to yourself… — Castaspella commented.

The Tyrant rose a brow at her, curious.

—Me? Whatever makes you think that?

—You must be joking…

—I don't think I understand…

—Look. Your methods are… questionable. And you're considered an overall evil person. Isn't that so?— the sorceress asked.

—Precisely.

—Yet the reason you got corrupted was because you wanted the power to face the Horde! A-and you are using that power to fight them! To help Etheria!— Castaspella argued. —So, don't you see? You can be evil or good, use your power for evil deeds or good deeds, if so you want!

—You can't seriously think I have anything good within me…

—I am standing here because of you, am I not?

Right.

—You're an *asset*. I keep you alive because *I need you*.

—I know as much, yes. But it doesn't erase the fact that you did something good for me…

—With selfish intentions.

—I am aware— she grunted, rolling her eyes.

—You're something else, little sorceress…

—Do not…

—I am not calling you a "girl"— Shadow Weaver interrupted her. —But you are at least fifteen years younger than me, aren't you? For me, you're a little sorceress.

—You can be so mean for absolutely no reason…

—Does that annoy you?

—Not enough— she defiantly replied, folding her arms. —It's actually amusing. The meaner you are, the more defensive you seem.

—How quaint…

—Is your little test over?

—It is.

—Then, unless there's anything else you want…

—Do you have anything important to do?— she asked, holding Castaspella by the wrist.

—Some training…

—I believe it can be delayed— the Tyrant commented, nearing her face and grabbing her by the chin.

—I suppose…

—So I can take that as a “yes”?

—You can— Castaspella sighed.

—Then allow me to ask something first.

—Sure.

—Why did you agree? Do *you* feel lust too, maybe?— she questioned her, mischievous.

—I'm- I don't know. I have no idea what I'm feeling, but you might as well call it "lust", yes — Castaspella nodded, rolling her eyes. —Not like it's important. Many of us have *needs*, it shouldn't surprise you that much…

—Fair enough— she smirked.

With that, Shadow Weaver took off her mask and pulled the sorceress into a kiss, which she quickly returned.

Soon, they were kissing against the bookshelf, while the Tyrant roamed her hands around Castaspella’s body, exploring…

It didn’t last long. And this time, Shadow Weaver didn’t take as much as she wanted, either.

But it was enough, like a test too…

The young sorceress kept her promise, so she could be sure from now on she’d be able to request her and there would be a significant chance she’d say "yes".

Otherwise, why would she be so willing?

Perhaps the sorceress had liked that first kiss?

And it seemed she wasn't the only lustful one…

So it meant this arrangement of theirs was but an equivalent exchange, right?

It was the first time she found someone like the sorceress, and maybe now she had secured her most important asset.

Now she had nothing to fear.

No matter what happened, not even Micah would be able to take Castaspella away from her.

Late, one night, Shadow Weaver arrived at her room in a mildly dizzy state, yet still poured herself a cup of wine from her reserve as soon as the door was closed.

She was… confused.

Delighted but… *confused*.

A few days after the events at the garden, the Tyrant noticed Castaspella hadn't changed one bit. That girl was- No, that *woman*… she was more than the Tyrant had expected.

A hidden jewel who had been concealed from her for so long.

Who would have imagined the young sorceress would become everything she needed when, just a year ago, she didn't even know of her existence.

Micah had kept her secret so well… he never even *mentioned* Castaspella at all.

Did he suspect she would do something like that?

No, of course not.

How ridiculous…

A new day began.

Castaspella got up early to make the most of it, and spent her morning knitting a pair of socks for her niece since breakfast and until it was time for her tutoring. After lunch, there was a council meeting, and a new mission was organized to recover a Rebellion outpost that had been seized during the night.

Once they were back, Castaspella went to the garden on the top floor to study the books they had there, and didn't leave until night fell.

That became her basic routine, with slight changes circumstantially.

Days passed, then weeks.

The sorceress read book after book, and soon was ready for another one of Shadow Weaver's tests. Yet when Castaspella was on her way to the gardens, a loud discussion called her attention, and she couldn't help going to see what was happening.

The door was ajar, and from there she could spy on the Tyrant, yelling angrily at a group of acolytes.

—…You do *not* choose how to spend resources! *I* decide what we use, and how we use it!

—Bu-but, Shadow Weaver. We needed…

—You do not take what you need if I don't allow it! That food had to last the whole month! Now *who* will ask the Princess Alliance for more!? *You*!?— the Tyrant interrupted.

Oh, no.

Absolutely *no*.

—That's enough— Castaspella decided to interrupt without hesitation. —Leave these people alone.

—Are you willing to take the fall for them?— Shadow Weaver asked, condescendingly, turning to look back at her. She hid her surprise well enough and only pointed out —You don't even know what they did…

—I heard it's about food, and that your issue is asking for resources— the sorceress replied, serious, standing her ground. —If that troubles you *so much*, I'll request the extra food myself— she offered. —But whatever reason they had to use more resources than allowed, I'm sure it's completely reasonable. You just dislike it when things don't go according to your plans…

The acolytes at the back stared in utter shock at the bold sorceress, unable to believe the way she spoke to none other than the Tyrant, yet didn't say a thing. They were too scared to even move, and there were two kids behind the adults that Castaspella hadn't seen.

Their priority was to keep them safe from the wrath of the Tyrant.

—They have given the children under their care more food than allowed— Shadow Weaver explained. —If I let this go now, what guarantees do I have that they won't do it again?

—Why did they give the kids more food than usual? Have you asked them?— Castaspella retorted.

—I have not, and I *don't* care.

—Please, tell us why— the sorceress requested, addressing the acolytes.

—We-we had to… The-there are many i-ill kids. The-they need it— a woman replied.

—See?

—*Medicine* is what ill children require, not extra food— Shadow Weaver argued.

—What do you know!?

—I know enough!

—I don't think you do— Castaspella defied her. —But I don't care. I will take responsibility for this, and fix it too. I'll request more food from Bright Moon— she continued. —Give me the reports and I'll make sure we're supplied with as much food as they used.

That damned little…

—You… are *lucky*— Shadow Weaver seethed, walking past the sorceress and out of the room. —The reports will be sent to your room. And I expect you for testing in ten minutes.

—Yes, yes…

The Tyrant slammed the door behind her, and everyone finally breathed easily.

As the sorceress went to check on everyone, finally finding the kids, she calmed them all down and assured them that nothing would happen.

She would take care of the whole situation as promised.

About a week later, the sorceress was overseeing the arrival of the requested supplies, late in the afternoon, when Shadow Weaver showed up.

She stood next to her silently for a moment before finally speaking up.

—I see you managed it.

—Did you doubt me?

—I doubted *them*— she clarified.

—Expected, I suppose. But I can be pretty convincing…

—Unrelated to how the Queen is your sister-in-law?

—Absolutely.

—Then tell me— the Tyrant requested, turning to face her. —How exactly did you get this?

—I filled in a formal petition— Castaspella explained, facing Shadow Weaver too. —As our allies, they have the *obligation* to heed our requests for help, and seeing how this was for survival necessities, as is food, they accepted my petition and gathered these resources in just a week.

—All by formal means? No shortcuts?

—None needed— the sorceress assured her. —One day, I hope you realize there's no need to be a Tyrant…

—What if I *like* it?

Castaspella didn't need to see her expression to guess she was smirking under the mask.

This was a game for her, clearly.

—I suppose I can't convince you to change your ways, especially since you seem to have so much *fun*… But if I can keep the people *safe from you*, be sure I plan on doing it the right

way— the sorceress sentenced, and attempted to walk past her.

However, Shadow Weaver hooked an arm around her waist to stop her, and muttered in her ear —You have proven to be very clever for your age… And I suppose you know by now what that attitude of yours makes me feel…

Of course…

The sorceress couldn't help letting out a breathless chuckle.

—So? Where should I meet you?

—In my room. Tonight— she quickly replied.

—Very well. Now let me go— Castaspella accepted, rolling her eyes, before attempting to leave again.

—But you better start measuring your words…

Shadow Weaver finally released her and, as the sorceress walked away, she briefly turned to remind her —You said you liked my boldness… now *deal with it*.

And turned around again to leave…

Chapter End Notes

Hehe! ^_^

Now, it may not seem apparent, but Castaspella's actions, and I mean defending the people and taking the matter into her own hands, is the watershed I mentioned in the initial note…
You'll soon see how that will affect the whole dynamic of events around Mystacor! In more ways than one, actually, but there is one more important than the others heh…

However, this time I have a question: What do you think? Is Casta falling for SW's manipulation, or is she *really* avoiding it?

Anyways! Thank you all for reading, and see you next week!!

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

> "Now, I will do everything in my power to make sure you start *helping* without being seen as a monster by everyone. That way, people will be able to see you like I do" ~ Casta

Chapter Notes

> Welcome back!
>
> I hope you're ready for more!! XD
>
> I'm not sure what to say about this chapter other than: Behold! SW's inner struggle! Featuring: the council being saved by Castaspella, *again*…
>
> Anyways XD
> Yeah, it's like 1am here, so I don't really know what else to say…
> See you in the ending notes! I hope u enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Oh, that woman was driving her *crazy*.

Shadow Weaver had met Castaspella outside her room, let her inside just for an hour, they had a *good time*, then the sorceress left, and now the Tyrant lay on her bed with an empty

bottle, restless.

She needed to do something, *anything*, to figure out Castaspella.

She needed to know what she thought about her, which would perhaps let her find the sorceress' weak spot. There had to be *something* she could use to her advantage without giving Castaspella so much power over her.

But what?

Perhaps…

—Yes— Shadow Weaver let out, getting up from the bed. —It's perfect— she muttered, rushing towards her desk.

She immediately began concocting a potion that looked a lot like wine, yet changed colors after she mixed some powder inside it.

After a while, the liquid turned transparent and the woman sealed it before settling it down.

With that potion, she'd be able to reveal Castaspella's feelings and finally find out what goes on in that sorceress' mind.

Now she was *ready*.

Shadow Weaver went to look for the sorceress early in the morning, and was the first thing she saw when she opened the door.

—Oh, Stars! You scared me! What are you doing here!?

—A little visit. Would you accompany me?— the Tyrant requested. —That's actually an order. Come with me.

—Right, right— Castaspella uttered, shaking her head and following her. —But couldn't you wait until I had breakfast?

—No. Because you will have breakfast *with me*— Shadow Weaver replied. She took her to an empty room where a table had been set, and a pair of steamy cups awaited them. —Now take a seat.

—What do you want now?

—Just a chat.

Castaspella rolled her eyes, exhausted, and brushed her face. Her disgruntled expression was extremely annoying, but the Tyrant had expected it. The sorceress was far from shy around her, and this time she had gone to bother her first thing in the morning.

She would be pissed off too.

—Alright… What do you want to talk about?— Castaspella asked, taking a sip of her teacup.

—It's quite simple. I want to know… what you think of me as a ruler— the woman replied, taking off her mask to drink her tea too, hiding a smirk as she knew the potion was already in effect.

—That's… a question, alright— the sorceress began, setting aside the cup. She looked nervous, scared, and now avoided eye contact. —I… It's… I don't think… you deserve any help from me— she began, seemingly trying to resist the effect of the potion. —Ah, you never… should have been made part of the council!— she then yelled, seemingly giving into the effect of the potion. —You always wanted power and nothing else! That's why you cast that spell and got corrupted! *You never cared for Etheria*!— she accused her, right before running away covering her mouth.

As the sorceress exited the room and slammed the door behind her, Shadow Weaver felt like falling, gasped for air, and suddenly opened her eyes, sweating.

—What!?— she let out, breathless. —What was…— she muttered, trailing off as she saw the vial on her desk.

She hadn't given Castaspella the potion.

It had all been a dream.

Of course.

The things Castaspella said were the same as Norwyn told her right before she obliterated him. And there was no way she could have known…

Ugh, cursed wine… she just *had* to drink so much…

Ah, but now, the Tyrant felt something akin to fear and decided *not* to use the potion.

Whether she was afraid of Castaspella's opinion being similar to the claims in her nightmare, or just not of her interest any more, she didn't care.

It simply wasn't worth it.

As afternoon arrived, Shadow Weaver had to call for yet *another* council meeting, although this time she was seething with rage.

Still bothered by that dream she had, the woman was *especially irritable*.

And the moment her eyes settled on Castaspella, her whole body tensed up, making her even angrier.

She gave her too much power…

—…And, according to our reports…— Daryon was saying when Shadow Weaver paid attention again. —It would appear our missions' success rate has significantly increased this year. Even our resource management improved enough to…

—*Enough*!? To *what*!? Handle the "ill children"!? That's what you were about to say!?— the Tyrant interrupted. —You all dare take the credit collectively… What a bunch of fools!

—The council is in all its right to take the credit collectively!— Castaspella immediately retorted. —Why does it bother you? Whoever takes the credit won't change the facts— she argued.

—You don't seem to understand— the Tyrant insisted. —They have contributed *nothing* in the past year! Disappointments! All of you!

—P-please, forgive us, Shadow Weaver- Master— Daryon pleaded, while the rest of the council looked away, ashamed.

Only Castaspella remained indignant.

So much so, that she immediately stood up, slamming her hands on the table.

Everyone turned to look at her, the council more scared than anything.

—This is bullshit! They perform their jobs as they should! Why must they ask for forgiveness now!?

—Silence!

That was enough.

Shadow Weaver couldn't take it anymore.

She liked it when the council begged for forgiveness, yes, and she wasn't letting it happen, but that wasn't the issue now.

The problem was that Castaspella's boldness reminded her of the dream.

She was *scared*.

But she mustn't show it.

She can't accept it.

—Wait! Ple-please forgive her!— Daryon exclaimed, scared when a mass of shadows enveloped Castaspella and raised her meters above the ground.

—Should I punish you instead?— she spat at the councilman.

—No! Do whatever you want to me! Punish *me*! *I dare you*! But let them all go!— Castaspella immediately exclaimed. —Your rage is against *me*, isn't it!?

Shadow Weaver looked at the sorceress struggling to break free, looking for a sign of that fear she had seen in her dream.

But there was none.

Not a trace of fear.

Only indignation.

Perhaps she had to listen to the sorceress this time…

Or not.

But still, she did.

For some reason… she did.

Shadow Weaver decided to settle the matter before it drove her crazy.

She dropped the sorceress on the ground and ordered —Everyone out! Now!

The councillors stood up immediately, and the ones closer to Castaspella helped her up, all while muttering —Yes, Shadow Weaver. Excuse us.

—Not you— she clarified, pointing at the young sorceress. —You stay here.

—Will you be okay?— Anya asked her, not wanting to leave her alone with the Tyrant.

—I'll be fine, don't worry.

With a nod and a small smile, Castaspella convinced the councilwoman to leave.

A pair of eyes on the ceiling followed the council outside but halted upon seeing the young sorceress linger. So instead of leaving, the curious eyes watched as she dusted her dress a bit…

Before she could move, Shadow Weaver appeared in front of her, forcing the sorceress to step back until she hit the edge of the room.

—Why aren't you afraid?— the Tyrant finally asked.

Pressing herself against the wall, Castaspella mustered all her strength to look back at her without flinching.

—Because I know… if you wanted me dead… you would have killed me already— she hesitantly answered.

So it's that, eh?

It was an *interesting* reply.

She was right… but how did she *know*?

Moving closer to the sorceress' face, tantalizing as if she were going to kiss her again, Shadow Weaver asked her —Why are you so sure?

—I…— she began, wavering as she was so close. —I just realized that… be it because I'm Micah's sister or because you need me, you just won't hurt me, or you would have done so already.

—This has nothing to do with Micah— she immediately replied. Grabbing the sorceress by the waist with one hand, and by the face with the other, she added —Since he decided to leave, I've lost all my interest in him. Now, my full attention is on *you*… Are you aiming for more favour, perchance?

—I *don't* want it. I've told you so already— Castaspella denied, looking away. —I would rather not have it if it means you will stop behaving like I *owe* you. Now, please, let me go.

Right…

Shadow Weaver slowly released her and noticed how the sorceress let out a sigh.

Perhaps she *was* really afraid, after all, yet wouldn't let that fear control her?

Ah, but she still wanted to know what the woman thinks of her…

Well, she'd lose nothing trying.

—Wait— she stopped her, placing a hand on the wall and obstructing Castaspella's path. —Can I ask you something first?

The sorceress was caught by surprise, not because of how she requested it, but rather because of the tone and the seemingly humble demeanor.

Well, she couldn't know with the mask, but it *did* appear like the woman was far from smug or proud at that moment.

—Tell me…

—What do you think…— she began, reaching for her mask. —…Of me as a ruler?— she concluded, revealing her face. She looked… somewhat defeated. Or something… there was something indecipherable in her expression. Castaspella must have stared for a moment too long because the woman added —Don't be afraid to be honest. I promise not to react…

Was a promise from the Tyrant of Mystacor worth anything?

She decided to believe it was.

—It’s not easy to explain… I told you before, I can’t agree with your methods, but I… still want *you* to be in power— she began, looking away occasionally. —I mean… I support what you do but reprove *how* you do it. That’s my problem— she further explained, now looking at her in the eyes.

—You mean… if you had the chance to change who rules… you would really choose to let me *stay*?

—I would. Because now I understand what Micah meant when he said he believed in your vision *before* the spell— Castaspella assured her. —And I do too. But I also realize that you let your hatred taint your initially-pure intentions— she clarified. —Now, I will do everything in my power to make sure you start *helping* without being seen as a monster by everyone. That way, people will be able to see you like I do.

See her like she does?

That sorceress… Her manner of speech… She could hardly believe the woman was just twenty-one…

Shadow Weaver slowly moved closer again, cupped her face, and whispered —May I?

Oh…

Castaspella easily realized what she meant.

But the way she asked, once again, took her aback.

And regardless of her hesitation, Shadow Weaver didn’t act until she got an answer.

—Alright— she accepted, breathless.

Much to her surprise, the Tyrant gave her the most tender kiss she had ever gotten.

Gentle, as a thank-you…

When she pulled away, Castaspella was shivering, eyes closed, and very relaxed.

—I must say I appreciate your constant honesty. But I should warn you: I tend to disappoint people.

Castaspella didn't reply, just looked away with a small smile and nodded while taking a deep breath.

The pair of eyes followed the sorceress out of the room, and a creature crawling on the ceiling managed to leave right before the doors closed again. The creature made its way to where a suspicious acolyte waited, and hid within their robes as they eavesdropped on the sorceress and the worried council.

—Oh, Stars! You’re still in one piece!— Anya exclaimed, as soon as she saw Castaspella.

—I told you she would be fine— Ekaterina reminded her. —If anyone can walk away unscathed from the Tyrant, that's our star defender.

—Oh, please— the sorceress dismissed them, blushing slightly. —It wasn't that terrible. She's just irritable today— she assured them.

—You're taking this too well— Ayax noticed. —Are you sure you're all fine, my child?

—Absolutely, please don't worry.

—What happened?— Daryon asked. —This is the first time you've been detained by her for so long. We… all have, but she used to be our tutor, we know how to appease her.

—Well, she was just… a bit angry, yes, but mostly confused because I'm not afraid of her.

—What did she do to you?

—Tried to intimidate me, of course. But I didn't let her— Castaspella explained, sharing only part of the truth. —I told her I knew she would have already harmed me if she really wanted to do it… And then she asked me what I think of her as a ruler— she continued. —It was a strange question, but she told me to be honest, and I was.

—What did you say?— Anya asked, exchanging a surprised look with the other councillors.

—Just that I don't agree with her methods, even though I want her to remain the ruler.

—You… do?— Daryon asked, shocked, and with a curious shine on his eyes, like hopeful.

—Yes. I think she only wants the best for Etheria, but resorts to *questionable* methods— the sorceress replied. —So, if we can counter her disregard for human lives, then we can better everyone's quality of life here. If we improve the atmosphere, people won't live in fear anymore. They will stop seeing her as a *terrible* Tyrant and start noticing how much she has done to stop the Horde.

—You really think we can make that happen?— Ekaterina asked, with a similar expression to that of Daryon.

—I think that's our duty as the council— she insisted. —To use our power to protect the people from Shadow Weaver's wrath, and instead let them focus on how much she has contributed to this never-ending war!

—Child, you're exactly what Mystacor needed— Ayax told her, placing a hand on her shoulder and smiling gently. —We thank you. And we shall do as you say, if you don't mind helping this old council.

—I only hope you can help *me* with this, and that you don't mind me disrupting the way you have been handling everything here until now— Castaspella replied, a bit shy.

—Not at all— Daryon assured her, glancing at the rest of the council. —In fact, I believe we should have a meeting to discuss how to proceed. With your insight, we'll manage to

“balance her out”, as you said.

—Alright. I- Sure!— she agreed, albeit nervous. —When would the meeting be?

—Tomorrow, here. We’ll tell Shadow Weaver we’re discussing strategies— he decided.

—We technically *will* be— Ekaterina pointed out.

—Right— he laughed. —Then it’s settled. Let’s retire now. It’s already late— Daryon said, looking back at the night sky outside.

—See you tomorrow— Castaspella farewelled, before walking away down the corridor in a pretty good mood.

—She’s… quite cheerful for someone who has faced Shadow Weaver alone like that for the first time— Kenno noticed.

—I suppose, yes— Daryon sighed. —Which is good for us.

—She’s *with* us— Anya remarked, with a tone of disbelief.

—Quite unexpected seeing how she was raised to see her as an awful Tyrant— Kenno pointed out.

—She has surprised us all. Excellent suggestion, Kenno— Daryon affirmed. —I was worried at first. Her relationship with Micah made me think she would be more like… Zosia.

—They never met, did they?

—Not that we know, no. As her brother kept her hidden, no council member could ever reach her. He made sure that all her tutors were as unrelated to Shadow Weaver as possible. But also low-ranking. Otherwise, he would have let Zosia teach her as she’s the only one who isn’t- wasn’t our Master’s pupil like us— Ayax assured them.

—How do you know that?— Anya curiously asked.

—Old fogeys like me have our ways…— they mysteriously replied, laughing slightly.

—I see…

—Anyways, this is *perfect*!— Ekaterina exclaimed. —We now have a way to keep delaying the riot!

—Silence! Don’t speak about that here…— Daryon warned her, his voice low. —But I agree. This will play to our favour. With Castaspella’s help, we can maintain things as they are for longer. It will give our Master more time to win the people over— he reflected.

—I don’t think she wants to, but maybe with us balancing her out as Castaspella said, she’ll be seen as a fair-ish ruler instead of a monster— Anya commented, in hushed tones. —They will see her like *we* do!

—People will never… share our opinion of her— Ayax denied, shaking their head. —We're talking about a woman who calls herself "Tyrant". They don't know her like we do, they never will, my friends— he insisted. —But this is our opportunity to make sure her rule continues for the years to come.

As the next day arrived, Daryon gathered the council after breakfast, and gave Castaspella the lead.

During the first hour, the young sorceress took the time to explain how she sees Shadow Weaver, what she has learnt about her umbrakinesis, and how she thinks the Tyrant is actually a key piece in the war. She elaborated on the different ways Mystacor had improved under her rule, albeit subtly, too subtly for anyone to notice. Then, she clarified she can't agree with how Shadow Weaver acted, casting the Spell of Obtainment and endangering her brother, but she understands the reasons and sees how she actually used the power as she intended: to fight the Horde.

All of that to explain how the real problem is mostly her personality and the way she treats people. Her condescending manners, her overbearingness, her violent reactions, and her obsession with perfection, all made the woman terrifying.

—…I understand why people are scared of even coming across her. Whenever she sees something she dislikes, she immediately jumps to punish it— Castaspella went on. —So we *need* to take certain matters into our own hands to shift responsibility *away* from the people and onto *us*.

—How?

—Well, last time, when more food than allowed was used, I took responsibility for it and fixed the matter as I could, remember?— she exemplified. —That way, the acolytes were free from any kind of punishment and, seeing that I, or rather *we* as a council, can protect them from Shadow Weaver's wrath, they seemed much more at ease— she explained. —They were more open to understanding why she had told them off; they could admit that they were in the wrong, even if they didn't deserve the way she treated them.

—So, you mean… If we assume responsibility for what our people do, they won't focus on Shadow Weaver's reaction and instead on the things that *provoked* that reaction— Ekaterina reflected.

—Precisely. She never discusses matters with us in public, so no one would see her fits of rage. And if we keep fixing whatever issues we have in the kingdom, everyone will focus on the improvements instead.

—That's a wise suggestion indeed— Daryon noticed. —I suppose we all have our methods, and if we share the burden, it might be even easier than it sounds.

—And with us making our people see that what they did is wrong in a… *gentler* manner, it will also keep them from doing it again— Ekaterina concluded.

—So we warn them that, next time, they'll have to answer to Shadow Weaver herself?— Kenno asked.

—I suppose that's a way, yes— Castaspella agreed. —Although, when it comes to kids, as they are prone to repeating mistakes, we may need to be discreet and keep their misconducts a secret from her. We should warn their caretakers, but never let Shadow Weaver know if they repeatedly mess up.

—Understood— Anya nodded. —I know she *does* somewhat care for everyone's safety and well-being, because she gets furious when anyone does something that endangers that… Even if it's just an accident…

—Which is why we *need* to ensure everything is *our* responsibility— Castaspella repeated. —We need people to see that, even if she's a Tyrant, she's still helping the kingdom in a way.

Chapter End Notes

:D

What do you think? (OwO)
If you feel like there's something strange about the council, you're absolutely right!

The "riot" bit will soon be explained, but that's not the only sus thing here hehe
Ah… but all in due time (UvU)

:D see you next week (or next Wednesday if you're also reading *Heart'Bit'-Burner* ^_^)

Thank you for reading!

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

Shadow Weaver couldn't help but be *suspicious*…

Chapter Notes

Hi, hi! Welcome back to another chapter!! Glad to see you again! (metaphorically speaking lol)

So! Today's chapter is… *something*
Mainly a photography of Mystacor's current status regarding, well, regency? I'm unsure how to put it.
You'll understand once you read it

Also, SW's internal struggle continues! It's just not-so-internal anymore lol

Oh! And something very interesting about the council is about to be revealed!!
Plus a little conspiracy? Kind of?

Anyways, I don't know what to say in these notes sometimes, so… I should just let you read now!
Enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Eventually, the Tyrant invited Castaspella to her room once more.

As the young sorceress undressed, she sipped the last of her cup of wine while resting back on the pillows.

Shadow Weaver observed her silently until she sat on the bed, and told her —Untie that bun…

She only chuckled at that and obliged.

—Is this better?— Castaspella asked, after loosening her hair.

Smirking, she laid back on the bed next to the dark sorceress, who immediately sat on her and kissed her once before whispering —Much better.

The Tyrant kissed her again, harshly, and Castaspella held onto her tightly, kissing back with the same strength.

They turned over several times as they pleased each other, sometimes simultaneously, and seemed to be fighting for control.

It was like a game in which either could win.

After a while, they lay down together, exhausted; Shadow Weaver rested on Castaspella's chest, and the sorceress absentmindedly caressed the Tyrant's hair.

—I can't believe… it's now a year since I joined the council— she realized.

—A year since I learnt of your existence… and since you provided the council with some brains, for a change— the woman mockingly said.

—Mean…

The Tyrant didn't reply to Castaspella's reproach, only took a deep breath and sighed slowly.

She felt very comfortable. And relaxed…

It was a *problem*.

Because, what if she ever *lost* this?

She couldn't get used to having Castaspella all for herself, could she?

What if…

No.

This fear… It had to be that cursed dream that still haunted her.

But it was just a dream. A *nightmare*, right?

—You really aren't afraid of me?— Shadow Weaver asked all of a sudden, while caressing Castaspella's naked chest.

—I am not.

—And you *really* want to help me?

—I do— she assured her, lifting Shadow Weaver's face to look her in the eyes. —But… I can see that *you* are afraid. What is it? What can possibly scare the great Tyrant of Mystacor?— she asked, giggling.

—You wouldn't understand.

—Really?

After a moment of silence, she admitted —You. I'm afraid of *you*…

—Of me?— Castaspella repeated, laughing slightly. —How can I scare you in any way?

—*You wouldn't understand*…

—Again that. Come on, try me— she insisted.

—No. I mean… you wouldn't understand because I can't properly explain it…— Shadow Weaver clarified, before resting her head on Castaspella's chest again. —I suppose… I'm scared of your… *influence*. And, of how much I depend on you now…— she finally managed to say. —I have to take precautions to avoid losing you. To keep you from leaving like Micah did, or from being convinced by him to leave…

—Precautions like… manipulation and seduction?

—Exactly— the Tyrant admitted, caressing Castaspella's side.

—I'm sorry to disappoint, but… nothing you can do can make me *stay*. Just like nothing my brother may say can make me *leave*— the sorceress began. —I *choose* to be here every day. I am here because I care for the people of Mystacor. I accepted the seat in your council because I want to make things better for them. And I help you because that way I can help…

—The people of Mystacor, I get it— she interrupted. —See? That's what I mean. You're unpredictable, indecipherable, and can't be controlled.

—And you don't like it when you don't have control.

—Neither do I like it when someone has so much power over me…

—You mean because you're "scared" of me? Or because I made you confess all of this?— she giggled.

Well, that was *enough*.

Shadow Weaver stopped caressing the sorceress' body abruptly and pushed herself up, saying —I think you should leave…

Right…

She should have known.

Hours passed since Castaspella left, yet the Tyrant was unable to sleep.

Perhaps she needed to distract herself a bit.

Then, she remembered there was something she could do, taking advantage of her restlessness.

—Time to check on the underground council…— the woman muttered, leaving her bed.

As Shadow Weaver approached her private basin, installed at the back of her room, a pair of shadow spies appeared at each side of her, ready to follow her commands. With a gesture, she made both jump into the basin, and clear images soon appeared.

At the lowest levels of Mystacor, her councillors gathered with some suspicious acolytes.

Ah yes, she knew them well…

Those weren't acolytes of the kingdom, they were infiltrated Horde spies. It amused her so much to see them scheme so carefully yet without any success. Meanwhile, her councillors did a poor job of double-crossing them, but somehow still convinced those "acolytes".

Who was more stupid? She didn't know…

Yes. Shadow Weaver was well aware of those meetings held with the sole purpose of planning a riot against her, yet she never did a thing about it because it was all too amusing to see her councillors coming up with excuses to keep delaying said riot.

They really loved her, didn't they?

And now they had a new tool…

—…We're just saying…— Daryon argued. —That Castaspella, as a new member of the council, should be given a five-year trial. She has already contributed significantly to Mystacor's wellness, and rioting now would hinder our progress.

—If you're really interested in helping our kingdom, you *must* understand this is not the time — Ayax argued. —Trust this old-timer.

—I suppose it's only logical— one of the Horde spies posing as an acolyte said. —We will allow it. But, this last year already counts as her first one… We will delay this for only four more years. By then, we're raising *everyone* against that Tyrant.

—Of course— Daryon agreed, bowing slightly.

That was apparently the end of the meeting.

She had caught only the ending.

But it was enough for her…

—Those lackeys Hordak sent are more stupid than I thought— the Tyrant said, dismissing her spies. —They just gave me *four* more years to make "significant changes", all thanks to Castaspella…— she summarized. —How quaint. With how much they always struggled to give me at least a few months… But now, because of that little sorceress, I don't have to worry about them for the next *four years*!— she concluded. —Ah… it's amazing how much she keeps benefiting me— she sighed, chuckling maliciously. Finally, feeling tired, the woman dropped on the bed and closed her eyes, groaning before admitting —She feels like a literal blessing, that damned sorceress…

Months went by one after the other, and over time, things in Mystacor slowly improved.

Just as Castaspella had said, taking responsibility for their people's wrongdoings kept the Tyrant from punishing the citizens and instead allowed them to notice and enjoy the things they had *thanks* to the Tyrant's actions.

So many things had the people taken for granted, but now they could see it was all because Shadow Weaver kept the Horde under control like no one else could.

However, at the same time, people started seeing Castaspella in a new light.

The young sorceress would always appear to help with anything they needed, she would gladly take care of whatever issues they couldn't take to the Tyrant, and she was known for protecting the sorcerers sent on every mission.

She was the one to whom everyone looked up to.

The one everyone could count on.

They put their trust in her. And what's more, they listened to her when she pointed out everything they had thanks to Shadow Weaver, which was the main reason for the Tyrant's image to have improved…

It absolutely did *not* escape the council's attention.

—Look: we *need* to be careful— Daryon was saying. —People are… quite fond of Castaspella.

—If she ever attempted to take power…

—But that's the thing! No matter what, she only supports our Master! She isn't trying to challenge her for power despite having everyone's backup!— Anya reminded them.

—But what if one day she does?— Ekaterina insisted, worried. —I trust her fully… But power can be tempting.

—I've heard rumours of acolytes saying she's better suited to rule and… I can't disagree— Ayax admitted.

—That much is… true— Kenno sighed. —For now, I believe we should keep things as they are. And, perhaps, we should ask Castaspella about this. Just to be sure.

—You think she'll be honest?— Daryon asked, sharing Ekaterina's worry.

—I'm pretty sure she will— Anya answered in Kenno's stead.

—Alright— he sighed. —We shall ask her then…— he accepted.

—We could tell her to meet us in a few hours, maybe?— Anya suggested.

—Of course— Daryon nodded. —After the meeting with our Master.

—Right! We should get going!— she realized.

—I almost forgot too— Ekaterina admitted.

—Then, let's not delay any further— Ayax prompted them.

As the council flocked into the meeting room, Shadow Weaver observed them take their places from the back of the room, surrounded in darkness as always. However, Castaspella was nowhere to be seen.

—Anyone knows exactly *where* your youngest member is? Or are you that disinterested?

—No-no, we're- We just don't know where she is— Daryon quickly answered. —Bu-but I'm sure she knows about this meeting, she should be here soon…

—Of course she knows. She does *not* need a babysitter, but you all could *at the very least* make sure your key-member arrives in time— the Tyrant insisted.

Before anyone else could say anything, Castaspella finally arrived running.

—I'm sorry for the delay!— she began, inhaling deeply before taking her seat. —I was studying and didn't see the time— she explained.

—See? With a bit of interest, you could have avoided this by making her notice the time— Shadow Weaver insisted.

—Please, tha-that's unnecessary. It was my fault— Castaspella argued.

—I'll overlook it this time but, unless your fellow councillors want you to be punished, you better stop dismissing their lack of responsibility— the Tyrant told her. —You *can't* protect everyone— she concluded.

—It's not about protecting them. I…

—Save it. That's enough— she stopped her. —We should get to the matter at hand.

—Of course— Daryon nodded, ready to report.

As they had decided before, the councillors stopped Castaspella on their way out of the meeting room to ask her for a moment, and took her to an empty chamber where they could discuss.

—We are sorry for this, but we have a question— Daryon apologetically began. —You have noticed how people see you, haven't you?

—I guess? I-I'm not sure what you mean…

—Don't you realize they see you as a potential ruler?— Ekaterina asked, more direct.

—What? No, no. I- They seem to appreciate what I do for them, but I-I'm hardly fit to rule! I'm not even… graduated— she nervously remarked. —Please, I've told you before: I *want* Shadow Weaver to be in power, just *not* in the way she has been, terrorizing our people.

—Listen to me— Ayax began. —You may be young, but it's clear you're a natural leader. You're caring and considerate. You know what's best for the people, for the kingdom… That's what everyone sees.

—Which makes us wonder if you… would ever challenge our Master for the position of command— Ekaterina admitted.

—I wouldn't. I don't want it— Castaspella sentenced with determination. —I am more than content with my current position, with what I can accomplish from here. And that's enough for me. So, why are you so… *scared*?

—Well, it has come to our attention that the Tyrant favours you. It would be… quite easy for you to make use of that favour against her— Kenno explained, looking away. —We *know* you haven't attempted as much, but we can't help wondering why.

—It's simple. I *never* wanted that favour. I've told her so. And… I really hoped it wouldn't be so obvious— she sighed. —I won't say I haven't made use of that favour, of course, but only for what I've told you: helping people.

—How did you… get such favour?— Anya curiously asked.

—I swear, she just… granted it to me the day of my birthday without any explanation— she assured them, revealing only part of the truth. —I've done nothing to earn it, I'm *in no way*

"paying" for it, so to speak, and I wouldn't mind if she rescinded it any moment.

—Well, you *did* save her life that day— Ayax pointed out.

—Perhaps— Castaspella sighed.

—I think that's enough interrogation. We're sorry— Daryon apologized. —And… once again, we thank you for supporting our Master.

The young sorceress didn't reply, only nodded respectfully at them, and left the room.

There was absolute silence for a moment.

—So?

—*So*… We can rest assured she remains on our side, I believe— Ayax told them. —We have all noticed how our Master not only favours her, but also seems… quite protective. Whatever the reason, I believe we can discard any kind of ploy from Castaspella, no?

—Of course— Ekaterina accepted. —I suppose I was just…

—Jealous?

—Don't tell me you aren't, Kenno.

—I suppose I am, but…

—But we can trust Castaspella; especially after the past year— Daryon insisted.

—I believe so too— Anya supported him.

—Then it's settled.

A few nights later, while lying in bed together again, Shadow Weaver decided to tell Castaspella about a little issue that had been bothering her.

—Have you heard about the Queen of Snows' invitation?

—I have. And I'm surprised you have made no preparations yet to travel to her kingdom for the meeting— the young sorceress replied.

—Because I won't attend. And I need *you* to come up with an excuse— she explained.

—Why won't you go!?

—I refuse.

—But *why*!? This would be convenient for you! It's a way of reinforcing relationships with an ally— Castaspella argued.

—Of course not. It's a *trap*.

—Alright— she sighed. —I won't tell you how to do your job. It's yours, not mine.

—So it's *my* job now, isn't it?

—What does that mean!?— the young sorceress asked, looking back at Shadow Weaver as she sat on the bed.

—Do you not aim for my position?— the Tyrant accused her. —Has the thought of overthrowing me not crossed your mind, now that the people of Mystacor love you? Or are you biding your time?— she went on, leaning forward.

—Stop right there— Castaspella demanded, realizing Shadow Weaver's intentions. —It's been enough for tonight— she firmly told her.

—Very well— the dark sorceress accepted, albeit reluctantly. —But, at the very least, tell me why you aren't plotting against me.

—Has the rest of the council mentioned something? Because they interrogated me about it a few days ago…

—They have not. But, this only means we all see *something*…

—Ah…— Castaspella sighed. —If you really want to know, I'll make myself clear. I've told you before that I'd rather see you in power, and that remains true. I don't *want* any more power than I currently have! I just don't!

—That only makes you more suspicious— Shadow Weaver insisted. —But… I can always remind you I am *not* easy to defeat.

—Good thing I *don't plan* on facing you that way, then— the young sorceress fearlessly replied. —Now, I suppose I should go.

—Seeing how you're not in the mood anymore, yes. I would say you should— she accepted. —But I expect that excuse for the Queen of Snows soon.

—I'll see what I can do…

With that, Castaspella got dressed and promptly left the room to return to her own. Yet, even after a long while, the Tyrant was still thinking about her words.

"I'd rather see you in power" she said.

Why?

Shadow Weaver couldn't help but be *suspicious*…

Chapter End Notes

Hehe, what do you think!?

I'm so glad to finally have introduced the Underground Council!
Hahahah I've been waiting for this… >:D

Also also, I really wanna know what you think about Casta as ruler -eventually-
She's really young now, but like, do you share the people's opinion that she'd be better fit to rule? ✍(◔◡◔)

And finally!! The big question: How long till SW's mental state reaches its breaking point? What do you think? XD

Joke, joke… or is it? :3

Hahaha, anyways, see you next week!!!
We're half-way there!!
But remember! This is only part 1 of 4! The saga is nowhere near done!
Bye! :D

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

She had to keep repeating to herself it was nothing but lust. *Lust*!

But the fact that she had to remind herself of it…

Annoying.

Disgusting.

Unconceivable!

Asset.

An asset!

That's what the young sorceress is.

Chapter Notes

I, uh, must apologize for how short this chapter is <("^_^)
I swear, future chapters are longer :D

Anyways, welcome back!

I present to you, another chapter full of… inner struggle XD

hehe

I mean, it's a short chapter, should take you 5 to 10 mins to read, but like a lot happens!!
In my opinion, at least…

Anyways!

Please enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Shadow Weaver's little tests at the gardens continued to happen sporadically, most times surprising the Tyrant with how much knowledge Castaspella had managed to incorporate in a short time…

Which made her… *thirsty*.

—Are you saying you're attracted to intelligence?— the young sorceress mocked her.

—I'm saying you are more enticing when you prove you're *not* useless or stupid— she replied, rolling her eyes.

She couldn't just be attracted to Castaspella, could she?

No, it had to be a question of lust, for the most part.

Her reaction to the sorceress proving herself, the way her whole body seemed to *need* her constantly…

It was certainly lust.

But then… what about the *other* part? What was it?

—Alright— Castaspella chuckled. —Will you take off your mask, or…

—Not this time— Shadow Weaver interrupted, wrapping an arm around the young sorceress' waist. —Do I take it you agree?

—I- Ye-yes… But, here? Don't you think someone might… walk in?

—Does it scare you?— the Tyrant asked back, tilting the sorceress' face up and leaning forward.

—N-no, but… I believed this was…

—Secret? Sure— she admitted, her tone turning mischievous. —But isn't it *thrilling*?

It made her sigh and chuckle again.

—As you wish— Castaspella accepted, shaking her head in amusement.

With Shadow Weaver already in her personal space, the young sorceress wrapped an arm around her waist too and moved her free hand down to touch the Tyrant through her robes. She then leant forward, closing the gap, and kissed between her jaw and her neck, right under the mask where her skin was exposed.

Castaspella had learnt how to fully please the dark sorceress, so it was easy for her to make Shadow Weaver moan.

She enjoyed it too, being thirsty herself even if not as much as the Tyrant, and little by little her concerns dissolved into pleasure…

However, the young sorceress was *right*.

Soon enough, councilwoman Anya obliviously headed to the gardens. Yet, right as she reached the entrance, she heard Shadow Weaver's moans, stopped on her tracks, and immediately found a hiding spot.

She let out a long sigh and rested back against the wall, blushing deeply.

That was… unexpected.

Anya had *never* heard the Tyrant moan, and thought she never would…

Oh, what would her fellow councillors say if they knew…

For a while, the councilwoman *enjoyed* what she heard, eyes closed, feeling she'd probably never have the chance again.

And once they stopped, Anya rushed to put on a cloaking spell so neither would see her hiding when they left the gardens.

That had been… actually pretty curious after all.

Their brief, aloof parting left her thinking…

What had just happened?

Since *when*?

And where there any *feelings* involved?

Castaspella had said she's not "paying" for the favour of the Tyrant, but what if that isn't true?

Or perhaps she wasn't lying and this is entirely unrelated to the favour?

If there were feelings involved, however… how would the rest of the council feel?

Personally, Anya couldn't exactly feel upset.

She knew she had no chance…

What's more, this only reassured her that Castaspella wouldn't betray their Master.

And yet… she felt so *anxious* now.

Perhaps this was something to be… kept hidden for the time being.

Fortunately for councilwoman Anya, it wasn't difficult to pretend she knew nothing; being an overall awkward and nervous person, she was always pretty jumpy around anyone…

So who could tell being around Castaspella kept triggering the memory of what she heard that day?

Who would possibly be able to guess her nervous giggles and inability to keep eye contact were related to that little event?

—Are you with us, Councilwoman?

—Ay! Ye-yes, Master. I'm sorry— she awkwardly apologized, being pulled back into reality by none other than Shadow Weaver herself.

The woman squinted suspiciously at her from the darkness of the back of the room, but ultimately said nothing and went on with the meeting.

—In that case, I'll take it that you have nothing to add. No supplies that require restocking or anything…

—No, no. Nothing— she promptly denied.

—Very well. That concludes today's meeting. You're all dismissed.

Quietly, as usual, the council left the room and the Tyrant remained alone in the darkness for a while before finally retiring to her chamber.

In any other case, she would have noticed something was off with Anya, like the fact she now avoided eye-contact when, since she can remember, she had never ever taken her eyes off of her…

But Shadow Weaver was too troubled with her… stupid, *stupid* "feelings".

She had to keep repeating to herself it was nothing but lust. *Lust*!

But the fact that she had to remind herself of it…

Annoying.

Disgusting.

Unconceivable!

Asset.

An asset!

That's what the young sorceress is.

An enticing asset that knows well what she's doing…

Perhaps *far too* well…

Ugh! *No*!

No, no…

This wasn't right…

Well, nothing was really right, being completely honest with herself, but this was different for the Tyrant.

This was *important*.

That was… probably the main problem…

The matter stuck with Shadow Weaver since then, and she could hardly think about anything else when Castaspella was around.

Inevitably, that meant their teasing was always traversed by the little subject of *what* they were doing and *where* they stood. Shadow Weaver insisted she had to be attracted to her power or status.

—No, I am not *that* basic…— the young sorceress giggled, confronted with the same power-creeping accusations yet again. —Whatever you think you know of me? Wrong unless I've confirmed it, alright?

—I have certainly noticed you're *not* like others I've met, yes… But that isn't necessarily a good thing— the Tyrant argued, squinting as she towered over her.

Shadow Weaver had just let her into the room, and *that* was how they started the matter…

Not like she minded it, but Castaspella certainly hoped no one would walk past the door in the meantime.

—You mean because that makes me so *unpredictable*? Or because it allows me to notice that *you* are a pretender?

—Me?

—Absolutely— Castaspella insisted, smirking up at the mask. —And one day I *know* I'll break through that façade of yours…

—Good luck with that— she scoffed, laughing sardonically. —Let's see how long you'll last…

—I'm not giving up any time soon. I'd even say *you* may give up before me and drop the act yourself…

—Keep dreaming…

That only made Castaspella's smirk widen as she reached for the mask and carefully removed it. Her expression then became smug, and she leant forward to brush her lips against the Tyrant's.

—I shall— she hummed, before kissing her fully.

The young sorceress wrapped her arms around the woman's neck and was immediately lifted by the waist and taken to bed…

Chapter End Notes

So… For me, "a lot happens" is basically:
- they are discovered making out,
- Anya *checks notes* enjoys it while it lasts,
- the question of whether there are feelings involved is raised,
- Anya does not rat them out,
- SW's inner struggle o'clock,
and
- the question of why Casta complies with SW's requests is also raised!

This will be important later on, I'm telling you…

Both the fact that Anya knows of this, but also the question of "are there feelings involved or is it just lust?"

Hehe…
I suppose you can guess feelings are developing, but, as I've mentioned in the tags, it's gonna take time!

I was gonna say it's still a bit early, but we're already starting the second half of the fic, so it's actually kinda close!

But not quite yet (UvU)

Anyways! Thank you for reading and see you next week!!

Chapter 9

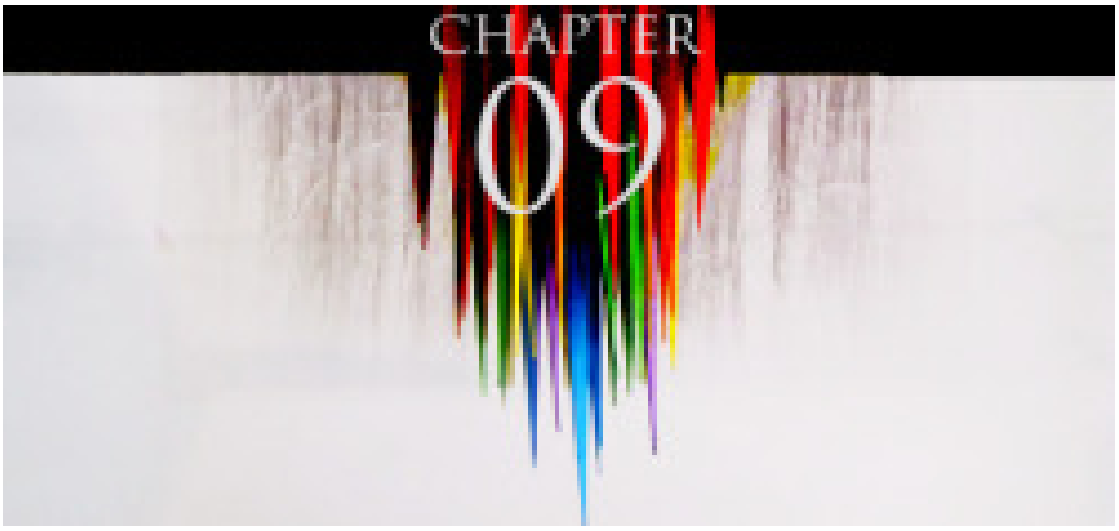
Chapter Summary

> "The corruption killed it all. Your scars aren't… superficial like, for instance, my scar on the side. No. It's… What you have is far *worse*" ~ Casta

Chapter Notes

> Alright! Welcome back! It's time for what might be my favourite chapter!!
>
> I'll introduce you to a little headcanon of mine, about SW's scars and how the parasite works :D
> If you're familiar with the concept of "Limiting factor", you'll quickly pick up on what Casta explains here… If not, I'll explain it in the ending notes ^_^
>
> So, without further comments, I hope you enjoy today's chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



Time kept passing, the situation in Mystacor notoriously improved, and yet… the Tyrant herself saw none of it.

Normally, she'd notice and dismiss how different the people of Mystacor behaved, how willing they were to follow the rules and provide any support requested…

So her absolute ignorance of it all was, at the very least, concerning.

She didn't care about it, to begin with, that much was true.

But she *should have noticed*.

So *what exactly* was the reason why she remained oblivious?

That was the problem.

What could have the Tyrant's attention?

Well, Castaspella would soon find out… even if she wasn't even wondering as much…

Shadow Weaver had no more options, so she didn't think twice before heading for the young sorceress' room late at night.

—Did I wake you up?— she asked as soon as the door opened, not really caring about the answer.

Her light white nightgown and messy hair made it evident she was likely fast asleep, or not-that-deeply since she heard the door.

Yet that was to be expected, and still… the Tyrant didn't care.

—It's… the middle of the night…— Castaspella yawned, eyes half open.

—I need your opinion on something— she simply replied.

—Unless it's a matter of life and death, can't it wait?

—I can always just proceed with my plan and possibly die— Shadow Weaver argued, gesturing dismissively with a hand.

—Fine, fine! I'll help— she accepted with a huff.

—I suppose I woke up the right councillor, then— the Tyrant smirked.

—But come in quick. I'm freezing— Castaspella urged her, inviting her inside.

Shadow Weaver walked in as if it were her own room, yet her surprise was evident in the way she inspected the place.

It was, as the sorceress had mentioned once, a windowless room. It had a simple bed at the back, a door that presumably led to a small bathroom, a desk full of books and pieces of fabric, boxes and needles, as well as other things she couldn't recognize, and the only tidy space was a vanity by the bed where she decided to set down the small potion vial she had brought with her.

Without asking, she pulled back the chair in front of it and took a seat before removing her mask.

Eyes closed, Castaspella took a deep breath to stay calm, sat on the edge of her bed, and focused on remaining awake.

—What a quaint little place.

—What do you need?— she simply asked, ignoring her comment.

—You have seen my face before, right?

What?

That made Castaspella open her eyes again, only to realize —I don't… recall. No, I'd remember if I did.

—Are you *serious*?— the Tyrant insisted, almost sure it had to be a joke. —Didn't you see it *any* of the times I kissed you since your birthday last year?

—I-I mean… It was… always so dark when you removed your mask… in your room, or the gardens… The-the few times we did anything in the light of day, you *didn't* take off your mask, so… No. I couldn't really see you before.

—Fine. Now you see— Shadow Weaver sighed, rolling her eyes. —This is what I'm trying to treat with a potion— she finally explained, pointing at her face first and the vial second. —Want to take the challenge to figure out what's wrong with it?

—It doesn't seem too bad— Castaspella commented, after looking at her for a moment. —Why do you even use the mask?

She couldn't be serious.

—Your naïvety knows no boundaries— she uttered in disbelief. —But if that's the case…

With a resigned sigh, the Tyrant slowly removed the first few layers of clothes in front of a very confused Castaspella.

—What are you doing?— she eventually stammered, confused and a bit groggy still.

—Relax, woman— she smirked, showing only her arms fully naked yet keeping everything else covered. If she hadn't ever noticed the scars in her face, then neither had she seen the rest… Probably she already knew, of course; that was why she came to her in the first place. But… with how sleepy the sorceress looked, it felt like she'd need a bit of a nudge. —This is Black Magic, or rather, the corruption it caused when I got my powers— she explained.

—It could have killed you! So-somehow it didn't… So it…— she began, staring at the scars running through Shadow Weaver's arms. However, she suddenly interrupted herself and looked up at her, now fully awake. —Wait. You called me "woman"!

—And that woke you up?— she laughed. —I suppose you will pay more attention now…

—Sorry, sorry. I just wasn't expecting…— she apologized, but once again interrupted herself and cleared her throat. —I… thank you for trusting me with this.

—Less thanking, more helping— Shadow Weaver urged her, fighting a blush as she handed her the vial of potion.

Trust.

She was not expecting her to take it that way.

But… what else could it be called?

Ugh… Not important.

It was just… a strategic decision; to get the necessary help, she had to reveal some information.

—Of course— Castaspella accepted, taking the vial and standing up to move closer. —Can I? — she then asked, waiting for confirmation to inspect her arms more carefully. Once the Tyrant nodded, the sorceress gently picked up her wrist with one hand, and applied some potion over the scar, making the woman hiss in pain. —Sorry! Sorry…— she immediately apologized, quickly leaving the vial and snatching the closest piece of fabric she could to clean the potion away.

But then she noticed…

It wasn't just any piece of cloth.

It was one of those dark blue sleeves Castaspella always uses…

—It just stung. You didn't have to stain your clothes— Shadow Weaver reproached her, rolling her eyes.

Why had she done that!?

—I… should have had something to clean it in case it hurt, anyways. It was my fault— she replied, dismissive. —Let me see something— she then said, before "brushing" all the way up one of her scars with some magic. —This is… so odd. And incredible. Did it hurt?

It was… certainly a strange sensation.

—For a moment only. Then it was… invigorating— she admitted.

—Makes sense— the sorceress nodded. —The corruption was just… literal consumption of your cells, squeezing the magic out of them— she reflected, thinking aloud. —Once it was all available for you to use, it must have felt like a sudden surge of power.

How could she…

—That's… exactly it. How can *you* know that from reading?— the Tyrant reacted, shocked.

—It's just the expected biological reaction, you know…— she simply replied, matter-of-factly.

But she wasn't satisfied with that little test.

No, no. Castaspella knew there was more to this. And if she wanted to help, she'd have to go *further*.

Following the longest scar took her towards the Tyrant's back, where she had to move aside her long black hair to continue… which she didn't seem to like.

—What do you think you're doing!?

—Easy… I'm just checking something— Castaspella calmly replied, letting go of her hair and returning to sit in front of her. —Look, you had a lot of luck— she began explaining. —Your scars indicate how much power over you the magic had. And black magic takes in exchange as much as it gives, right?— she went on. As Shadow Weaver nodded, she took it as permission to proceed. —Well, you're alive because it didn't reach your heart; your scars stop right around there, don't they?— she asked, pointing at the spot near the center of her chest, a bit to her left. —Likewise, you have control over the umbrakinesis because it didn't win your brain— she added. —The scars in your face only reach a few centimeters into your scalp, from what I can see; behind your neck, they stop right before the roots of your hair. And…— she concluded, now taking her hand again and moving it to show how the scars end in the back, before reaching her fingers or her palms, —You can use both sorcery and umbrakinesis because the magic barely got to your hands…

—What?

That was… new information.

—I need to ask you something— Castaspella sighed, looking down for a moment. —And please, be honest. There's no point in asking for my help if you don't tell me the truth— she pleaded.

Of course…

She didn't like it one bit but… she had proved she could, most likely, help.

If truthfulness is what she required, then, perhaps, she should grant it.

—Go ahead— the Tyrant accepted, after a moment of hesitation.

—You feel a need… a *hunger*… for power, right?— she first asked. As Shadow Weaver solemnly nodded, she further inquired —Have you ever consumed any extra power?

—I would require quite a great source. Something far more powerful than I currently am— she explained, shaking her head.

That made Castaspella sigh.

She could guess what the Tyrant would think of her next words, but she had to tell her.

—I know how this will sound for you, but, *please*…— she began, taking her hands. —If you ever find such a great source of power, *do not* consume it— she pleaded. —It won't help you.

What!?

No, no.

She couldn't simply say something like that and expect her to *go with it*!

—What do you mean? You haven't explained *anything*— Shadow Weaver complained, albeit without pulling away.

With another sigh, Castaspella held her hands tighter and locked eyes with her as she fully disclosed —I am trying to warn you: Black magic will take *every ounce of power it can* and give you "greater" powers in exchange. That much we established. *But*, it won't fully drain the source of power until it has a greater one. Meaning, if you ever find something more powerful than yourself and let your dark magic take it, it *will* drain your powers, *rid* you of your sorcery, and you will *depend* on that new source of power to do *any magic*. Even the umbrakinesis would be weakened. You'd have to... I don't know, use potions or the like to cast spells.

Oh…

Now that was…

—Fascinating— the Tyrant ironically replied, making the sorceress roll her eyes. —Let's suppose I heed your advice then, what can I do about these?— she insisted, reproachingly.

Castaspella finally let go of her hands and looked away.

She had hoped she'd forget about that.

—Nothing.

—What!?— she scoffed, indignant.

The only thing she came for, and *that* was her answer!?

After all that speech!?

—The corruption killed it all— the young sorceress pointed out, shaking her head. —Your scars aren't… superficial like, for instance, my scar on the side. No. It's… What you have is far *worse*— she explained. —I felt absolutely nothing when I tried magic on your scars. The cells… are all *dead*. All the way down your skin, flesh, muscle, and maybe even your bones, it's all been affected, consumed, and killed.

—I… see— Shadow Weaver muttered, frowning.

Silence.

While the Tyrant remained pensive, she had no idea what else to say.

She hadn't helped, after all…

—You, eh… can dress again. You must be cold— Castaspella eventually let out.

Seemingly agreeing, Shadow Weaver began covering her arms once again, and asked —Is there any risk of them spreading, then?

—I doubt it— the sorceress denied. —That was the price for your *current* powers, because your magical energy is the only thing black magic can consume from you— she explained. —For more power, not only would it need a new source, but also… it would render you unable to do sorcery in exchange.

—You said as much before, yes. So, my sorcery would be the price next time, just like my body was back then— she reflected.

—Precisely.

Castaspella let out a sigh and stood up, right at the same time as the Tyrant, and after a moment, the dark sorceress let out a smirk.

—Indeed, the right councillor— she admitted.

Blushing and looking away, she replied —Even if it wasn't what you came for, I'm glad to be of help.

—Of course you are— Shadow Weaver remarked. Rolling her eyes yet smirking still, she commented —I'm sure you'd lose sleep over someone's potential death.

Far from offending her or otherwise causing any indignant reaction, it made the sorceress laugh slightly and close the distance.

—You really are terrible at giving thanks…

—Maybe… Or I could just…— the Tyrant began, pausing a moment as she towered over Castaspella. —…Further assert my favour.

With a small smile, the sorceress let her wrap an arm around her waist and kiss her, promptly reciprocating for a moment before uttering —You're terrible.

As their kissing resumed, Castaspella allowed herself to enjoy the sensation like the first time… Those split lips had been such a surprise back then, yet after seeing them now, the feeling was different, the rough edges clearer. Meanwhile, her tongue found Shadow Weaver's fangs amidst a smoky taste.

Caught up in making out, she didn't realize they were moving until she hit the bed and the Tyrant pushed her down on the mattress not-so-gently, never breaking the kiss.

With their foreheads pressed against each other as they lay together, breathing through their noses became difficult, and eventually forced them apart.

—Where have you been hiding all this time…— the dark sorceress suddenly sighed, without thinking it through, and immediately regretted it.

—In the library.

Right.

She knew that.

But her answer was so serious that Shadow Weaver had no idea what to say.

—Of course.

—But, I wouldn't be the way I am if it weren't for that, so… you could just consider me to have appeared not a moment too soon— she reminded her. —Do you think you… Ne-never mind.

—What?

—Nothing…

—Say it— the Tyrant insisted.

—Would you… mind staying tonight?— Castaspella finally dared ask. —It's just that… this feels quite comfortable— she shyly admitted.

—You're serious…

—I am— she nodded, biting her lower lip. Yet she quickly brushed her shyness away, teasingly saying —Although you have so many layers of clothes on, it's probably uncomfortable. However… I *can't* imagine you with night clothes…

—That's because I simply sleep naked.

—I don't know if you're teasing me back or being serious— Castaspella laughed. Part of her expected Shadow Weaver to move away and decide against staying… yet she didn't move. So the sorceress dared snuggle against her, and sighed —Thank you.

—Right… Sleep now, before you blame me for losing all night.

Morning soon came.

It was just a couple of hours away, after all.

And the young sorceress half-expected Shadow Weaver *not* to be there when she opened her eyes.

Yet she was.

Soundly asleep…

But not for long.

—Did I wake you?

—No.

—Alright— she chuckled. —You can stay in bed if you want, but I'd rather get up now…

—Sure. Wouldn't want to disrupt your morning beauty routine.

—Mean…

Without another word, Castaspella got up and went straight to her bathroom for a moment, presumably to wash her face.

Meanwhile, the Tyrant only observed as she soon returned with a set of clothes, which she guessed had been left to dry off in there, and hung them in her closet before retrieving an identical dress and pair of sleeves.

She had, apparently, three sets of sleeves, at least.

The stained ones were promptly taken to the bathroom for a quick wash before being hung too, and only then did Castaspella get dressed, as if Shadow Weaver weren't right there, laying on her bed still.

She then proceeded to tie up her hair in a bun, leaving only the usual pair of loose locks framing her face, and finished without putting on any make-up.

It took the Tyrant a whole minute to realize she had, for some reason, presumed the sorceress to use something at least…

Why had she even thought about that, anyways?

In any case, what surprised her the most was the fact that she apparently washes her clothes on her own, and it made her sit up and ask —You… launder everything manually?

—Yes! I do it every day; I made it all, and sometimes need to fix some things, so I have to be careful to make sure they will last…— she explained, sounding proud. Then, having picked up the hairbrush from her vanity again, she approached Shadow Weaver, sat next to her and offered —Mind if I comb your hair?

—Why would you… Right. Go ahead, I guess— she reluctantly accepted, since the sorceress didn't really wait for a reply.

—Don't be a baby— Castaspella teased her, gently getting rid of the few knots she bumped into. —It's incredible how expressive your hair is… More than you, at least— she suddenly

commented, giggling a bit.

—What do you mean?

—Well, it shows whether you're calm, like now that it's down and as if asleep… Or if you're angry, nervous, excited… then it rises and floats above your head like a black flame!

—You can be… weirdly observant, sometimes.

—And you can be very ambiguously mean— the sorceress retorted, finishing up. —Anyways. I should start my day now.

—Right. So should I.

They both stood up, stared at each other in silence for a moment until awkwardly saying farewell, and finally left the room, each on their own way.

Chapter End Notes

Hehe, so!!

Let me start by explaining the Limiting factor in ecology according to our friend Wikipedia:

> Common limiting factor resources are environmental features that limit the growth, abundance, or distribution of an organism or a population of organisms in an ecosystem. The concept of limiting factors is based on Liebig's Law of the Minimum, which states that growth is controlled not by the total amount of resources available, but by the scarcest resource. In other words, a factor is limiting if a change in the factor produces increased growth, abundance, or distribution of an organism when other factors necessary to the organism's life do not.

So! My understanding of how the parasite works is that, as it depends on the magical energy to live, it won't take the totality of the user's magic, but rather just enough to guarantee its continuity; the magical energy available is the scarcest resource, the limiting factor. HENCE, when/if SW takes a new source of power, greater than hers, it's like introducing more of the scarcest resource to an environment.
It makes the population that depends on it think there's now more of that resource and consume more than before, but as the amount of that resource is not naturally greater, unless it continues to be provided externally, the population will end up consuming more than it should and cause its own demise.
Translating this to SW and the parasite, the externally provided resource would be the magical power, like in the show with the Black Garnet; this would explain why she depended on it, why she had to recharge. The parasite, having more power available to it, consumed more than at the beginning, which meant consuming more than what SW

had naturally available. As soon as she lost access to the Black Garnet, the external provision of power disappeared and using its power started to kill her.

But then again, that's just my opinion, my headcanon :D

Anyways!
I hope you liked the chapter ^_^ and see you next week!!

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

> Giving the young sorceress the time and space she needed to finish her studies and graduate was the least they could do…

Chapter Notes

> Oops! I ALMOST FORGOT, I'M SO SORRY!
>
> Ahem... tomorrow I'm returning from my vacation, so I completely forgot I had to post this today 😅😅
>
> And this is quite a chapter, I mean, there's a very important conversation :D
>
> I sure hope you enjoy today's chapter! See you in the ending notes!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



As months went by, things progressed quite well for everyone in Mystacor.

The council was usually on the receiving end of the Tyrant's mighty wrath, yes, but always behind closed doors, which gave people the *feeling* that the atmosphere was overall lighter.

It was *precisely* what Castaspella hoped to achieve.

And yet, with her upcoming graduation, she hardly had any time to appreciate it.

Her duties and studies were overwhelming her to the point she had skipped her birthday dinner, much to Micah's consternation. She had also been declining Shadow Weaver's requests lately, and it very clearly reflected on her mood; her irritability was more notorious each day, and the council had no idea how to deal with it anymore.

—If we don't do something *fast*, we'll end up worse than three years ago— Kenno complained. —All it takes is *one* incident and her image will crumble again.

—The people… You think they will lose their trust in us?— Anya shyly asked.

—Exactly— he nodded. —But just *what* haven't we considered!?

Well, the councilwoman certainly had an idea…

—Ma-maybe…— she began, yet interrupted herself upon locking eyes with Castaspella. —No-nothing— she regretted, looking away immediately.

—Ah… Listen. I am so sorry I've been of little help lately, but until I'm done with my graduation and all…— the young sorceress tried to explain, thinking that Anya was going to reproach her for the lack of input. —I simply can't do much.

—No one is saying you have to be the one to fix this— Daryon quickly clarified, placing a hand on her shoulder. —We're here to discuss strategies to keep her, um, *contained*. Whatever ideas you can provide will be appreciated, but it's alright if you need to go and keep studying.

—Yeah. We'll see what we can do— Ekaterina nodded, letting out half a smile. —And you can also ask for a hand if you need anything yourself.

—Thank you, but… I must do this myself— she insisted. —Perhaps… she just… has a problem we don't know about— she then said, hesitant. Yes, the problem was *dissatisfaction*, but she couldn't exactly say that. Likely, the Tyrant would calm down once Castaspella gave her attention again, yet that would be difficult to explain too. So, instead, she told them —I want to believe this will pass. Her humor won't be this bad forever. If we just focus on what we've been doing, she might… calm down eventually. Let's just make sure *we* don't give her any more "reasons" to be upset.

Her fellow councillors all agreed; not only was it the most logical thing to do, but also, they felt like they owed her. Giving the young sorceress the time and space she needed to finish her studies and graduate was the least they could do…

In parallel, of course, Shadow Weaver had been dreading every single day.

Not so much because she was always angry.

Anger was a feeling she could respect.

Her problem was the *source* of that anger, namely how much Castaspella's absence was affecting her.

It was driving her insane.

She *never* needed someone like this before.

Never!

So why now!?

What did Castaspella have that made her so… *addictive*?

And why was *she* being so *considerate* too!?

Since when did she simply "accept it" when she can't have something!?

Yes, part of the deal was respecting when Castaspella said "no", but… the *maddening* part was that she actually *hated* the idea of betraying her.

She simply couldn't find it in her to cross the boundaries she'd normally dismiss, because, for *once*, she was actually afraid of the consequences.

Afraid…

How disgusting.

How could she allow those feelings to develop!?

How could she let Castaspella *weaken her* like this!?

The more she thought about it, the more she agonized, and the worse it all got…

Her mind was wrapping around itself trying to… to what!? Justify something?

She didn't even know where she was going with all this thinking and reflecting.

What could she achieve other than utter insanity!?

Enough was enough… She needed to distract herself.

Perhaps some spying was in order.

If the underground council was in session, maybe she'd have something else to focus on for a while. If not, she could always send her shadow spies to the Horde itself…

The distraction worked for a while.

Seeing Hordak's spies struggling to keep the façade of "acolytes representing the will of Mystacor's people" was always so amusing…

But then they mentioned Castaspella's trial period was almost over, and how they were failing to keep Shadow Weaver calm lately, and it completely ruined her mood again.

The Tyrant's rage returned, and so did the insufferable mussing about the young sorceress.

So *annoying*!

But, alright. If it was so… strategical to keep Castaspella on her side, and for that, she *had* to respect her boundaries, then she'd have to figure out *another* way of getting what she wanted from her…

When was her graduation?

Perhaps she could accelerate the process, make her pass just like that, without sitting for her exams…

Ah… but she'd definitely hate that. She's too *correct*.

Then what!?

Wait about another month!?

It'd be a nightmare!

Ugh, she suddenly felt the urge to break something…

Fortunately, the month finally passed, after what felt like an eternity, and Shadow Weaver anxiously waited for Castaspella's return from her last exam.

She had had… too much time to think.

She had hated every second of it…

But at the same time, she had come to a realization.

She didn't deserve her help.

And she was going to throw everything away, admit this was all manipulation, and see what Castaspella would do.

That was it.

That would finally crush those petty feelings, prove how weak and stupid they are, and put an end to her dependency on the young sorceress.

She'd probably get no more attention from her, not *that kind* at least, but if she had survived the past months without her, then it was only a question of getting used to her absence for good.

And about losing her as an asset…

Well, if the sorceress was so petty to want to leave the council upon learning of her manipulation, she'd have to offer something else to keep her, then. She had to have a price…

Shadow Weaver pushed all her thoughts aside as she saw Castaspella finally appear at the end of the hall.

She looked cheerful; surely approved her exams.

—I expect you to have passed…— she seriously said, once she was close enough.

—Do I take it that you *trusted* I'll be capable? That's *almost* a compliment coming from you! — she giggled.

—You're one of my councillors and spent *months* focused solely on your damned studies. If you failed, I'd be most disappointed— the woman pointed out, reproachingly. —So was it or was it not a waste of time?

—It was *not*— Castaspella grunted, rolling her eyes. —I don't need you to congratulate me, but if you want me to fulfill *my* promise, at least stop bitching about it.

—Ah, yes. Your *promise*— the Tyrant smirked. —You're lucky I decided to take your word for it instead of…

—Instead of forcing me? *Wow*, I am *so lucky* that you decided to be a decent person and *not* force me to do anything— she retorted, getting annoyed. —I'm starting to question why I do this!

—Took you long enough…— Shadow Weaver sighed, trying to dismiss it. She now had the feeling the little admission wouldn't end well, so she decided to wait until *later*. She *needed* Castaspella now, like it or not; at least one last time. Turning around to go to her room, she tried to sound nonchalant as she said —If you *are* fulfilling your promise regardless, then we should get going… I've waited long enough.

—With how grumpy you got, I'd say you did, yeah— the sorceress muttered, following right away.

Breathless and tired, the women were resting back on the bed after a few hours of action.

Castaspella was surprised to realize she had actually *missed this* so much.

She felt devoid of strength and had barely managed to go and return from the bathroom just earlier, so she only closed her eyes and let herself sink into the pillow with a deep sigh.

—Don't fall asleep just yet…

—I am not— she quickly answered, her voice a bit raspy. —But give me a few minutes before you kick me out…

—I wasn't going to send you away— the Tyrant clarified, preparing herself and already regretting what she was going to say. —I need to talk.

—About… anything in particular?— Castaspella asked, yawning a bit.

—In fact, yes.

—Are you not tired? You sound…

—I suppose I have more stamina than you— the woman interrupted, sounding more serious than mocking. —I've been thinking about this. About how *not* doing this affected me more than I'd like to admit.

—I reckoned your anger was my fault…

—It was. And that only made it *worse*. It shouldn't have affected me so much. *You* shouldn't have affected me so much— she insisted.

Castaspella's expression fell as a tinge of sadness made its way to her heart.

Perhaps she had been harboring hope without realizing…

She shouldn't have.

—I… suppose you're displeased with me then.

—Does it upset you?

—I guess I shouldn't care either…

—Indeed, you shouldn't— the woman agreed, incidentally crushing the last of the sorceress' feelings. Right after, with a deep sigh, she went on —You shouldn't care because it'd be unfair. After all… I have been manipulating you all this time.

Silence.

Shadow Weaver half expected her to get up and leave right that moment but, as she didn't, she began wondering whether it was because she was too tired, or if she wasn't that upset.

—Can you elaborate?— she finally asked.

—What?

—You manipulate… well, *literally* everyone in the council. I need you to be more specific here— Castaspella insisted, a bit too casual.

—What I mean is… I *tried* to manipulate you like them, but I couldn't do exactly the same since I needed that boldness of yours intact— she began. —That's what actually helped us, after all. For so many years the council was nothing but a bunch of generals, if anything, who followed my orders while suggesting *nothing*; so afraid of displeasing me that they would put more energy into their excuses than into finding actual solutions— she went on, closing her eyes. —But not you. Without any fear or interest in pleasing me, you offered proper ideas; be it because you want to help others or just because you had seen what others didn't. In any case, that meant I couldn't turn you into another puppet of mine. That's one of the reasons why I refuse to teach you. Yet I still wanted- *needed* to have some control over you— she further explained. —So I tried manipulating you *another way*, by offering you something instead of influencing you. I gave you my favour, an opportunity to try and snatch power… But you didn't take it.

—I know.

—You know?

—I always knew you were just manipulating me. I'm not stupid. How would I not notice?— she scoffed. —But I honestly have no interest in power. And I thought you were just doing this out of… well, *desire*. I indulged because I don't mind, really, and… when you promised to respect it if I declined, it was quite important for me. One of the reasons I agreed, precisely.

—At first, I *was* trying to charm you, or make you dependent— Shadow Weaver admitted. —But I failed. And I couldn't stand owing someone my life— she added, finding Castaspella's scar with her right hand. —So, instead, *I* was the one to become dependent.

—You don't need to feel like you owe me your life— she assured her, turning her head to face her. —I mean, you can think of it as…

—As?

—Ne-never mind. It's… No.

—Say it.

—But…

—Go ahead.

—It's silly— the young sorceress argued.

—I insist.

—Alright…— she sighed. —Consider it payback. Or… returning a favour.

—What could I have possibly done to have you pay me back in such a way?— Shadow Weaver immediately questioned her, disbelieving.

—You spared my brother… decades ago. So now, you can just say we're even.

She couldn't be serious.

The Tyrant made an effort to push herself up enough to look at Castaspella, and gave her a questioning look.

She meant it.

—I won't accept that— she refused. —You're ridiculous for thinking like that.

—What!?

—Trust me. I *don't* care about personhood, but it's ridiculous how you're reducing yourself to being just "Micah's sister", when even *I* no longer see you as such— she indignantly argued. —You have *no reasons* to "repay the favour" in his stead. You're just being too selfless for your own good, as always…

Ah, but that selflessness of hers…

It was ridiculous, but also one of the things she *liked* about her, along with her irreverence.

Realizing as much made her suddenly hungry, and she leant forward to kiss the young sorceress for a moment without saying anything else.

—Does this mean you like that from me?— she asked, as soon as they broke the kiss.

—What if it does?

—I'll keep that in mind— Castaspella breathed out. She then reached for another brief kiss before pointing out —But I don't understand. How can someone like you… *like* my selflessness?

—And don't forget your irreverence and boldness— Shadow Weaver smirked.

—Even more so then! How come you *like that* from me if you always want to have control?

The woman let out a sigh and made herself more comfortable, resting on her side and keeping her head up supported by her hand.

—Normally, I *would* try to control you, which I attempted, mostly out of fear since those qualities would easily threaten my rule— she began, looking away. —But, you showed and claimed no interest in taking my place as ruler of Mystacor, despite having the skills and the express support from the people. So… I suppose I allowed myself to… appreciate that from you instead.

The young sorceress remained speechless for a moment.

Shocked.

She couldn't believe the Tyrant was being so *honest*.

And it all sounded so ridiculous!

—I'm just twenty-three and literally graduated today! I lack experience and I've only been in the outside world for three years!— she argued in utter disbelief. —A-and I'm not stupid enough to ignore how much you've accomplished just because your *methods* are questionable beyond compare. I'm *sure* that your rule is the best we can have, granted it should be less cruel— she insisted. —I-I guess you're not wrong… The councillors can be… a bit moronic, me too. I appreciate them all, but none of them, *none of us*, would be able to properly rule— she assured her. —The people… they wouldn't obey.

—You mean it.

—Yeah…— she nodded, looking away. —I just… I don't know how else to make you understand…

Another kiss, sudden and hungrier, interrupted Castaspella.

She melted into it after a moment, and tenderly cupped Shadow Weaver's face with one hand, feeling her hopes rekindle.

Perhaps…

—I think I'll have to revise your permissions…— the Tyrant let out, brushing her lips.

—Huh?

—Consider yourself permanently invited here— she decided. —Congratulations on reaching a new level of favour…— she smirked.

—You're unbelievable.

So it hadn't been that bad after all…

However, it had been quite unpleasant for Shadow Weaver; being so *honest*, admitting so many things, not only to Castaspella but to herself…

But then again, the result was… *great*.

Their little conversation had increased their mutual trust and, even if everything remained secret, it was more and more obvious that the young sorceress was under her protection and could probably get away with anything she did.

Rumours and theories about how it had happened didn't fail to rise eventually, but the general opinion on Castaspella was *so good* among the people that the most outrageous ones were quickly discarded in favour of theories about her great skills having won the Tyrant over.

In practice, things had hardly changed between them, except for the fact that Shadow Weaver would now delegate a lot of things to the young sorceress, fully trusting her criteria to handle

things.

And it was of public knowledge that she did most of the administrative paperwork in Shadow Weaver's chambers…

Hence, at the end of one particularly busy day, Castaspella arrived at the woman's room and made a beeline for the long couch under the window.

—Tired, I reckon— the woman said, without turning to look at her, having only heard her flop down.

—I didn't stop a single second today…

—You don't know how to manage time— she reproached her.

—I just put too much on my schedule— the sorceress argued. —What have *you* been doing all day?

—Things…

—You mentioned this morning you were going to do some recon, and yet you're doing it *now*.

—And?

Castaspella blinked a few times, processing what she meant, until realization hit.

She stared at a shadow spy perched next to the woman as if looking for confirmation and had the faint sensation it did, somehow, communicate a certain fatigue.

—Don't tell me you spent sixteen hours spying on the Horde with your Shadow Spies!

—Then I won't tell you.

—I can't believe it!— she exclaimed. —I feel used!

Now she feels used!?

Funny…

—How so?— the Tyrant asked, curious now.

—You dumped all your responsibilities on me!

—If you think *those* were *my* responsibilities in any way, then you're sorely mistaken— she scoffed, rolling her eyes and finally dismissing her spies.

—Oh, really!? Then *what* have your responsibilities been the past few decades if not the administration of Mystacor!?

—Spying, ordering attacks, coordinating missions…— she replied, dismissive. —And more recently, since your *bright* suggestion, providing cover for ambush teams and the like— she concluded, standing in front of her with a mocking smirk.

—You mean… all I'm doing has always been done by the rest of the council!?

—It *should* have. But you must have noticed all the outdated paperwork.

—Yeah! I-I reckoned it was because it's too much for a single person to handle on top of… everything else.

That made the Tyrant snicker in amusement.

She had no idea.

—You can always get that bunch of fools to help you, but something tells me they would only be a burden…

—No, no. I-I mean, some can help with a few things, especially those I have no experience with…

—As long as everything works, you may do as you see fit— Shadow Weaver nodded, turning to go to her desk.

—In any case… I will need your report on whatever information you could gather today so that tomorrow's scout mission goes well— Castaspella finally requested. —I mean, we wouldn't want to encounter any surprises…

—Who is going on that mission?

—I'm going with Daryon.

—Interesting choice. Why are *you* going?

—I have a few theories, I've been investigating the information we have on the area… And if we come across any enemies, I can keep us safe— she argued.

—And why take Daryon instead of Ekaterina or Kenno?

—Kenno is still recovering from the last mission, and Ekaterina is actually in Bright Moon planning that outpost-recovery operation we've been trying to sort out for a while now.

—I see.

With that, as Shadow Weaver sat on her desk, Castaspella finally pushed herself up, yawned, and decided it was time to go to sleep.

She wasn't even hungry…

However, before leaving, and after hesitating for a moment, she first went to bid the Tyrant farewell.

Half expecting her to complain, the young sorceress placed her hands on the woman's shoulders, kissed the top of her head briefly, and quietly walked away.

Chapter End Notes

Well ^_^

Casta's growing in power, isn't she? Hehe

What do you think of this development?

And congrats Casta! She has graduated!! ＼(^o^)／

XD
Anyways!

Mystacor is progressing! Casta is progressing! SW is... progressing? I think? Lol

See you next week for moooooreeeee!!

Chapter 11

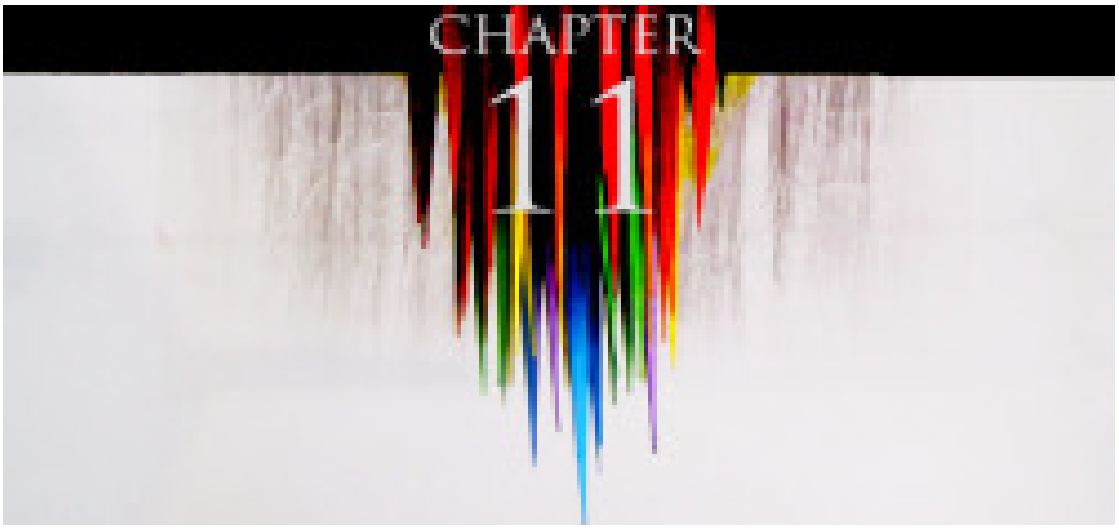
Chapter Summary

> "Oh! Oh! Can I tell this part?" ~ Casta
> "Go ahead…" ~ SW

Chapter Notes

> Hi everyone! Welcome back! :D
>
> Today's chapter is brought to you by: Casta being a silly little sorceress 🤭
>
> Honestly, she's almost adorable in this chapter lol
>
> ~~Not like SW would ever say that, nope…~~
>
> Ahem!
>
> Ok, just, I'll let you read! Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



The scout mission Castaspella and Daryon carried out was… not that successful, yet not an utter failure either.

However, since they returned muddied from head to toe, it gave everyone the impression it had been quite a challenge…

The council shivered just thinking about what would be the Tyrant's reaction to their report. Daryon didn't hesitate to assure everyone it hadn't been that bad, but Castaspella behaved jumpy and nervous since their return, which made her fellow councillors hesitant.

And yet, her problem wasn't remotely related to the result of their mission or the report they had to give Shadow Weaver.

No.

Her concern was, surprisingly, being *seen* by the Tyrant before she had a chance to clean up. The only reason why she wasn't locked up in her bathroom already was that she *had* to write the pertinent documents immediately for the others to read and be ready before the formal report.

And, with how silly her problem was, she refused to let anyone know, which meant having to avoid Shadow Weaver on her own.

It would have been so much easier if she had told the council… They would have covered for her.

Instead, she awkwardly excused herself whenever there was *a chance* that the woman would appear, leaving the councillors completely confused.

—Did she just…— Anya began, after watching the young sorceress struggle to teleport away.

—She did. *Again*. But why?— Ekaterina wondered, looking at the rest as if they could answer.

—I hear Shadow Weaver coming. Maybe that?

—Again: *Why*? She's just writing her report.

—She must have her reasons— Daryon dismissively said, right before the Tyrant showed up.

—You look like a mess— she uttered, first thing. —Get yourself cleaned up before the meeting.

—Of course, Master. I-I was…

—I don't care what you were doing. Go.

—Yes— he complied, lowering his head.

As he walked away, the Tyrant turned to the rest of the council and inquired —Why are you not revising the report?

—It's not done yet. Castaspella is still writing it— Ayax calmly replied.

—The meeting will *not* be delayed, so you better make sure she's not losing time.

—No-no! She's writing it!— Anya nervously assured her. —Just… not here.

—It doesn't matter *where* she writes it, as long as you all are properly informed in time— she rebuked. —I will *not* tolerate any more displays of mediocrity from you all. Am I clear?

—Yes, Master— they all nodded in unison.

Shadow Weaver was now curious, to say the least.

It surprised her that Castaspella was stalling since she's the one who always insists on giving her fellow councillors enough time to get informed…

What could she be doing?

It occurred to her that she was probably in the same state as Daryon, yet *knowing* the sorceress, which was saying a lot, she'd normally refuse to do anything before having the report ready for the council, arguing that cleaning herself up could wait…

Unless the fool was hurt and hiding it from everyone?

Thinking about that utter idiot doing as much suddenly infuriated the woman, so she returned to her room to search for the sorceress with her spies.

She found her right when she finished the famous report, and observed in her basin as she rushed to hand it to the council before nervously struggling to cast a teleportation spell, presumably to go back to her room.

Well, at least she *wasn't* hurt.

But then, she couldn't even imagine why she was sneaking around like that.

Or… she could.

Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes so hard it made her head hurt.

How ridiculous…

By the time Castaspella left her room, now refreshed, looking prim and proper, it was already time to go to the meeting. However, the Tyrant materialized in front of her in the empty hall.

—Fuck!— the sorceress gasped, startled. —Don't *do* that!

—What was all that circus earlier?— she asked, ignoring her complaint.

—Wha-what do you mean?

—Did you or did you *not* make all kinds of efforts to avoid me after returning from the mission?

—I-I don't know what you mean— Castaspella stammered, nervously brushing one of her locks of hair. —I just wrote the documentation for the council and took a bath…

—Don't bother; I saw you with my spies— she interrupted, waving a hand and summoning a shadow spy to her side. —I saw you sneaking around to handle the report, and you looked almost paranoid when trying to teleport back to your room…

—I- Um, well…— the young sorceress hesitated, blushing. There was no point in hiding it anymore. She had seen her after all… —I just didn't want you to see me in that state— she mumbled.

—You're joking.

—No…

—Why?

—I-I looked awful. Disgusting…

She couldn't be *serious*!

Shadow Weaver was so baffled by its ridiculousness that she felt the urge to prove just how stupid that had been.

—I've seen you looking like a mess from just getting out of bed, sitting four hours straight on my desk, reading reports and making occasional notes, and then stretching as you *finally* stand to get some breakfast, *still looking like a mess*— she casually pointed out. —Do you *really* think I'd be somehow disgusted because you were covered in mud?— she insisted, rolling her eyes. However, she immediately regretted saying all of that seeing Castaspella blush. That sounded less mean than intended and she had probably found it "sweet". Hence, she immediately smirked mockingly as she added —You could say I'm used to your uglier side.

That was more like her…

With a deadpan expression, the young sorceress said —Give me a moment, I need to update my record of times you've completely ruined with a mean comment something sweet you had just said.

So she had noticed!

—I'm *very* creative, didn't you say that?— the Tyrant laughed, amused. But… she had to be mocking her back, right? As if it were a common occurrence… —You don't really have a record, do you?— she inquired, disbelieving.

—I actually do— she replied, with a smug look. Turning to the shadow spy that was still hovering next to the dark sorceress, she spoke, with a commanding tone, —Hey you! How many times has it been now?

It wouldn't answer to her, right!?

It *shouldn't* answer… Especially not something so ridiculous!

Except that it did.

Bending part of its "body", it made the shape of a number.

Fifty-two.

What the heck was going on!?

As Castaspella laughed whole-heartedly, Shadow Weaver stared in shock for a moment before dismissing the shadow spy, in utter disbelief.

The young sorceress gave her a smug look while raising a brow, all too proud, it seemed.

But the Tyrant only cared about one thing now.

—*How* did you do that!?

Now it was Castaspella's turn to be shocked.

—Wait. You don't even know how your own powers work?— she asked, eyes wide open.

—Do *you* know!?— she asked back, indignant. —There's not exactly a manual of umbrakinesis. Just a few studies on the subject— she pointed out.

—Well, then— the sorceress snickered. —I suppose I just *accidentally* discovered that your shadow imps will answer to anyone's command if ordered not-so-gently…

—And *how* did you discover that?

—By mere chance— she replied, shaking her head. —I just… I was angry, frustrated, one of your imps was there and I yelled at it not to stare at me; that if it wanted to be useful, then it should bring Ayax to me…— she began. —It left. I thought it had just disappeared or something. But, moments later, it returned with them— she concluded.

Huh…

Curious.

But she was starting to get annoyed.

How could she not know!?

How long had this been happening?

—So even Ayax knows you can control them, but I didn't?— she scoffed.

—No, no. They still think you sent the imp to bring them to me— she promptly replied. —I haven't really used their help that much; just when I'm working in your room…

Alright, that wasn't that bad.

This meant the sorceress had enough brains to use all resources at her disposition, as the Tyrant intended.

But…

After thinking a moment, she decided —Don't tell anyone, then. And, of course, if you want to have their assistance, I suppose I don't mind. They are tools, after all…

—Tha-thanks— Castaspella sighed, blushing and toying with her hair again.

—Now we should get going.

—Yes! Everyone must be in the council room already!

—Then hurry up, I won't wait for you— Shadow Weaver lied, before teleporting away.

—Bitch!

She just had to…

The sorceress fumbled a bit before managing to properly draw the spell, but in the end, teleported into the council room just in time.

The subject of the meeting was the special scout mission carried out by Castaspella and Daryon, since regular scouts had claimed to be unable to explore that particular area of the Whispering Woods as it made them feel sick.

The councilman solemnly explained —Although it doesn't bring any advantages against the Horde, at the very least we are now well aware of the characteristics of that area. It's an important magical location, that…

—Oh! Oh!— Castaspella interrupted. —Can I tell this part?— she requested, quite eager.

Silent, Daryon only gave Shadow Weaver a questioning look, and the woman sighed —Go ahead…

—As you know, the Whispering Woods is a mysterious region, full of magic beyond our imagination— she began, dramatic. —That area is one of its magical grooves, an epicenter of

powerful energy where ancient creatures have been in deep slumber for centuries…— she went on, trying to sound mysterious and enticing.

But the Tyrant was less than impressed and interrupted —You're taking too long…

—Oh, come on! I almost got eaten by a plant! I deserve to take my time explaining!— she complained.

She *what*!?

—Oh, Stars!— Anya gasped, covering her mouth. —Are you alright!?

—We had to fight a few plants, that's true, but there was no danger— Daryon promptly replied.

—Wait, so… you found a groove full of magical energy, and creatures that we don't know of? — Ekaterina asked, curious.

—Correct! Or rather, I'd say they are creatures we thought extinct.

—Right. The report mentioned the animals you saw are mentioned in old investigations— Ayax recalled. —You quoted them, but we couldn't look for them yet.

—Oh, I can always find them for you later if you're interested— Castaspella assured them.

—Back to the matter at hand…— Shadow Weaver ordered, calling their attention. —We have no time for this discussion.

—Maybe if you allowed me to finish, they wouldn't have to ask questions and derail the report— the young sorceress reproached her, surprising the council.

They all tensed up, holding their breath as they expected the Tyrant to lash out at her…

But she didn't.

Instead, she allowed her to go on.

—Get to the point.

—Right. So: It seems like the creatures, both animals and plants, have been slumbering there for centuries. And our presence must have caused a disturbance, which made that plant suddenly attack us when we got too close to the sleeping animals— Castaspella resumed. —I understand they were protecting them.

—I would have probably blasted that plant with fire if she hadn't stopped me— Daryon admitted.

—But that would have made it worse— the sorceress quickly clarified. —The point is: none of that unsettled the scouts.

—Then why are they unable to enter that area?— Kenno asked, confused.

—The key to understanding that strange phenomenon is finding out *why* those ancestral creatures are there— she replied. —As you read my theory I'll only go over it briefly: I believe those grooves are overloaded with magical energy, enough that it kept them alive, albeit in slumber, for centuries. The amount of energy required for that is so massive that it must have been too much for our scouts to bear— she explained. —After all, by your prerogative, the scouts are always the weakest of our acolytes— she then reproached Shadow Weaver.

—So they can't bear the raw magic saturating the air there— the Tyrant reflected.

—Exactly. They perceive it because of their connection with sorcery, but it feels like a weight on them since they lack enough resistance— the young sorceress nodded. Almost immediately, she noticed what little of the woman's expression could be figured out despite the mask and the darkness, and it set off all the alarms in her head. Without thinking, she stood up, slammed her hands on the table, and seriously stated —You *cannot* take that magic.

Shadow Weaver slowly stood up, approached the council, and leant forward slightly in front of Castaspella.

—I do not care about your morals— she stated.

—You're not understanding— the young sorceress denied, shaking her head. But perhaps, it wasn't a good idea to disclose everything right that moment. —Should I elaborate while everyone's here?

Raising a brow, and hoping she took the hint, Castaspella waited for the Tyrant to decide.

She did, in fact, realize what she meant.

—Everyone, get out— Shadow Weaver finally said.

—I'm not leaving until I convince you that power is *not* for you to take— Castaspella muttered.

This was about the conversation they had that night, when she went to consult her about treating her scars…

Then private would definitely be better.

Alright then.

Raising her voice, she ordered —She will finish reporting alone. Everyone else, get *out*.

The council certainly didn't want to leave her alone… But they had no choice.

Castaspella wouldn't back down, and the Tyrant had given an order.

Swallowing nervously, Daryon gestured at the rest to start moving, and they all reluctantly left the room.

However, after a moment of hesitating by the door, Ekaterina decided to stay and try to eavesdrop; as soon as the others noticed, they joined her.

It was mostly out of concern, yet they had to admit they were also quite curious.

But what if they got caught!?

Anya trembled at the thought, but her curiosity got the best of her in the end…

—First of all— Castaspella began. —It is actually impossible to extract the magic from that place. It's not… the same energy we can manipulate with sorcery. It's raw magical energy stuck in some sort of limbo that makes it inaccessible to us— she elaborated. Then, letting out a sigh, she walked around the table to approach the woman. With a lower tone, and showing her concern, she reminded her —Besides, even if you found a way to take it, I already explained to you why you mustn't take any more power.

—And what if I want to take the risk? You clearly don't understand what this means to me. What I'm willing to do…— the Tyrant argued.

—I *do* understand. And that's why I'm trying to keep you from making a great mistake!— she insisted. —If you found a way to take that power, you'll just end up powerless… ironically. And…— she went on, daring to take her hands. —I don't want that to happen.

More power would make her powerless…

Yes, she had said that last time.

But… how could she know!?

What if this was all a farce!?

What if she was only pretending!?

What if she only wanted to keep Shadow Weaver from finally achieving her goal of being powerful enough to eradicate the Horde in one go!?

—No. You are just trying to sabotage me!— the Tyrant finally spat, angry, yanking her hands off. She then pulled her mask away violently, revealing pure rage. —Look at me in the eye and tell me you're not!

She looked into her eyes, but all Castaspella could see was pure madness.

The thought of potential power within her reach was driving her insane.

The sorceress felt a surge of sorrow invade her, and didn't hesitate to cup her face as she assured her —I am not. I'm doing this for your own good, to keep you from hurting yourself further.

—And why would you care about a monster's well-being!? Don't *lie* to me!

—I've *never* lied to you— Castaspella insisted, maintaining her calm tone. —I don't see you as a monster, just as a very troubled woman— she clarified. —And… I care for everyone, you know that. But this? I'm putting all this effort into convincing you because I care for you. This is solely *for you*— she concluded, leaning forward to kiss her.

Part of her feared the Tyrant would be too enraged, that she would push her away…

Yet she didn't.

Fortunately for Castaspella, the woman only calmed down as her fears vanished into thin air.

The sorceress' earnest expression had managed to convince her she was only being paranoid…

—I *will* go to one of those grooves regardless— Shadow Weaver declared, after breaking the kiss.

—Then let me go too.

—To stop me if I attempt to take the power for myself?— she asked, smirking teasingly.

—To keep an idiot from rendering herself powerless, to be precise— she replied, chuckling.

Rolling her eyes, the Tyrant finally gave in and, heading for the door, ordered —Get ready, then. I won't wait for you.

—Right.

—Oh, and the council has been eavesdropping— she added, fixing her mask back in place.

—Oh, yes, I supposed they would— Castaspella nodded, unamused.

Right after, Shadow Weaver opened the door and the councillors immediately straightened up, looking anywhere but at her, pretending they heard nothing.

The Tyrant only gestured at the sorceress to leave and the young sorceress walked away.

Immediately, the council followed her as she went to her room.

—What happened!?— Ekaterina asked, as soon as they were far enough from the council room.

—Nothing…

—Please. You must tell us— Daryon begged. —Did something happen to our Master?

—I said "nothing"— Castaspella insisted, finally reaching her room.

—We beg of you— Ayax pleaded, before she walked inside for a moment to retrieve something they couldn't see. —We need to know— they insisted, once she was out again.

Their looks were… unbearable.

—Ah… Alright— she finally sighed. Reluctantly, she asked —Have you all ever seen her face?

—After her corruption?— Kenno asked.

—Yes.

—Not me— he denied. —Only before, and she used a veil, so… Only part of it.

—Same for me— Ekaterina replied, seconded by Daryon.

—I have briefly seen it— Ayax admitted. —Once, I walked into the training ground and unexpectedly found her there. But that was years ago, I barely remember; only that she has some scars.

—Yes, I… once found her maskless in the gardens, but she quickly put it on— Anya told them.

—Well, the spell that corrupted her, the Spell of Obtainment, caused great damage to her. I mean, it's obviously the definition of "corruption" after all, but I suppose you can't realize the actual dimension of it if you haven't seen the scars it left.

—What do you mean?— Ekaterina inquired, worried.

—They are marks of dead tissue… the price she paid for her current powers— Castaspella explained.

—We heard you saying… she will be powerless if she takes more power— Daryon pointed out.

—Yes. The parasitic magic that corrupted her didn't take everything. But it will if she gets any more power than she naturally has. The next time, the price will be her sorcery— she concluded.

Looking between them, the sorceress saw only concern and worry. She had no idea they cared so much about her… but she *is* their Master, after all…

It was curious, but also a bit endearing.

—That's… a lot— Kenno sighed.

—I know. And that's why I won't let her find a greater source of power. I-I think she's already powerful enough— she assured them.

As soon as she said that, Shadow Weaver appeared behind the council, and they all dispersed, biding them farewell respectfully yet too ashamed to look at the Tyrant.

—Time to go— the woman sentenced, pretending she didn't hear anything.

Chapter End Notes

So!

Hehe, what do you think?

Next chapter is a beautiful one, really loved writing it! So I'm actually more excited about next week than this one lol
But like, this was important ofc, so I hope you liked it and now look forward to the next chapter hehe >^<

Also! I hope you enjoyed my little wink at canon XD

Alright, enough! See you next week!!

Chapter 12

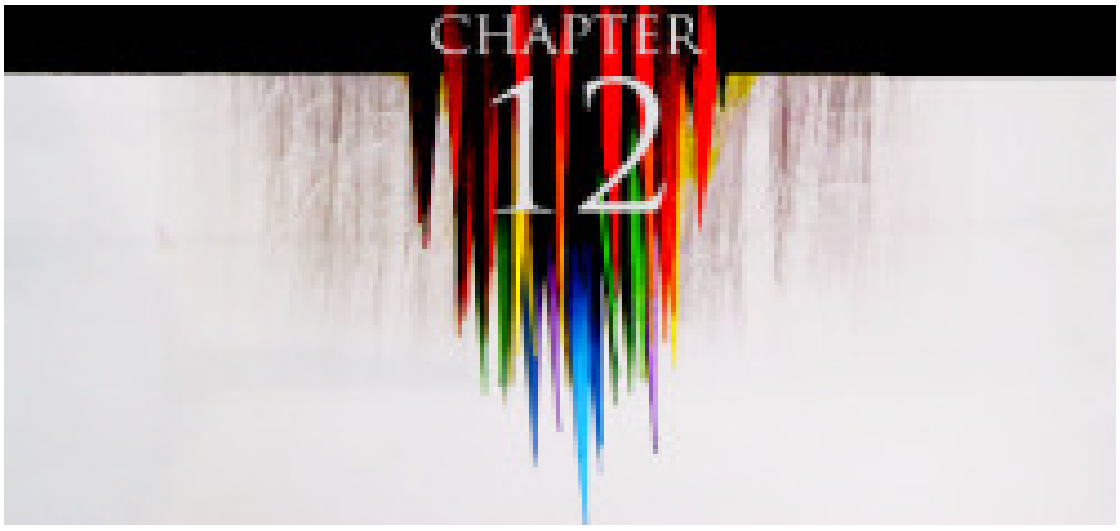
Chapter Summary

> "You're *addicted*, and… that means you'll always be looking for a way to gain more power" ~ Casta

Chapter Notes

> Hi, hi!
> Welcome back!!
>
> I'm so excited to finally post this chapter!! XD
> It has some visual images that I absolutely love, and the ending, oooh the ending, hehe
>
> I mean, we are like two chapters away from the end already!! :D
>
> So, well, I sure hope you enjoy this new chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



The sorceresses soon appeared in the Whispering Woods.

The sun was just setting yet it seemed like night had fallen already under the thick foliage.

It was a good thing, Shadow Weaver considered, since it meant they would be able to hide easily if they happened to come across anyone on their way to the groove…

—Alright. If I'm not mistaken, the one we scouted should be this way— Castaspella uttered, thinking aloud.

—What's with the book you brought?— the Tyrant curiously asked, following her.

She had been meaning to ask since before they left Mystacor, as it had surprised her that all she took from her room was that small red book.

—Oh, it's… just… a notebook I put together, actually— she hesitantly revealed. —I meant to record the creatures we found there from what I could remember, but since I'm going back now, I thought I could now use magic to better document everything— she explained, smiling cheerfully.

—Are those creatures *that* interesting?

—Very much!

Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes…

Not so much because she considered her cheerfulness silly, which she did, but rather because she found that silliness to be… endearing.

She *hated it* when something Castaspella did sparked such tender feelings.

So she decided not to say anything else, lest she regretted it.

After a short while, Shadow Weaver began feeling a tingling sensation little by little spreading through her body, increasing in intensity until it made her gasp.

—What's happening?— she asked, breathless.

—Calm down. Take a deep breath— the young sorceress promptly told her, making a pause. —We're almost there. The magical energy must already be affecting you— she explained. —I didn't expect it to happen until we arrived but… Right. You must be extra sensitive to it— she reflected.

—It hurts but, at the same time, feels… *invigorating*— the woman admitted, still shocked. —How did I never… feel this before!? I've been in these woods so many times…

—These grooves are… quite special— Castaspella began. —I'm taking you there following my intuition, for the most part, since the Woods are- Well, it's like this place has a mind of its own. It must have kept you away before.

—And why not now?

—Who knows…

The Tyrant took a few deep breaths before finally nodding and ordering —Let's go. I'm fine.

—Are you sure?

—Yes.

—Ah… alright— the sorceress sighed. —Through here.

Moving away a few vines and bushes, Castaspella stepped into a brightly illuminated clearing that overflowed with shiny sparks. As Shadow Weaver followed, the sight made her stop cold.

—What is this?

—Magic— the young sorceress smiled, turning around to face her, hands raised as she gestured around her. —Isn't it beautiful?

Still in shock, the woman carefully caught a spark with one hand, felt it seep into her skin, and hissed a bit.

—It *really* is raw magical energy— she finally sighed, taking off her mask.

—Yes. It's contained to this area somehow. I know there are other grooves, I haven't seen them, but… they are all like this, I reckon.

—So this is the true magic of Etheria— the Tyrant sighed, before letting out a low laugh, disbelieving. —To think I don't know the first thing about this…

—No one does.

—I've investigated Etheria's magic my whole life— she pointed out, snarling a bit. —You'd think I'd be aware of the existence of the magical grooves, at the very least.

—No need to get angry over this. You know now!

—Too late— she insisted, seething.

Castaspella couldn't help approaching her, concerned, and attempted to comfort her.

—Listen… Knowing about this earlier wouldn't have changed anything, alright? You… wouldn't be more powerful, the war wouldn't have ended, things would have been the same with the only difference that you'd be aware of these places existence— she explained.

—You can't know that.

—But we can't change things either— the sorceress insisted, looking away. —So why not think like that? What use is agonizing about this?

—Right… No use— the woman muttered, clenching her jaw.

—Come on, now. Look at the sleeping creatures— Castaspella invited her, carefully approaching what Shadow Weaver thought were a pair of large boulders. She halted about a

meter away and opened her notebook, explaining —If you look carefully, you can see them breathing.

—Those are…

Beasts!?

The sorceress began drawing a few sigils and quickly imprinted images in her notebook, filling the pages with outlines of the creatures, the roots and moss surrounding them, and the many plants that populated the groove.

—They look so peaceful…— she eventually sighed, closing the notebook. —I kind of envy them.

Her admission made Shadow Weaver chuckle unexpectedly, and she had to cover it with a cough, pretending nothing happened.

—Alright. I believe a proper investigation of this and any other groove we can find should be carried out soon— the Tyrant began, serious. —If anything, these places might teach us more about the magic of the Woods, and that can give us an advantage over the Horde.

—As long as you focus on understanding, then I'll help as much as I can— Castaspella promised.

—Still worried that I might take this power for myself?

—I… am— she admitted, looking away. —You should see the way you get when you so much as *think* about potential power to grab— the sorceress scoffed, indignant. —It's the look of a madman! Your whole body, your behaviours, everything! You're *addicted*, and… that means you'll always be looking for a way to gain more power— she sentenced. Then, looking away again and with a lower tone, she added —No matter what I do…

—If you know you can't do anything about it, why do you keep trying to stop me?— the Tyrant asked, smirking sardonically.

—The alternative is to just watch as you let it consume you…— Castaspella uttered, sorrowful. —I can't- I *don't want* to do nothing while you- while you…

—Alright, enough— Shadow Weaver interrupted her, approaching to place a hand on her shoulder. —Don't start panicking about something that hasn't happened.

—But it *may* happen— she pointed out, looking away.

—Or not— the dark sorceress corrected her, reaching for Castaspella's cheek to make her look back. —If you really mean it, if you really want to help me, don't get in my way. Advice me all you want, but don't try to control my actions; the more you forbid me, the more I'll want to do it— she pointed out, a bit cocky.

—And you'd listen to me?

—I'll make no promises, but I can assure you that your advice won't fall on deaf ears.

—Why does it feel like you're mocking me?

—For once, I am not… But if you want me to mock you…

—No! No, I'm alright— Castaspella interrupted, giggling. —Just… Well, it's so rare to hear you speak like that— she admitted, looking back at the Tyrant with a gentle smile.

The sorceress had been staring for a moment when she realized how utterly enraptured she probably looked.

Part of her felt so… stupid now.

Was she *falling* for the Tyrant!?

Suddenly ashamed, she was about to step back and look away, but Shadow Weaver caught her in a kiss for a moment before laughing sardonically against her lips.

—Do I have something entertaining in my face?

—N-no, no. I… Um, I was just thinking…

—About?

—A-about…

Well?

How could she fool the master of deception herself?

—Don't even try to lie…

—Alright— Castaspella sighed. —I wasn't really thinking about anything.

—I guessed as much.

—And what was the kiss for?

—Would you have preferred an alternative to bring you back to reality?

—No!

—So I thought— the Tyrant laughed, letting go of her and stepping back. —I suppose there isn't much more we can do here, so… time to return.

—Can I… stay here a bit longer?

—Haven't finished recording creatures?

—I did, but… It's a nice place, I want to enjoy it a bit now that there isn't a plant trying to eat me— she awkwardly admitted.

—I wouldn't recommend staying here alone.

—Is that your way of asking if you can keep me company?— Castaspella inquired, raising a brow.

—No. I mean it— the woman replied, deadpan, before putting her mask back on.

—Of course— she muttered, rolling her eyes. —I'll be alright alone, but…

—And if I refuse to let you stay here?

—You would- Why would you…

—Are you forgetting I'm a ruthless Tyrant who needn't explain the reasons behind my orders? — she interrupted her, standing tall with her hands joined behind her back looking menacing.

—As a matter of fact, yes, I *did* almost forget— Castaspella mocked her. —But, in all seriousness… I haven't had a chance to just… enjoy nature, in a really long time. I barely leave Mystacor, and…

—You can leave whenever you please; if you don't, that's on you— Shadow Weaver interrupted her once more. —But choosing here and now, of all places and times, is quite stupid.

—Why!?

—You may not have noticed, but this is disputed territory. Just being here is risky… Alone? That's a death-wish— she insisted, squinting.

—So you're worried about me?

The sorceress wasn't looking her way, yet the Tyrant felt ashamed of being seen so clearly.

No, no.

She couldn't allow her to realize there was any level of concern behind her insistence.

—You forget how much of a crucial asset you are.

—It's that it?

—Yes.

—You- But…

—Enough questioning. Do you need me to order you to return!?

—So now you'll play the Big Bad Tyrant to intimidate me into returning!?— Castaspella scoffed, folding her arms, seemingly offended.

—I don't need to "play" the Big Bad Beast. I *am* the Big Bad Beast in real life. If you finally leave those children's tales behind and join us in the real world, you'd realize as much— Shadow Weaver replied, towering over her and instilling as much malice into her words as possible.

Silence.

For a moment, Castaspella only held her sight, frowning angrily, stubbornly standing her ground.

However, she eventually swallowed hard, which tipped off her nervousness.

—You can be… so…

—What?

—Never mind…— the sorceress sighed, letting her arms fall to her sides and looking away. —You win. Let's go back.

It was around midnight when the women set foot on Mystacor again, and Castaspella immediately stalked away, leaving the Tyrant alone at the entrance.

Her first instinct was to follow the young sorceress, yet she refused to go back on her words or the intentions behind them.

But, why did she want to push her away now?

Same as always: she was getting *too* close. She could see it in her eyes.

However…

What if it was the wrong call this time?

No. No…

It couldn't be a good idea to let that woman come so close.

She didn't exactly seem like a threat, all the opposite. But… Shadow Weaver couldn't give her any more power over her!

The more Castaspella helped her, the more her influence grew; it was a bit of an issue since she *needed* that help, but despised the way she was influencing her.

The Tyrant looked up at the Moons of Enchantment, so close to aligning, and frowned.

It made her realize that, this month, it was close to being the seventeenth or eighteenth anniversary of her rule over Mystacor…

Close to two decades of finally showing Etheria what she's capable of, without Norwyn or *anyone* stopping her.

And yet, only the last couple of years had she been getting *some* recognition for it, at least from the people of Mystacor… *thanks to Castaspella*.

It was all, *always* thanks to her, lately.

That infuriated her even more.

She needed…

What did she need?

In short, she needed *her*.

But…

No, no. The reasons she needed Castaspella were *so* stupid!

She couldn't…

Well, in fact, she *could*! What stopped her but herself?

Ah… But after what she did…

After telling her the truth about it all being manipulation…

The fact that Castaspella revealed to have known since the beginning, and chose to stay regardless…

Curse her!

It was so… so…

Infuriating!

She couldn't allow it!

She couldn't let this happen…

No, no!

She was absolutely *not* in love!

She wouldn't ever be!

Much less with someone so… so… naïve and cheerful!

Shadow Weaver, the Tyrant of Mystacor, would *never* allow it…

…to be known.

Chapter End Notes

:D

Yes, my dears, it's finally happening!!

Again, two more chapters to go, but I promise good stuff >v<

Thank you very much for reading, everyone! I hope you liked this chapter!!
See you next week!!

Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

She was bleeding all over, unconscious, and most likely, on the brink of death.

Chapter Notes

As you can tell from the summary… This chapter will HURT!

I am sorry in advance for the angst <("^_^)
But, don't worry, it's a hurt/comfort chapter. You won't be left hanging XD

That was a terrible choice of words. You'll realize when you read this (/-\)

ANYWAYS!
I won't keep you any longer! Please enjoy the chapter :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes



For a few days, the Tyrant didn't request Castaspella's company at all.

In fact, every time the young sorceress went to her room to work on administrative matters, she would come up with an excuse to leave her alone there and return only after she was gone.

She simply couldn't… couldn't *stand* thinking about her now.

After what happened at the groove…

And it still maddened her how Castaspella insisted she couldn't take the power of that place… There had to be a way, and with how smart the young woman had proved to be, it was evident she'd need her help to find it…

But she refused to help!

And what was worse, she argued it was for her own good!

Why was she so… *caring*!?

However, the worst part wasn't Shadow Weaver's inner conflict.

No… That was pretty annoying, but not the worst.

The worst was how the council seemed to be… noticing something.

And that meant the underground council kept talking about it…

So, every time she tried to distract herself spying on them, she'd end up ignoring them after a short while…

Unfortunately for the Tyrant, it meant she was missing important information they discussed…

In this occasion, after Shadow Weaver dismissed her spies, the underground council's discussion took a turn…

—Now, we have something important to address— one of the fake acolytes, the tallest, said. —Namely, we believe there's a test of sorts we should carry out. And since you agree that the relationship between the Tyrant and your youngest member may be more than professional…

—Wait, wait— Daryon interrupted, raising a hand gesturing at them to stop. —Why test such theory? It is but an irrelevant conjecture we have— he argued.

—Ah, but hasn't your fellow councilwoman here admitted to have seen and heard them together?— the other fake acolyte reminded him, gesturing at Anya. —If the only missing detail is whether there are feelings involved or not, then allow us to carry out this test and we shall know for sure.

The other councillors side-eyed Anya, who shrunk nervously, but said nothing.

—I believe it's unnecessary. Confirming that shouldn't affect…

—It most certainly affects out little deal— the tallest fake acolyte rudely interrupted, mildly annoying Ayax. —As a matter of fact, it is now of great importance for us whether that sorceress feels something. And if she does, you better pray the Tyrant feels the same, or we

will have to take action. If she doesn't return her feelings, we can't continue with the five-year trial, even if it's close to ending.

—In fact…— the other one added. —Either we carry out this test or we'll consider you're not cooperative enough to hold our deal.

—Meaning we would start the riot this same day. You choose.

—What!? *Why*!?

—We have our reasons, which you will learn in due time.

—So, we insist: make a choice.

Now *that* was a problem for the council.

They all exchanged conflicted glances…

None of them wanted to allow it, but they could *not* let the riot happen.

With a sigh, Daryon finally looked back at the fake acolytes and severely said —We'll allow you to perform this test. But… don't touch a single hair of hers. Understood?

—Of course— the tall one nodded. —*We* will not lay a hand on her…

Once back from the lowest levels, the council gathered in an empty chamber to discuss Anya's untimely reveal.

—Why didn't you tell us!?— Ekaterina complained. —Saved it all for yourself?

—I-I wasn't- I didn't mean to… But…

—You thought it would upset us?— Kenno guessed.

—Yes…— she admitted, looking down.

—Like you, we're well aware we have no chance— Daryon sighed, shaking his head. —But it would have been better to discuss this before meeting those acolytes— he argued. —It played against us!

—My friend, I know it wasn't your intention, but hiding this from us wasn't the right call— Ayax told her, disappointed.

—I'm sorry— Anya sighed. —And I don't know why I told them… I-I panicked!

—They were certainly doubting Castaspella today— Kenno admitted. —It wasn't the best choice, revealing so much, but… It's alright.

—Now, what do you think their "test" implies?

—I'm unsure— Daryon told Ekaterina, thoughtful. —But they promised not to hurt her…

—However, they put quite some emphasis on how *they* wouldn't hurt her, so I'm mostly unnerved— Ayax admitted. —Perhaps we should keep an eye on them…

—They will notice us. It would likely backfire— Daryon pointed out.

—Then we can only wait— Kenno sighed.

—So we just- We'll resign ourselves and let them do whatever!?— Ekaterina complained.

—We have no choice now.

—But, Daryon…

—I *know*. But we can't risk making it worse by interfering.

—I hate this so much!

—Calm down, Ekaterina— Ayax told her. —Believe me, we feel the same. Yet we're in quite a tight spot right now.

—I know… I know.

The following day, it was early in the morning when the fake acolytes intercepted Castaspella on her way back from breakfast. She was supposed to head for the Tyrant's room to get started with paperwork, but… they were *convincing enough*.

—You have no idea what you're getting yourselves into— the sorceress warned them.

—We know very well— the tallest one said.

—Which is why you should take us seriously… councilwoman— the other one insisted, malicious. —You can try to go to your dear Tyrant and tell her about us, yes, but… by the time you reach her room, we will have exposed everything. You can be sure…

She couldn't allow that.

She didn't know what they could mean; what was there to expose about Shadow Weaver?

What could possibly worsen her image?

Ah… but after all the effort she and the council put into improving that image…

No, no.

Whatever they had on her, she simply couldn't let them reveal it.

—Fine. I will follow you— she reluctantly accepted, squinting at them. —But you better hold your end of the deal.

—We will, of course. Just come with us…

—Where are we going?

—You will soon see…

Muttering angrily, Castaspella walked after them for a while, followed the fake acolytes down to an eerie, empty floor, and it wasn't long before she recognized one of the forbidden corridors.

—Wait- No, no. We can't… go in there! Shadow Weaver has banned everyone from this place! It even has traps!

—We're aware.

—You- No…— the young sorceress uttered, realizing what they wanted to do.

—Yes.

—Why!?

—It is simple: you *love her*, don't you?— the tall one asked, smirking.

—I… Why-why are you asking this!?

—Haven't you realized yet? This is a *test*.

—Don't think we'll let you walk away without consequences…

—I am *not* stepping in there. I am *not* betraying her— Castaspella sentenced, taking a defensive stance, ready to cast a spell.

—You can't take on us both, councilwoman.

—You can't make me walk into the forbidden corridor…

—Alright— the tall fake acolyte smiled. —Don't do it.

—But of course, that means we shall expose her.

—You will not!

—What will you do about it? Your magic cannot stop us.

—You might be adept at defense magic, but what will that do against us?

—I…— Castaspella hesitated.

—Face it. Your only option, if you want to protect your Tyrant, is to walk in there as we command— the tall one insisted, getting more aggressive.

—What will you gain!?

The fake acolytes exchanged a glance, and the taller one nodded.

—We'll tell you: it's to test *her*.

—Ho-how!?

—We asked a question… And we wonder the same about her. If she feels anything for you, she will certainly free you from the trap and forgive your transgression.

—What makes you think she could possibly- Why does it matter to you whether she feels something for me!? Who-who are you!?

But they didn't answer this time.

—I think that's enough. Make your choice.

Castaspella hesitated for a moment. She was still ready to cast, but…

They were right.

She can't stop them alone.

She knows it.

—If I obey… You'll keep your promise and *not* expose her?

—You can be sure.

Conflicted, and feeling her eyes sting, the sorceress finally lowered her hands. She then took a deep shaky breath, resigned, and turned around to walk into the corridor.

Barely a few steps inside, a sudden surge of spikes sprout from all sides, piercing her body all around.

She didn't scream.

She couldn't.

Letting out a single gasp, eyes wide open, Castaspella stared at the distance as immeasurable pain invaded her.

What was this!?

—We shall ask one more time— the tall one began, shaking her awake from her clouded mind. —Do you love her?— they slowly asked.

—I don't know— she uttered.

—A simple yes or no, and we'll make sure this pain ends soon.

—You have chosen to walk into this trap. Did you do it for her?

—I…— she breathed out. —Yes…

—Because you love her.

Does she?

They were… probably right.

She had been trying to deny it all this time…

But…

—I… do— she faintly admitted, feeling about to pass out.

—Then you better hope she feels the same…

Would she?

Could she?

Back on the top floor, Shadow Weaver was sitting in front of her desk, once again trying to distract herself to avoid thinking about Castaspella.

Then an alarm spell was set off; a trap in a forbidden corridor had been triggered.

—Hmm… Someone was foolish enough?— she wondered aloud, considering whether she should check who the transgressor was. Or maybe just send some of her spies? —No one can survive those traps. What even is the rush? Besides… Castaspella is running late and I have to explain this to her…— she then realized after a while, before being interrupted by a knock on the door. As she went to open, she found a note on the floor. —Who…— she wondered, picking it up, confused and a bit curious. —*What*!?— she immediately exclaimed, upon reading it. —It can't be— she muttered. As anger suddenly overwhelmed her, she crushed the paper between her hands, grumbling between gritted teeth —No one would survive those traps!

But it was clear what the note implied.

"Are your secrets safe?"

She had to go to the forbidden corridor.

Now.

Back in the lowest levels of Mystacor, only the tallest fake acolyte gathered the underground council.

—The test is done— they announced. —But now, we shall test your Tyrant.

—Wait— Kenno interrupted. —So she- Castaspella *loves* her!?

—How will you test our Master?— Ekaterina inquired, worried.

—The test has already began, as a matter of fact— they clarified, with an unnerving smile. —We believe she's just using your fellow councillor… But, in any case, she must be on her way to the forbidden corridor.

—The *what*!?— Daryon exclaimed. —You swore not to hurt Castaspella!

—But you didn't do it yourselves…— Ayax realized. —I knew the way your phrased it was suspicious.

—Now, now. This had to be done. If we're right and the Tyrant is just using her, then she will be disposed of for her transgression… We don't need a puppet of hers hindering our plans, do we?

Ah… That put them in a tight spot again.

The council couldn't reveal their true intentions, but how could they allow this!?

—This is insane!— Daryon finally exclaimed. —Castaspella's been nothing but helpful to the kingdom! You claim to be doing this for Mystacor, but now do *this*!?

—This erases all the progress we've made!— Ekaterina joined him.

—We must go for her— Ayax told them.

—So you think your Master won't save her from the trap?

—That doesn't matter! We can't do nothing when we know what you've done to her!— Kenno insisted.

—Let's go now!— Anya nodded.

—This isn't over— Ekaterina told the fake acolyte, before all of them teleported directly to the entrance of the forbidden corridor.

Being left alone, the Horde spy grinned and took out a small communication device.

—Lord Hordak— they spoke. —The sorceress has been dealt with. And it won't take much longer to take down the Tyrant.

Shadow Weaver was fuming.

Who had dared defy her!?

Oh, the things she would do to them…

But first, she had to check the corridor itself.

If they had somehow sorted her traps, then there had to be some traces left, right?

Blinded by rage, she arrived at the corridor expecting something completely different from what she found.

Shocked, she remained frozen in place as she saw a figure between the spikes, hanging a few centimeters over the floor, unmoving.

Then who left that note?

Anger was replaced by confusion and a hint of fear, which only grew the more she stared at the figure.

It could not be.

She had to be… seeing things…

It had to be… someone similar…

Right!?

Yet her denial shattered as soon as she dismissed the spikes and the body fell.

And so it happened…

Her heart, always so cold, shrunk with dread when she saw her clearly.

—No!

The Tyrant wasn't thinking anymore. She immediately rushed forward, fell on her knees, and struggled to lift Castaspella onto her lap.

The young sorceress was bleeding all over, unconscious, and most likely, on the brink of death.

Why had she- If she *knew* these traps were here, why would she…

No, *no*!

This was her fault.

She didn't know what kind of traps these were.

She should have told her…

But why was she here!?

Perhaps she had gone after the actual transgressor!?

Ugh! What did it matter now!?

There was no time to dwell on that. *She had no time*.

But the pain, the anger, and powerlessness she was feeling completely overtook her for a moment and, holding the sorceress between her arms, the Tyrant let her rage out, yelling madly and allowing her power to pour out of her, enveloping the corridor in darkness.

She never saw the council arrive, and they couldn't see what was happening either. Yet they inferred it, for only Shadow Weaver's magic could cast such darkness, and they *knew* this was a display of rage.

The question of whether that rage was against the sorceress or not was soon answered when the Tyrant walked out of the obscure corridor carrying Castaspella and ordering Anya to follow her.

After a few hours tending to her wounds, the young sorceress was finally stable.

—Get out— Shadow Weaver ordered.

—Yes, Master— Anya replied, barely holding her tears.

She felt so guilty… So did the rest of the council…

But the woman didn't notice nor would she care.

Not now.

Once alone in her room, the Tyrant went to sit on the bed next to Castaspella and gently caressed her chin.

Only her face remained intact. Almost everything else had been covered by bandages.

Very slowly and noticeably weak, her eyes opened as she whined in pain.

She wasn't expecting the sorceress to wake up yet, but she did.

—Don't move— Shadow Weaver warned her. —You need to take this— she then said, reaching for a vial on her nightstand. Carefully, the Tyrant helped her drink up the potion to stave off the pain, and laid her back on the bed. —You still need rest.

—Sorry…— Castaspella muttered, her voice barely audible.

Oh no… She was apologizing already; that wasn't good.

—Ah…— the old woman sighed. —I planned on waiting a bit more before asking, but… why were you there?

—I… was…— she began, yet struggled to breathe for a moment and gasped for air.

—Slowly. Your lungs were pierced too… We barely managed to keep you alive. You don't have to speak if you can't.

—I have… to— Castaspella insisted. —It was… some-some aco-acolytes… The-they told me… they wou-would expose… you i-if I did-didn't follow… them.

—They took you to the forbidden corridor?

—I-I know you… cou-could have dealt… with them. Bu-but it… would be too-too late i-if I ca-came to find… you.

—You… walked into the trap… for *me*?

—I had to— she breathed out, her eyes half closed. —It wa-was… a test… fo-for me a-and you. I'm… sorry.

—Stop with the apologies— Shadow Weaver grunted. —You did *nothing* wrong.

And there was only one pair of "acolytes" who could have done this…

Perhaps it was time to finally deal with those damned spies.

Watching them scheme against her so hopelessly had been fun and kept Hordak under the illusion he had the upper hand…

But this!?

Those two… were *doomed*.

Chapter End Notes

I am so sorry TT-TT
I swear, I adore Casta, I don't know why I make her suffer so much…

And now you see why saying "you won't be left *hanging*" was a poor choice of words in this instance <("^_^)

In any case, you can see this was a very important chapter, and the culmination of this first arc is just around the corner! Next chapter will mark the end of this part, and I sure hope it will be up to your expectations! :D

I guess there's nothing more to say this time, so… Thank you very much for reading, and see you next week for the ending!! Bye!

Chapter 14

Chapter Summary

> "I'd say it's the beginning of a new era for the kingdom. So, trust me, Brother. I'll make sure things only get better from now on…" ~ Casta

Chapter Notes

> OMGS
>
> Screaming internally at the fact that this is the last chapter!!!! (Of this part, mind you)
>
> Anyways, I'll keep it short: THIS IS THE END -for now.
>
> Please enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes



—Listen now, all of you— the Tyrant began. From the shadows at the back of the room, her menacing look went through every old council member before finally settling on the pair of Horde spies posing as acolytes. —It's the end of the road. You've had your fun, but it's over now. As amusing as it was to watch you plan to raise Mystacor's people against me, you have crossed a line I cannot ignore— she sentenced. —Scheming against me was always futile. Whatever information you *think* you may have gathered for your Lord, you can be sure is only what *I* allowed you to get…— she went on. The spies, who remained impassive until that moment, finally let their neutral expressions fall. The tallest one clenched their jaw in

anger, while the other looked shocked. —However, yesterday you decided it would be… what? Interesting? Entertaining? To test me and my most efficient councillor?

—Call it what you want… We know what she is— one of the spies fearlessly said. —We thought you were using her, but she's *your weakness*, is she not?

—Now Lord Hordak knows— the other added, their tone malicious. —If your trap didn't kill her, he will make sure to target her from now on.

—Empty threats from a pair of weaklings… I'm almost tempted to delay your demise as much as possible— she mockingly said, approaching them slowly. —In fact, I should put you through that same trap. Leave you hanging there until you pass out and finally bleed out— she added, her voice like a growl while she placed a hand on each of their shoulders. Her nails suddenly dug into their skin, and they could feel something crawl up their legs. Something that burnt their skin as it reached higher and higher. —Unfortunately, I don't have the time…

With that, she let go of them right as her shadows arrived at their shoulders, barely giving them any time to scream before they invaded their mouths. The all-consuming dark magic finally enveloped them both, swallowed them into the void, and just like that, the spies were gone.

Just like Norwyn decades before.

—Ma-Master… We…

—*You*… will keep your mouths shut, Daryon— she interrupted. —In fact, you should be thankful that I saw your efforts to keep the riot from happening, or every single one of you would be gone like them for allowing those *pitiful* excuses of spies almost to kill your youngest member!— she reproached them. —Do you not care!? Or are you too jealous, too *envious* of her!?

—We're not! Master, listen to us!— Ekaterina pleaded. —We made them promise not to hurt her!

—And like the bunch of fools you are, you believed them…

—They tricked us!— Kenno argued. —If we didn't comply, they threatened to start the riot right-away!

—Enough of your excuses— she cut him. —I won't hear another word from you until the only sagacious councillor I have rejoins you! You are all dismissed until further notice, but you better handle the administrative duties Castaspella can't fulfill for the time being. Am I clear!?

Obediently silent, the councillors lowered their heads and nodded, not daring to look at her as they felt more ashamed than ever before. And after they left the room, a bit too shocked to speak, Daryon gestured at them to call their attention, and guided them to an empty room.

—What… have we *done*?— he finally breathed out, his sight unfocused.

—She always knew…— Ayax let out, reflecting. —She… was aware of it all… since the beginning.

—We messed up. We-we should have- Ho-how did we not realize those were Horde spies!? — Ekaterina exclaimed, increasingly anxious.

—And now she blames us for what happened to Castaspella… And how not? We *did* allow it…— Kenno lamented. —We've hit rock bottom…

—If she didn't hate us before, she surely does now— Anya sobbed. —What can we do!?

—At least you assisted her in saving Casta— Ekaterina reminded her. —But the rest of us!? We did *nothing*! And she knows it! She only spared us because we kept the riot from happening, but… Ugh! Why does it feel like that was the bare minimum!?

—Because it was…— Ayax sighed. —We should have reported those supposed acolytes from the beginning, and none of this would have happened…

—Alright. Enough— Daryon sighed too. —She's right. We're fools. We're not cunning like her, we can't come up with good plans and strategies like Casta either… All we know how to properly do is lower our heads and follow her orders. So… we can only keep doing that.

—Do you think… we can learn from Casta how to be more useful?— Anya shyly asked.

—Do you think she'll want to teach us!?— Ekaterina scoffed. —As soon as she learns we allowed those two to "test" her, she will…

—Before you say she will have our Master dispose of us…— Ayax interrupted. —Let me remind you she's always been quite nice and more than willing to help us— they pointed out. —If anything, yes, I believe Castaspella could assist us, teach us the skills we're missing, and perhaps even convince our Master to be more lenient…

Meanwhile, the Tyrant wasted no time after dismissing the council and went immediately to her room to check on the young sorceress.

—You're… back— she uttered, watching Shadow Weaver approach her. —Will you tell me… now what you went to do?

—Why do you care?

—I'm afraid you… did something stupid— Castaspella admitted, leaning against the woman as she sat on the bed next to her.

—Perhaps— she mischievously replied. —I just did what I had to.

—You killed those two?

—Yes…

—It is… something stupid, yes…

—They were spies from the Horde. I told you.

—You also said… the council knew them… What happened to them?

—I let them go. I still need someone to handle the paperwork while you recover— Shadow Weaver replied, knowing exactly how that sounded.

—Don't punish them… Please…

—Alright— she sighed. —I won't. They did their part, I suppose…

—And… that trap…

—I took it down— she interrupted. —There's not even any reason to keep it there.

—What… do you… mean?

—The reason that corridor, and practically half that floor, are forbidden, is because they are just… important places for me.

—Really?

—My old workshop is at the end of that corridor— she began. —Then there's my old room, and my old classroom…

—I see…— the young sorceress sighed, smiling a bit.

—But I'll remove all traps. There's… not really anything to hide there. I just didn't want anyone to go snooping around.

—What if… I want to… go see?

—Perhaps…

—Works for me— she smiled.

The Tyrant only let out a sigh and looked down at her in silence for a moment.

Holding Castaspella against her, and being in such a weakened state, she couldn't help reflecting on how this looked like.

—Who would have thought…

—What?

—Right now… I can only see myself as some… *monster* holding a small frail woman who might break if I'm not gentle enough…— she admitted, unexpectedly honest.

—I'm not… small? O-or frail? I'm hurt, a-and… I'm just a bit shorter than you!— Castaspella complained, in utter disbelief. —Oh, wait!— she faintly scoffed. —Really? Like… "The Monster and The Maiden"!? Di-didn't you tell me I… had to forget those children's… tales?

—I should have known you'd get the reference…— Shadow Weaver chuckled.

—It was my… favourite tale, actually…— Castaspella admitted, snuggling closer to her but hardly able to move without feeling excruciating pain. —Once… I even told Micah that I… wanted to be like the maiden.

—Really?

—He… said I was more like, uh… "The Fair Lady of The Tower"— she weakly laughed.

—"Of The Library", in your case— the Tyrant commented, smirking.

—True…— the young sorceress faintly snickered. —But… You know… The Fair Lady… she hadn't been locked there by her… brother… or for her pro-protection.

—And you shouldn't have to be hidden for your protection either…

—Wasn't I… safer there?

Was she?

It almost, *almost* pained Shadow Weaver to admit so.

—Yes…— she eventually sighed, before kissing Castaspella's forehead. It seemed to have surprised the young sorceress, which made her chuckle slightly and want to kiss her properly. However, Castaspella moved her face away before she could, her demeanor completely changed all of a sudden. —What happened?

—I'm… sorry. I-I can't… keep kissing you.

—What!?

—I can't… stand our affair anymore.

—*Why*!?— the Tyrant exclaimed, feeling a sudden surge of anxiety, only worsened by Castaspella's efforts to move away from her now.

—Be-because… I- The-the test… ugh… I… I just *know*… you'll hate me… but I love you— she stammered, rolling onto her side and facing away from Shadow Weaver.

—Hate you…— she breathlessly laughed. —*Of course* I hate you. I hate everything about that cursed personality of yours. Always cheerful, always positive and full of energy. I hate your smile, the way it reaches your eyes, those stupid locks of yours framing your face…— she began, speaking severely. —I hate how smart you are, how perceptive you can be when fully focused. I hate your dedication to keeping everyone safe, even *me*, despite it being so difficult most of the time. And I absolutely hate that you love me. *How would I not*!?

Castaspella could almost hear her heart breaking.

What did she expect?

She always knew she was an asset.

Shadow Weaver had only saved her life because she needed her, but only to fulfill her roles…

Right?

—If you hate me so much… If all you want from me is… sex and whatever help I can offer to-to make your… fight against the Horde be… successful…— Castaspella began, now interrupted by drowned sobs. —Then just say so. I can… return to my room… a-and we'll go back to… what we've been doing… a-as if I said nothing.

But the Tyrant only laughed sardonically.

—You didn't understand— she mockingly said, shaking her head. —Being so wounded must be taking a toll on your perceptiveness— the woman laughed, before reaching for her shoulder. Gently turning the sorceress to look her way, Shadow Weaver explained —I hate all those things from you, for the same reason that I hate that you love me… Because I hate love, you *know* that.

—Then what… did I not understand!?— she insisted, unable to hold back her tears anymore.

—You fool… What I mean… What I hate so much… is having to admit that I love you.

Castaspella's eyes opened wide upon hearing the confession, but before she could say anything, the Tyrant leant down to kiss her, and she immediately kissed her back, still crying.

—Why did you… have to be a bitch about this?— the young sorceress breathlessly laughed.

—I was under the impression you would understand…

—I told you… Whatever you think …you know about me, wrong un-unless I confirm it!— Castaspella reminded her.

—Right, right…— Shadow Weaver sighed, rolling her eyes. —Just tell me if this means we can continue our little affair…

—We… can— she accepted, smiling shyly. —But I… suppose you'll still… want it to be kind of… secret.

—For the time being. That would be for the best— the Tyrant admitted. —We're also keeping this incident as secret as possible.

—Please— Castaspella agreed. —If Micah learns… about this… He'll walk alone into the Fright… Zone to-to get back at that… Hordak.

—He would— Shadow Weaver smirked.

It took the young sorceress a few days and many sessions with healing spells to finally recover enough to speak without much difficulty, but she was fortunately improving.

Her body was still covered in bandages, which Shadow Weaver or Anya would carefully change periodically, and it was evident how much it seemed to affect her.

Castaspella tried to hide it, but the Tyrant could see how it darkened her mood every time she saw the scars.

—Can I ask you something?— she suddenly requested, after about five days.

—Go ahead…

—Can you take me to the Steam Grotto?

Shadow Weaver turned around from her desk to give her a questioning look.

—What?

—I would like to… see if the water's properties help with these scars— she sighed, a bit ashamed.

—Not such a fan of scars when they are yours, right?

—Don't mock me now…

—You said I was making a big deal of my scars… Now I get to mock you for that hypocrisy.

—Bitch…

—What was that? "You're right, Shadow Weaver"?

—Oh, fuck off! I'll just… go myself… So-somehow.

—Sure— the Tyrant snickered. —You'll hurt yourself if you try to go alone… So, give me a minute, and I'll take you there. But don't try to argue my scars aren't "that bad" ever again. Understood?

—Yeah, yeah…

Having given the order to empty the Steam Grotto and stay away for at least an hour, Shadow Weaver finally teleported there with Castaspella in arms.

The young sorceress felt rather ashamed of being carried around like that, but it was still quite difficult for her to move without the pain making her fall.

—Should I take off the bandages first?

—Yes, please— Castaspella nodded, while being set down on the edge of a pool.

Shadow Weaver crouched in front of her and carefully began unwrapping her legs, taking off the long bandage pieces and revealing several scars still far from healing fully, which perpetually marked the places where those spikes had pierced the sorceress' body.

The way she did it, however, the way she unwrapped the covered skin, it was almost reverential.

It was so strange for the Tyrant to be that careful, gentle, and serious when she had so many chances to mock Castaspella.

But no… She couldn't tease her about this…

—You can get your legs into the pool. I'll uncover your torso now— she said, looking up at the young woman. Her expression, however, was so flustered it made Shadow Weaver ask —What is it?

—So-sorry. Nothing, it's nothing…

—Then… are you getting in?— she asked, standing up now.

—Sure…

Feeling a bit awkward, Castaspella turned around, slowly raised her legs over the edge of the pool, and sank them into the steamy water with a hiss. The Tyrant stepped back and gave her a minute to get comfortable; once she nodded, she approached her again to take off the rest of the bandages.

—Is it helping?— she asked, halfway through unwrapping the sorceress' torso.

—It hurts less, yes…

—Good…— she nodded. Shadow Weaver sighed deeply, removed the rest of the gauze from around Castaspella's chest, and gently pushed her to sit down on the pool. —Let me unwrap your arms and I'll leave you to rest… You should submerge all the way to your neck.

—And If I want you to stay with me?

The sorceress' shy question took the Tyrant by surprise and she froze for a second.

—Why?

—Why not?

—You need to rest…

—And you tend to distract me? Is that what you mean?

—Precisely…

—Oh, come on— Castaspella insisted. —I will end up falling asleep if you just leave me here alone…

—That's the idea.

—But…

—No buts, Casta. I'll finish taking off these bandages and you will rest here. You should start with short sessions. I'll pick you up in twenty minutes, and put these on again— Shadow Weaver sentenced.

—And there's nothing I can do to convince you to stay?— the sorceress insisted, lowering her tone and giving her a mischievous look.

—No, you can't do anything— she replied, deadpan.

—Right… You never exactly react to my body…— Castaspella recalled, obviously offended.

—Before you start thinking I don't like you physically, which is a stupid conclusion after the past few years, let me clarify: I don't care about bodies, naked or otherwise. As you put it once… I may be attracted to intelligence… Or to useful and powerful things, if you may. But bodies? I couldn't care less…

The sorceress looked back at her, surprised.

She didn't expect that.

—Tha-thank you for the… clarification— she muttered. —I hadn't… noticed. And I didn't think you'd…

—Care about you feeling upset I don't find your body attractive? I wouldn't care, but it's more, *far more annoying* to have you mopping around than simply explaining this.

—Mean!

—Alright, I'm done— Shadow Weaver sighed, placing the last roll of bandages with the others she had been piling up by the edge of the pool. —I'll return soon. You rest. And *don't* try to leave on your own. Don't make me set shadow spies to guard you.

—I won't, I won't… It hurts a lot to move alone…

—Good.

—It is not!

The Tyrant only rolled her eyes and took a deep breath before finally walking away.

It turned out to be quite useful for Castaspella to bathe in the Grotto, and Shadow Weaver decided to arrange a certain time for the place to be exclusively hers for about two weeks. Initially, for short periods, and then gradually increasing the time until she could stay for two hours.

She helped her every time, took her there, unwrapped her bandages, *sometimes* remained there to keep her company, and then wrapped her again and took her back to the room.

By the end of the first week, Castaspella slowly began returning on her own feet, with some difficulty.

However, this was good enough. She was progressing and it wouldn't be that long before she could finally see her brother, as she had been promising for a while now.

After almost a month since the… incident, Castaspella felt recovered, could move without great difficulty, and only suffered if she had to strain herself too much.

So it was time to visit Micah.

—I am so sorry I couldn't come before…— Castaspella apologized, as soon as she arrived. —There was a lot of work to do after we caught some Horde spies planning a riot against Shadow Weaver; plenty of paperwork, as absurd as that sounds, and obviously, damage control.

—Spies… That's strange. One would think someone like that Tyrant would find them right away— Angella commented, arriving at the dining room with her husband and the sorceress.

—Oh, well… She knew for a long while, actually— she replied, deciding to tell half-truths. —The problem was… it got pretty serious, they became a real threat, so she finally decided to do something about them.

—Can't imagine what that "something" is— Micah muttered, looking away.

—Better don't…

—That's far from reassuring, Casta— the Queen pointed out.

—I am aware…

—Well, I was going to ask you, as it's been a few years, the same question I made on your twenty-first birthday, but… I doubt your answer has changed…— she reflected, right as the food arrived. —Alright, let's eat!

Castaspella did taste her meal right away. However, Angella's words resonated in her head and she couldn't help realizing her answer was quite different this time.

—As a matter of fact…— she began. —My answer *did* change.

—Really? You would recommend Glimmer went to Mystacor to study if she were of age?

—Well, that's going to take another four years, if my calculations are correct, so… taking that into account, along with the progress the council and I have been making, I can almost assure you it will be a better environment, enough to consider it a good idea— Castaspella smiled.

—You have a lot of faith— Micah sighed, looking a bit more pessimistic.

—I do, but I think it's deserved— she insisted.

—Well, she'll probably be happy to know that once she's back from visiting her friend— Angella let out, surprising her husband.

—Wait, what do you mean?

—Hasn't she told you how she wishes to turn twelve already so she can go to Mystacor to study and be able to fight the Horde?

—No…— the King uttered.

—She has only mentioned it a thousand times…— the Queen remarked. —At least tell me you *know* about her friend, Bow.

—I… think?

—My Love, you need to focus a bit more— Angella giggled.

—I haven't heard of this friend— Castaspella realized.

—He's a good boy, usually visits, and seems eager to join the Rebellion. He's still young and I heard his fathers don't like the idea, of course, but they don't want him to have to lie to them to do what he wishes.

—So… his fathers will let him fight!?— the sorceress asked, in utter disbelief.

—Not for now. And I gave my word not to allow it unless they agree. Which will only happen if Bow proves to be able to defend himself. Just like Glimmer won't either until her sorcery is good enough— she explained. —So he usually comes to train with several kinds of weapons. He hasn't found one comfortable enough, yet…

—It's insane that kids their age are practically dreaming about fighting in a war…— Castaspella lamented. —I know it's for the best that they know how to defend themselves, but… wanting to go to the battlefield is an entirely different thing.

—It's the world we live in, Casta— Micah said, shaking his head. —I don't like it either, but I can't be against them wanting to do something about it instead of observing from a distance… Especially because we don't know how long this will be. If I hadn't trained since I was a kid, I'd be useless to our cause— he pointed out. —But I've always wanted to do everything I could to fight the Horde, and if Glimmer is anything like me, I know nothing will stop her the more she grows.

—I see— Castaspella nodded, albeit resignedly. —Then it's a good thing she'll have the chance to train at Mystacor, no?

—I hope you're right— her brother let out.

—It's… I'd say it's the beginning of a new era for the kingdom. So, trust me, Brother— she confidently assured. —I'll make sure things only get better from now on…

Chapter End Notes

First thing I wanted to say: I have only scars from hot water burning me, so ofc such scars wouldn't be treated with hot water as is the Grotto's BUT, for slashing scars in the scarring stage Casta is in at that point in this chapter, hot water actually helps and reduces the pain, as I wrote (I looked it up very specifically)

So, yeah, I swear it's accurate (and the water is magical anyways lol)

Also, should have said it before, the love confession is similar to the one in *a certain other fic of mine* because in that fic I may have posted it first, but the original idea was to use it here so <("^_^)

And uh, well, I can't say much about what's to come… I don't wanna spoil or promise things that won't make it to the final stage <("^_^)
So, I'll just say, I REALLY hope you enjoyed this and return for *The Tyrant of Mystacor: Rise of A Queen*!!

See you around, and if you're subscribed to this fic, you'll get a notif for a 15th chapter announcing Part 2's posting!! (some time next year, probably around september… hopefully)

Now yes, this is goodbye for now!
Many many thanks for reading and accompanying me all this time! :D

Have a nice end of the year!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!